

MASTERING ENGLISH IDIOMS

A Comprehensive Professional Guide

Meanings • Usage Notes • Short Explanations

Real-Life Dialogue Conversations • Exercises & Review

Everyday Conversation • Work & Business • Feelings & Emotions

Success & Failure • Money & Spending • Time & Relationships

School & Learning • Food, Animals & Nature • American & British Variants

Written for Learners, Teachers & Professionals

Senior Idioms Reference Edition

HAMZAA ABDULLAHI

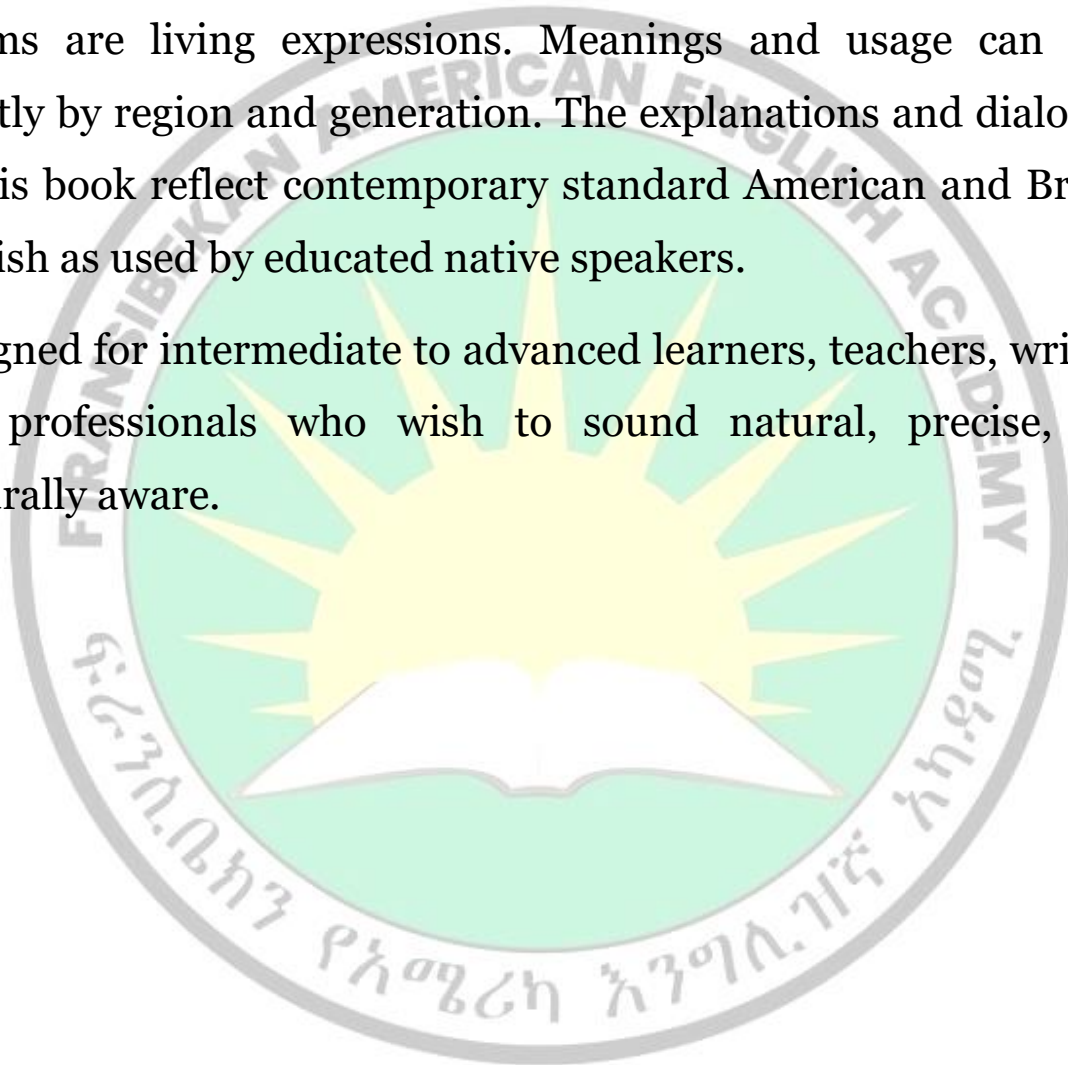
Fransibekan School of American English

Copyright © 2026. All rights reserved.

This professional reference work is intended for educational purposes. No part of this publication may be reproduced without permission, except for brief quotations in reviews or classroom use.

Idioms are living expressions. Meanings and usage can shift slightly by region and generation. The explanations and dialogues in this book reflect contemporary standard American and British English as used by educated native speakers.

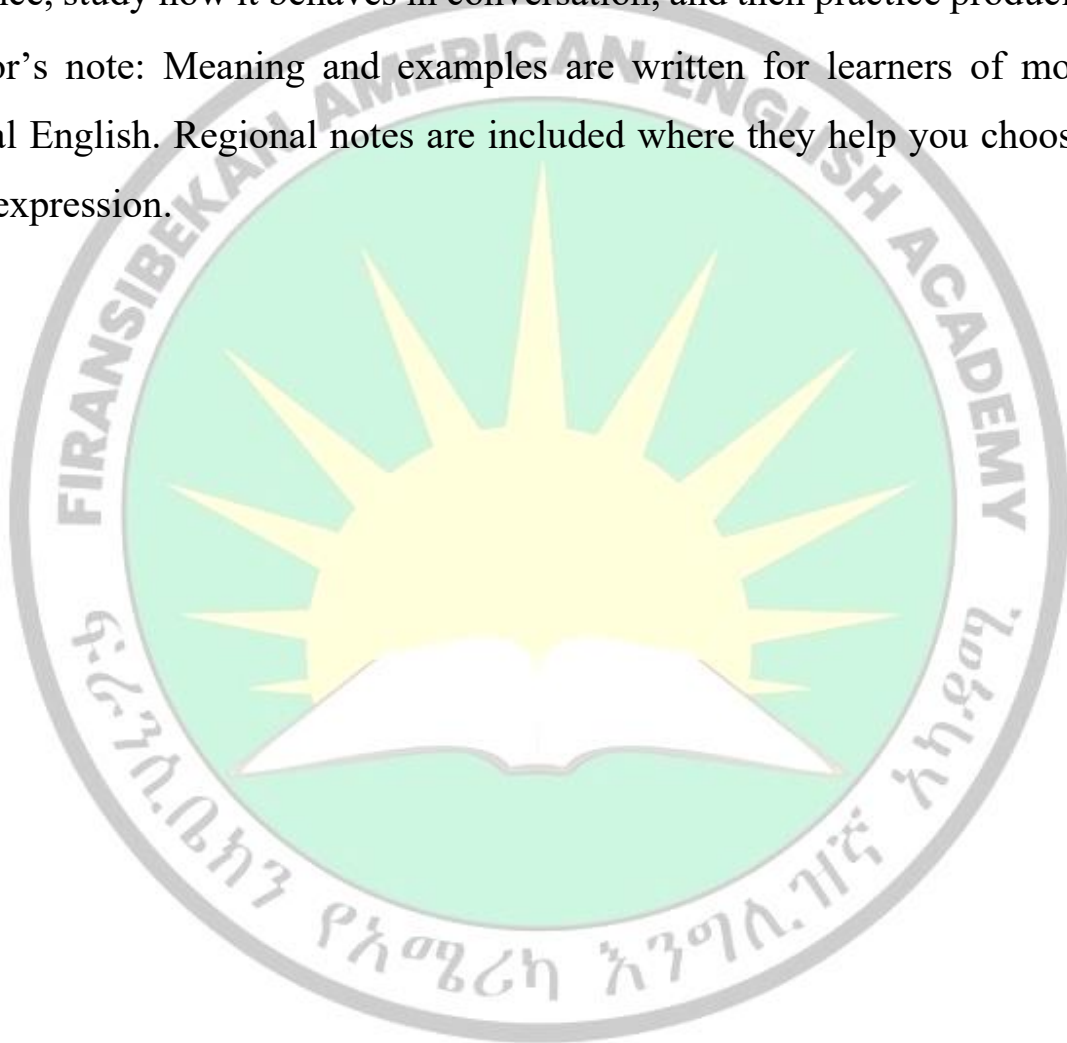
Designed for intermediate to advanced learners, teachers, writers, and professionals who wish to sound natural, precise, and culturally aware.



About This Book

Idioms are not ordinary vocabulary. Their meaning often cannot be guessed by translating each word. This book treats idioms as ready-made communication tools: learners meet the expression, understand its meaning, see it in a natural sentence, study how it behaves in conversation, and then practice producing it.

Author's note: Meaning and examples are written for learners of modern, natural English. Regional notes are included where they help you choose the right expression.



Acknowledgements

Every book carries a story behind its pages, and this one was made possible through the support, guidance, and encouragement of many wonderful people.

First and foremost, I would like to express my deepest gratitude to my teacher, **Mr. Ana's Jibril**, for his endless support, patience, guidance, and encouragement throughout this project. His passion for teaching and his dedication to helping students grow in confidence and master the English language have been a true inspiration. His wisdom and belief in his students gave me the motivation to keep learning, writing, and improving.

I am also sincerely grateful to **all the teachers at Fransibekan American English School**. Your commitment to excellence and your dedication to your students have helped shape the way I understand and appreciate the English language. Thank you for creating a supportive environment where learning feels meaningful and mistakes become opportunities to grow.

To every **student and English learner** who opens this book: **this book is for you**. I know that English idioms can sometimes feel confusing because their meanings are not always clear from the words themselves. My goal was to make these expressions simple, practical, and enjoyable to learn. I hope these pages help you understand everyday English, speak more naturally, and build greater confidence in your conversations.

You've got this, fam! Keep learning, keep practicing, and keep believing in yourself.

I would also like to thank **my family and friends** for their constant encouragement and support. Your kind words and belief in me kept me moving forward throughout this journey.

Finally, thank you to every learner who chooses to read, practice, and grow with this book. Your curiosity and determination inspire me. Remember: every new word you learn, every idiom you understand, and every conversation you practice brings you one step closer to fluency.

Never stop learning. Never be afraid of mistakes. And never stop believing in yourself.

With sincere gratitude,

HAMZAA ABDULLAHI

How to Use This Book

Welcome. This book is written as a practical working reference, not a dry dictionary. Every idiom is presented with the same clear structure so you can move quickly from recognition to confident use.

Read the idiom aloud. Study the meaning and short explanation. Read the example twice. Then read the real-life dialogue as a performance, not a vocabulary exercise. Notice who would naturally use the phrase, whether the tone is formal or informal, and what situation makes the idiom appropriate. Finally, create one sentence from your own life.

Author's note: Meaning and examples are written for learners of modern, natural English. Regional notes are included where they help you choose the right expression.

The Entry Format

Each idiom appears with five consistent elements:

1. Meaning – a plain, accurate definition.
2. Short Explanation – why the expression exists or how native speakers feel it.
3. Usage – register (formal/informal), regional notes, and typical contexts.
4. Examples – short, natural sentences.
5. Real-Life Dialogue – a multi-turn conversation that shows the idiom in a believable setting.

Study Tips

Read the dialogue aloud. Notice the surrounding language, not only the idiom. Try rewriting one line of each dialogue with a different idiom from the same chapter. Keep a personal notebook of three new expressions each week and force yourself to use them in real conversations or writing.

American and British variants are noted where they differ significantly. Many idioms travel freely between the two varieties; a few remain strongly regional.

Chapter 10 contains exercises designed for self-study or classroom use. An answer key appears at the end of that chapter.

What “Usage” Means

The usage line tells you when the idiom sounds natural, who commonly uses it, and what register it belongs to. Some expressions are universal everyday English; others are informal, business-oriented, regional, humorous, or more common in American or British English. Good idiom use depends on context, not on quantity.

Author’s note: Meaning and examples are written for learners of modern, natural English. Regional notes are included where they help you choose the right expression.

Conversation Method

For each dialogue, underline the idiom. Read both speakers aloud. Change the names and details. Then replace one part of the dialogue with a true detail from your life. Repeat the conversation without looking at the book. This turns passive recognition into active speaking ability.

Author’s note: Meaning and examples are written for learners of modern, natural English. Regional notes are included where they help you choose the right expression.

Memory Method

Create a three-step memory link: picture the literal image; connect that image to the figurative meaning; attach the idiom to a personal situation. For example, picture a ball on a tennis court, then remember “the ball is in your court,” then connect it to a time when responsibility shifted to you.

Author’s note: Meaning and examples are written for learners of modern, natural English. Regional notes are included where they help you choose the right expression.

Mastery Checklist

You have mastered an idiom when you can recognize it in conversation, explain it simply, choose a natural context, produce an original sentence, and use it without stopping to translate. The review pages at the end of the book are designed to test all five abilities.

Author’s note: Meaning and examples are written for learners of modern, natural English. Regional notes are included where they help you choose the right expression.

Table of Contents

About This Book.....	II
Acknowledgements.....	III
How to Use This Book.....	IV
The Entry Format.....	IV
Study Tips.....	IV
CHAPTER 1.....	1
Everyday Conversation Idioms.....	1
How to Study This Chapter	1
Chapter Review	14
CHAPTER 2.....	15
Life Idioms.....	15
IDIOMS RELATED TO LIFE.....	17
Additional Life Expressions.....	20
CHAPTER 3.....	24
FAMILY IDIOMS.....	24
How to Study This Chapter	24
IDIOMS EXPRESSION RELATED TO FAMILY.....	38
Chapter Review	41
CHAPTER 4.....	42
Work & Business Idioms.....	42
CHAPTER 5.....	51
Feelings & Emotions.....	51
IDIOMS EXPRESSIONS RELATED TO EMOTIONS.....	55
CHAPTER 6.....	59
Success & Failure.....	59
CHAPTER 7.....	67
Money & Spending.....	67
<i>Real-Life Dialogues</i>	70
CHAPTER 8.....	76
FOOD IDIOMS.....	76
How to Study This Chapter	76
Chapter Review.....	87
CHAPTER 9.....	88
RELATIONSHIPS IDIOMS.....	88
How to Study This Chapter	88

IDIOMS RELATED TO RELATIONSHIPS	92
<i>Real-Life Dialogue</i>	96
CHAPTER 10.....	100
TIME IDIOMS	100
IDIOMS EXPRESSIONS RELATED TO TIME.....	107
<i>Real-Life Dialogue</i>	110
Chapter Review	114
CHAPTER 11	115
School & Learning.....	115
Real-Life Dialogue.....	117
CHAPTER 12.....	123
Food, Animals & Nature Idioms	123
Real-Life Dialogue:	126
CHAPTER 13.....	129
Animal Idioms	129
IDIOMS EXPRESSIONS RELATED TO ANIMALS	133
Additional Animal Expressions.....	134
CHAPTER 14.....	135
Environment Idioms.....	135
IDIOMS EXPRESSIONS RELATED TO ENVIRONMENT	137
Environment Idioms Dialogue.....	140
CHAPTER 15.....	142
IDIOMS RELATED TO NATURE.....	142
IDIOMS EXPRESSIONS RELATED TO NATURE.....	142
<i>Real-Life Dialogue</i>	145
CHAPTER 16.....	146
IDIOMS RELATED TO SEA	146
IDIOMS EXPRESSIONS RELATED TO SEA	146
<i>Real-Life Dialogue</i>	149
CHAPTER 17	150
Idioms and Expressions Related to Weather	150
IDIOMS EXPRESSIONS RELATED TO WEATHER	150
CHAPTER 18.....	153
Common American & British Idioms	153
Shared Favorites (Used Widely in Both Varieties)	153
More Commonly American	153

More Commonly British.....	154
CHAPTER 19.....	156
Idiom Exercises & Review.....	156
Final Note from the Author	158
REFERENCES	159



CHAPTER 1

Everyday Conversation Idioms

These are the expressions you will hear most often in casual talk among friends, family, colleagues, and strangers. Mastering them makes your spoken English sound natural and confident rather than textbook-like.

These are the idioms you hear every day in offices, cafés, group chats and casual conversation. They are modern, high-frequency, and essential for sounding natural in spoken English. Mastering them will make your everyday interactions smoother and more fluent.

How to Study This Chapter

Read each entry carefully. Notice the register and tone. Read the dialogue aloud. Then choose five idioms and deliberately use them in real conversations this week.

Break the ice

Meaning: To do or say something that makes people feel more relaxed and comfortable in a social situation, especially when meeting for the first time.

Short Explanation: Imagine a frozen surface that must be broken before anyone can move freely. The first joke, question, or shared activity 'breaks' the social stiffness.

Usage: Very common in both American and British English. Suitable for parties, meetings, classrooms, and networking events. Neutral to informal.

Examples:

- *The host told a funny story to break the ice.*
- *A short game is a great way to break the ice on the first day of class.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Maya: *I always get nervous at these networking events.*

Jordan: *Me too. Want to go over and break the ice with that group by the window?*

Maya: *How?*

Jordan: *Just ask them what they think of the keynote. People love talking about that.*

Maya: *Okay... here we go.*

Jordan: *(a few minutes later) See? They're smiling. You broke the ice perfectly.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Host: *Everyone looks a bit awkward.*

Friend: *I'll break the ice with a quick game.*

Hit the nail on the head

Meaning: To describe exactly what is true or correct about a situation; to be precisely right.

Short Explanation: From carpentry: striking the nail squarely drives it in cleanly. Figuratively, your comment lands perfectly on the truth.

Usage: Common in conversation and light professional discussion. Neutral register. Used in both US and UK English.

Examples:

- *You hit the nail on the head when you said the real problem is communication.*
- *Her analysis hit the nail on the head.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Alex: *I think the campaign failed because we never really understood the audience.*

Sam: *Exactly. You just hit the nail on the head. We spent all our energy on clever slogans instead of listening.*

Alex: *So next time we start with research?*

Sam: *Yes. That insight changes everything.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Colleague: *I think the delay is mainly because of unclear priorities.*

Manager: *You've hit the nail on the head.*

A piece of cake

Meaning: Something that is very easy to do.

Short Explanation: Cake is soft and pleasant; the expression treats the task as equally effortless and enjoyable.

Usage: Informal. Extremely common in everyday American and British speech. Avoid in very formal writing.

Examples:

- *The driving test was a piece of cake.*
- *Don't worry about the presentation – it'll be a piece of cake once you practice.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Lina: *Are you ready for the interview tomorrow?*

Tom: *Honestly, after all the mock interviews we've done, it feels like a piece of cake.*

Lina: *That's the confidence I want to hear.*

Tom: *As long as they don't ask me to code on a whiteboard with no internet, I'm good.*

Under the weather

Meaning: Feeling slightly ill or unwell.

Short Explanation: Old nautical language: sailors felt sick when the weather was bad or when they were below deck in rough seas.

Usage: Very common, polite, and mild. Suitable for workplace and casual contexts. Both US and UK.

Examples:

- *I'm a bit under the weather today, so I'm working from home.*
- *She looked under the weather after the long flight.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Manager: *You don't look yourself this morning.*

Employee: *I'm feeling a bit under the weather. Nothing serious – just a head cold.*

Manager: *Take it easy. If you need to leave early, just let me know.*

Employee: *Thanks. I'll push through the morning meetings and then reassess.*

Let the cat out of the bag

Meaning: To reveal a secret, usually by accident.

Short Explanation: Historically linked to market fraud: a cat was sometimes substituted for a piglet in a bag; opening the bag exposed the trick.

Usage: Informal to neutral. Widely used in both varieties of English.

Examples:

- *Please don't let the cat out of the bag about the surprise party.*
- *He accidentally let the cat out of the bag during the meeting.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Priya: *We're planning a surprise dinner for Dad's birthday.*

Ravi: *I almost let the cat out of the bag yesterday when I asked him if he liked Italian food.*

Priya: *Ravi!*

Ravi: *I caught myself just in time. He still has no idea.*

Once in a blue moon

Meaning: Very rarely; almost never.

Short Explanation: A 'blue moon' is the second full moon in a calendar month – an uncommon event. The idiom exaggerates rarity.

Usage: Informal, colorful, and common in conversation on both sides of the Atlantic.

Examples:

- *I only eat fast food once in a blue moon.*
- *We see each other once in a blue moon these days.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Sarah: *Do you still play tennis?*

Mark: *Once in a blue moon. Work has taken over.*

Sarah: *We should fix a date. Even if it's rare, it's worth it.*

Mark: *You're right. Let's not wait for the next blue moon.*

Speak of the devil

Meaning: Said when the person you have just been talking about appears.

Short Explanation: From the older proverb 'Speak of the devil and he shall appear.' Now used lightly, without any supernatural meaning.

Usage: Very common in casual conversation. Friendly and slightly humorous. Both US and UK.

Examples:

- *Speak of the devil – here comes Emma now.*
- *We were just talking about you. Speak of the devil!*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Nina: *I wonder if Carlos is coming to the lunch.*

Omar: *He said he might be late.*

Nina: *Speak of the devil – look who just walked in.*

Carlos: *Sorry I'm late. Did someone mention my name?*

Beat around the bush

Meaning: To avoid talking directly about the main point, often because it is uncomfortable.

Short Explanation: From hunting: beating bushes to flush out animals without going straight at them. Figuratively, circling the topic instead of addressing it.

Usage: Common in both professional and personal talk. Slightly critical tone. Neutral register.

Examples:

- *Stop beating around the bush and tell me what happened.*
- *He spent ten minutes beating around the bush before admitting the mistake.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Boss: *Is there something you need to tell me about the budget?*

Analyst: *Well, the figures are a bit... complex this quarter...*

Boss: *Please don't beat around the bush. Just give me the bottom line.*

Analyst: *We overspent by twelve percent. I'm sorry.*

Cost an arm and a leg

Meaning: To be extremely expensive.

Short Explanation: Hyperbolic: losing limbs is a high price. Emphasizes that the cost feels painfully high.

Usage: Informal. Extremely frequent in everyday speech. Both American and British.

Examples:

- *That designer bag cost an arm and a leg.*
- *Repairing the roof is going to cost an arm and a leg.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Jess: *Did you see the new phone?*

Chris: *Yeah, but it costs an arm and a leg. I'm sticking with my old one for another year.*

Jess: *Smart. The features aren't that revolutionary anyway.*

Call it a day

Meaning: To stop working on something; to decide that enough has been done for now.

Short Explanation: Literally deciding that the working day is finished. Extended to any activity that has reached a sensible stopping point.

Usage: Very common at the end of work sessions, meetings, or long tasks. Neutral to informal.

Examples:

- *We've fixed the main bugs. Let's call it a day.*
- *After six hours of hiking we decided to call it a day.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Team lead: *The presentation is solid. Any last changes?*

Designer: *Just minor color tweaks.*

Team lead: *They can wait until morning. Let's call it a day – you've all earned the rest.*

Get the ball rolling

Meaning: To start an activity or process; to take the first step that allows others to continue.

Short Explanation: From sports: once the ball is in motion, the game can proceed. Used for projects, conversations, and meetings.

Usage: Common in both casual and professional settings. Neutral register.

Examples:

- *I'll get the ball rolling with a short introduction.*
- *Someone needs to get the ball rolling on the fundraising campaign.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Chair: *We have a lot to cover. Who wants to get the ball rolling on the first agenda item?*

Maria: *I can start. I've prepared a two-minute summary of last quarter's results.*

On the same page

Meaning: In agreement; sharing the same understanding or information.

Short Explanation: From reading the same page of a document so everyone has identical information. Extended to shared understanding.

Usage: Extremely common in business and teamwork. Neutral. Both US and UK.

Examples:

- *Before we vote, let's make sure we're all on the same page.*
- *I thought we were on the same page about the deadline.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Project manager: *The client changed the requirements yesterday.*

Developer: *I didn't hear about that.*

Project manager: *That's why I called this quick sync – we need to be on the same page before the next sprint.*

Bite the bullet

Meaning: To face a difficult or unpleasant situation with courage because it cannot be avoided.

Short Explanation: From the days before modern anesthesia, soldiers bit on a bullet during surgery to endure the pain.

Usage: Common and slightly dramatic. Suitable for personal and professional contexts. Neutral.

Examples:

- *I finally bit the bullet and asked for a raise.*
- *We'll have to bite the bullet and tell the team about the delays.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Friend A: *Have you told your landlord you're moving out?*

Friend B: *Not yet. I've been putting it off.*

Friend A: *Just bite the bullet. The longer you wait, the more awkward it gets.*

Friend B: *You're right. I'll call this afternoon.*

The best of both worlds

Meaning: A situation in which you can enjoy the advantages of two different things at the same time.

Short Explanation: Literally having the good parts of two separate worlds without the drawbacks of either.

Usage: Positive, common in conversation and marketing. Neutral register.

Examples:

- *Working remotely gives me the best of both worlds – career progress and time with family.*
- *This hybrid car offers the best of both worlds: efficiency and power.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Colleague: *How's the new hybrid schedule?*

You: *Honestly, it's the best of both worlds. Three days in the office for collaboration, two at home for deep work.*

Cut to the chase

Meaning: To get to the main point without wasting time on unnecessary details.

Short Explanation: From early film editing: 'chase' scenes were the exciting parts; directors were told to cut straight to them.

Usage: Slightly informal, efficient tone. Common in meetings and conversations when time is short.

Examples:

- *I know we're short on time, so let me cut to the chase.*
- *Can you cut to the chase? What's the actual problem?*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Client: *We've reviewed the proposal thoroughly...*

Account manager: *I appreciate that. To cut to the chase – are you ready to move forward, or do you need changes?*

It's not rocket science

Meaning: It is not difficult to understand or do.

Short Explanation: Rocket science is considered extremely complex. Saying something is not rocket science means it is simple.

Usage: Very common informal dismissal of difficulty. Both American and British English.

Examples:

- *Come on, it's not rocket science – just follow the steps.*
- *Cooking pasta isn't rocket science.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Friend: *I still can't set up the Wi-Fi.*

You: *It's not rocket science. Just follow the instructions on the box.*

Get the hang of it

Meaning: To learn how to do something; to become comfortable with a skill or process.

Short Explanation: 'Hang' suggests the natural way something moves or works.

Usage: Very common for learning. Informal and encouraging.

Examples:

- *You'll get the hang of it after a few tries.*
- *It took me a week to get the hang of the new software.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Colleague: *This keyboard shortcut is confusing.*

You: *Keep practising. You'll get the hang of it.*

Up in the air

Meaning: Uncertain or undecided; not yet settled.

Short Explanation: Things that are up in the air have not landed yet.

Usage: Common for plans and decisions. Neutral.

Examples:

- *Our holiday plans are still up in the air.*
- *The final budget is up in the air until next week.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Friend: *Have you booked the flights?*

You: *Not yet. Everything is still up in the air.*

On the same page

Meaning: To understand and agree with the same information or plan.

Short Explanation: Reading from the same page means sharing the same text and interpretation.

Usage: Extremely common in modern professional and team talk. Neutral.

Examples:

- *Let's make sure we're all on the same page before we start.*
- *I just want to confirm we're on the same page about the deadline.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Manager: *Does everyone understand the new process?*

Team lead: *Yes — we're all on the same page.*

Cut to the chase

Meaning: To go directly to the important part; to skip unnecessary details.

Short Explanation: From early film: 'chase' scenes were the exciting part. Directors would say cut to the chase.

Usage: Informal. Common when time is short or patience is limited.

Examples:

- *I'm busy — can you cut to the chase?*
- *Let me cut to the chase: we need a decision today.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Colleague: *There are several background factors...*

You: *Could you cut to the chase? What's the recommendation?*

No pain, no gain

Meaning: You must work hard or suffer a little to achieve something valuable.

Short Explanation: Without effort (pain) there is no progress (gain).

Usage: Common motivational saying. Informal.

Examples:

- *Learning a language takes effort — no pain, no gain.*
- *The training is tough, but no pain, no gain.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Friend: *This workout is killing me.*

You: *No pain, no gain. You'll feel stronger next week.*

Keep me posted

Meaning: Continue to give me updates or information.

Short Explanation: 'Posted' once meant informed by post (mail). Now it simply means kept informed.

Usage: Very common in modern conversation and messaging. Neutral.

Examples:

- *Keep me posted on the results.*
- *I'll keep you posted as soon as I hear anything.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Colleague: *I'm waiting for the client's reply.*

You: *Okay. Keep me posted.*

It's a no-brainer

Meaning: An obvious or very easy decision; something that requires little thought.

Short Explanation: The decision is so clear that the brain is not heavily engaged.

Usage: Informal and modern. Extremely common.

Examples:

- *Accepting that offer is a no-brainer.*
- *For me it's a no-brainer — we should go with the cheaper option.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Friend: *Should I take the higher-paid job with the longer commute?*

You: *That's a no-brainer for you. You hate commuting.*

Touch base

Meaning: To make brief contact with someone to update them or check progress.

Short Explanation: From baseball: a runner must touch a base. Figuratively, a quick check-in.

Usage: Extremely common in modern business and casual professional talk. Slightly informal.

Examples:

- *I'll touch base with you later this week.*
- *Let's touch base after the client call.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Manager: *How's the vendor negotiation?*

Buyer: *Still in progress. I'll touch base as soon as I have a final number.*

That's a wrap

Meaning: Something is finished; the work or event is complete.

Short Explanation: From film production: 'That's a wrap' signals the end of filming for the day.

Usage: Informal and modern. Common at the end of meetings or projects.

Examples:

- *That's a wrap for today.*
- *The conference is over — that's a wrap.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Director: *Any last questions?*

Team: *No.*

Director: *That's a wrap. Great work everyone.*

Ballpark figure / Ballpark estimate

Meaning: An approximate number; a rough estimate.

Short Explanation: From baseball: a figure that is 'in the ballpark' is close enough.

Usage: Very common in business and casual planning. Neutral.

Examples:

- *Can you give me a ballpark figure for the cost?*
- *We're looking at a ballpark estimate of around \$5,000.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Client: *How much will the whole project cost?*

Consultant: *Ballpark figure? Somewhere between eight and ten thousand.*

Get the ball rolling

Meaning: To start something; to begin a process or activity.

Short Explanation: Once the ball is rolling, momentum continues. The first push is important.

Usage: Common for starting projects or conversations. Neutral.

Examples:

- *Let's get the ball rolling with a short brainstorm.*
- *Who wants to get the ball rolling?*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Facilitator: *We have ninety minutes.*

Team member: *I'll get the ball rolling with the first idea.*

In a nutshell

Meaning: In a few words; summarized briefly.

Short Explanation: The important content fits inside a small nutshell.

Usage: Extremely common when summarizing. Neutral.

Examples:

- *In a nutshell, we need more time and more people.*
- *Can you explain it in a nutshell?*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Boss: *What's the situation?*

Analyst: *In a nutshell: the numbers look good, but the timeline is tight.*

Call it a day

Meaning: To stop working on something; to decide enough has been done for now.

Short Explanation: Literally deciding that the working day is finished.

Usage: Very common at the end of work sessions. Neutral to informal.

Examples:

- *We've fixed the main bugs. Let's call it a day.*
- *After six hours we decided to call it a day.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Lead: *The presentation is solid. Any last changes?*

Designer: *Just minor tweaks.*

Lead: *They can wait. Let's call it a day.*

Jump on the bandwagon

Meaning: To join a popular activity or trend that is already successful.

Short Explanation: From political parades that used bandwagons. People climbed on to show support.

Usage: Can be neutral or slightly critical of trend-following.

Examples:

- *Many companies are jumping on the AI bandwagon.*
- *I don't want to jump on the bandwagon just because it's popular.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Colleague: *Everyone is using that new app.*

You: *I'm not jumping on the bandwagon until I see real results.*

Keep your fingers crossed

Meaning: To hope for good luck or a positive outcome.

Short Explanation: Crossing fingers is a traditional gesture of hope or protection.

Usage: Common and light. Informal.

Examples:

- *Keep your fingers crossed for me — the interview is tomorrow.*
- *We're keeping our fingers crossed that the weather stays good.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Friend: *Results come out Friday.*

You: *I'll keep my fingers crossed for you.*

It's up in the air / Still up in the air

Meaning: Not yet decided or settled.

Short Explanation: Things that have not landed are still uncertain.

Usage: Very common for undecided plans. Neutral.

Examples:

- *The venue is still up in the air.*
- *Everything is up in the air until we get the final budget.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Partner: *Have we confirmed the date?*

You: *Not yet. It's still up in the air.*

You can say that again

Meaning: I strongly agree with what you just said.

Short Explanation: A way of emphasising agreement by inviting the person to repeat the statement.

Usage: Informal and friendly. Extremely common in spoken English.

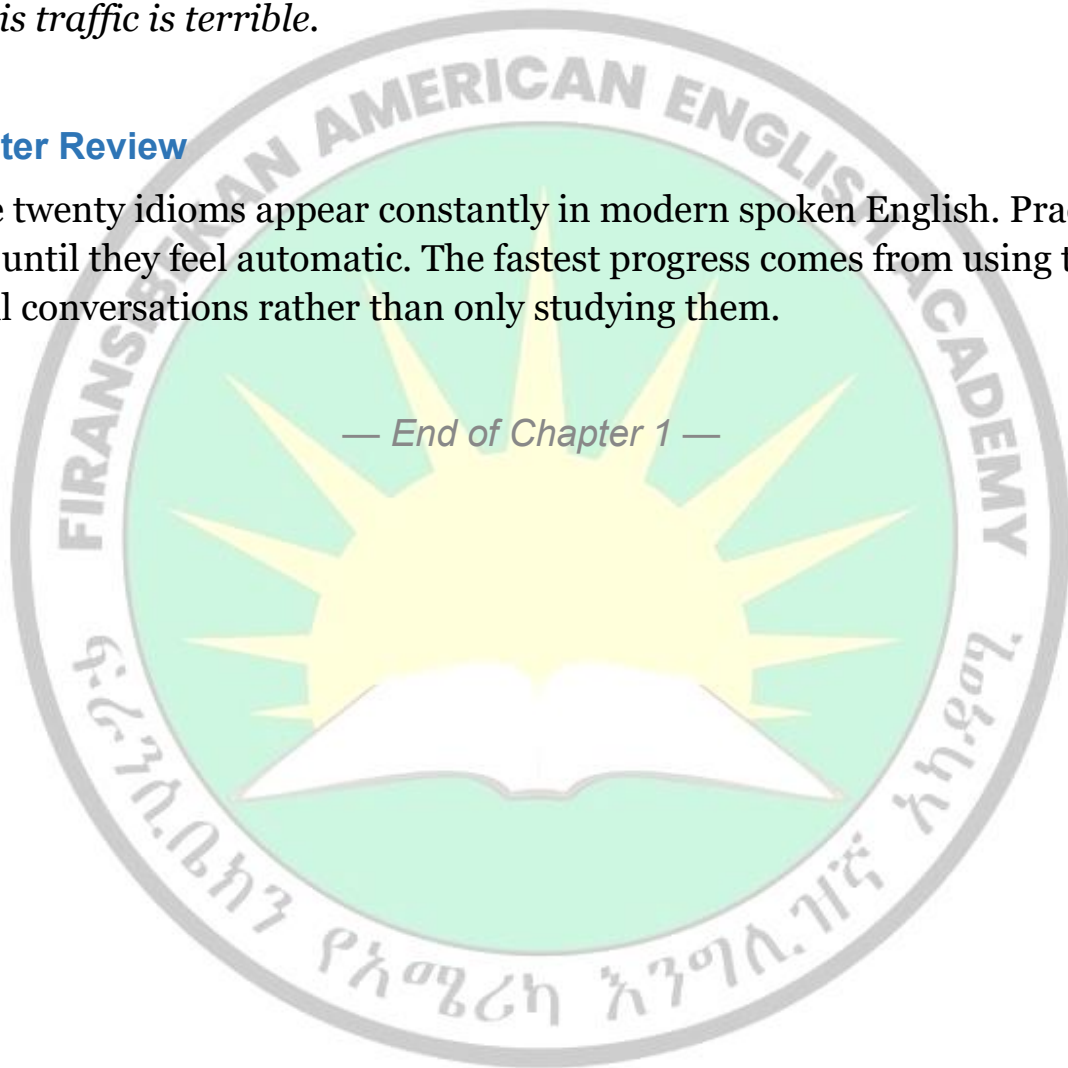
Examples:

- *This traffic is terrible.*

Chapter Review

These twenty idioms appear constantly in modern spoken English. Practise them until they feel automatic. The fastest progress comes from using them in real conversations rather than only studying them.

— End of Chapter 1 —



CHAPTER 2

Life Idioms

These expressions capture the ups and downs, lessons and attitudes that shape everyday existence.

A blessing in disguise

Meaning: Something bad that later turns out to be good.

Short Explanation: The misfortune disguises a later benefit.

Usage: Common and comforting. Neutral.

Examples:

- *Losing that job was a blessing in disguise.*
- *The delay turned out to be a blessing in disguise.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Friend: *Sorry you didn't get the apartment.*

You: *It was a blessing in disguise. The later one is better.*

When life gives you lemons, make lemonade

Meaning: Turn problems into something positive.

Short Explanation: Lemons are sour; lemonade is sweet.

Usage: Motivational. Neutral to informal.

Examples:

- *She failed but studied harder — when life gives you lemons, make lemonade.*
- *We made lemonade by using the research for a paper.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Colleague: *The client pulled out.*

You: *When life gives you lemons... let's improve the other proposals.*

Every cloud has a silver lining

Meaning: Every bad situation has something good.

Short Explanation: Sunlight creates a bright edge on dark clouds.

Usage: Comforting. Common.

Examples:

- *She lost her phone but reduced screen time — every cloud has a silver lining.*
- *Every cloud has a silver lining — we learned a lot.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Colleague: *We lost the contract.*

Manager: *Every cloud has a silver lining. Now we focus on stronger clients.*

Back to square one

Meaning: Start again from the beginning.

Short Explanation: From board games or early radio commentary.

Usage: Common after setbacks. Neutral.

Examples:

- *The plan failed, so we are back to square one.*
- *We had to go back to square one after the crash.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Developer: *The client rejected the architecture.*

Lead: *Back to square one. Fresh workshop.*

Hit rock bottom

Meaning: Reach the lowest point in life.

Short Explanation: Rock bottom is the solid floor; from there the only way is up.

Usage: Strong. Common in recovery stories.

Examples:

- *After losing everything he hit rock bottom but recovered.*
- *She realised she had hit rock bottom.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Friend: *How bad did it get?*

You: *I hit rock bottom last year. That's when I asked for help.*

Turn over a new leaf

Meaning: Start behaving in a better way; make a fresh start.

Short Explanation: Turning a page reveals a clean new page.

Usage: Positive. Common.

Examples:

- *He decided to turn over a new leaf and stop lying.*
- *She turned over a new leaf and started exercising.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Relative: *You've changed.*

You: *I decided to turn over a new leaf.*

Face the music

Meaning: Accept the consequences of your actions.

Short Explanation: Possibly from military or theatrical origins.

Usage: Common for accountability. Neutral.

Examples:

- *He cheated and had to face the music.*
- *It's time to face the music and tell the truth.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Colleague: *Are you going to hide?*

You: *No. I'll face the music this afternoon..*

IDIOMS RELATED TO LIFE

1. A blessing in disguise

Meaning: Something bad that later turns out to be good.

Example: Losing that job was a blessing in disguise because I found a better one.

2. The ball is in your court

Meaning: It is your decision or responsibility now.

Example: I've given you all the details, now the ball is in your court

3. When life gives you lemons, make lemonade

Meaning: Turn problems into something positive.

Example: She failed the exam but started studying harder—when life gives you lemons, make lemonade.

4. A hard nut to crack

Meaning: A difficult problem or person to understand.

Example: That math question was a hard nut to crack.

5. Live and let live

Meaning: Accept others as they are and don't interfere.

Example: I don't agree with his lifestyle, but I believe in live and let live.

6. Burn the midnight oil

Meaning: To work late into the night.

Example: He burned the midnight oil to finish his project.

7. Every cloud has a silver lining

Meaning: There is something good in every bad situation.

Example: She lost her phone, but it helped her reduce screen time—every cloud has a silver lining.

8. Cross that bridge when you come to it

Meaning: Deal with a problem when it happens, not before.

Example: Don't worry about exams now, we'll cross that bridge when we come to it.

9. Life in the fast lane

Meaning: A very busy, exciting, or risky lifestyle.

Example: After moving to the city, he started living life in the fast lane.

10. Back to square one

Meaning: To start again from the beginning.

Example: The plan failed, so we are back to square one.

11. Take life as it comes

Meaning: Accept life without worrying too much.

Example: She is very calm and takes life as it comes.

12. Hit rock bottom

Meaning: To reach the lowest point in life.

Example: After losing everything, he hit rock bottom but later recovered.

13. A new lease of life

Meaning: A fresh start or renewed energy in life.

Example: After changing schools, he got a new lease of life.

14. It's not the end of the world

Meaning: It's not a very serious problem.

Example: You failed once, but it's not the end of the world.

15. Take it one day at a time

Meaning: Deal with life slowly without worrying about the future.

Example: After the accident, he learned to take it one day at a time.

16. Life goes on

Meaning: Life continues even after problems or sadness.

Example: She was sad about moving, but life goes on.

17. In the long run

Meaning: Over a long period of time.

Example: Studying hard will help you in the long run.

18. Turn over a new leaf

Meaning: To start behaving in a better way.

Example: He decided to turn over a new leaf and stop lying.

19. Go with the flow

Meaning: Accept things as they happen without resistance.

Example: I didn't plan anything; I just went with the flow.

20. Make the best of it

Meaning: Try to use a bad situation in a positive way.

Example: The trip was delayed, but we made the best of it.

21. At the end of the day

Meaning: When everything is considered.

Example: At the end of the day, health is more important than money.

22. A change of heart

Meaning: A change in opinion or decision.

Example: He planned to quit school but had a change of heart.

23. Face the music

Meaning: Accept the consequences of your actions.

Example: He cheated in the exam and had to face the music.

24. Learn the hard way

Meaning: To understand something after experiencing difficulty or failure.

Example: He learned the hard way that smoking is dangerous.

25. The early bird catches the worm

Meaning: People who act early get the best results.

Example: He woke up at 5 a.m. to study—the early bird catches the worm.

26. No pain, no gain

Meaning: You must work hard to achieve success.

Example: She trained every day because no pain, no gain.

27. Keep your chin up

Meaning: Stay positive in difficult times.

Example: Keep your chin up, everything will be fine.

28. On cloud nine

Meaning: Extremely happy.

Example: He was on cloud nine after winning the match.

29. A rough patch

Meaning: A difficult period in life.

Example: They are going through a rough patch in their relationship.

30. Hit the jackpot

Meaning: To get a big success or lucky result.

Example: She hit the jackpot with her new business idea.

31. Cost an arm and a leg

Meaning: Very expensive.

Example: That phone costs an arm and a leg.

32. Bite the bullet

Meaning: Accept something difficult or unpleasant.

Example: He bit the bullet and started studying harder.

33. Break the ice

Meaning: Start a conversation in a social situation.

Example: He told a joke to break the ice.

34. Burn bridges

Meaning: Destroy relationships so you cannot go back.

Example: Don't burn bridges when leaving a job.

35. Better late than never

Meaning: It's better to do something late than not do it.

Example: He finally apologized—better late than never.

36. Rome wasn't built in a day

Meaning: Big things take time.

Example: Be patient—Rome wasn't built in a day.

37. Actions speak louder than words

Meaning: What you do is more important than what you say.

Example: He promised to help, but actions speak louder than words.

38. Let the cat out of the bag

Meaning: Reveal a secret by mistake.

Example: She let the cat out of the bag about the surprise party.

39. Pull yourself together

Meaning: Calm down and control your emotions.

Example: After crying, she pulled herself together and continued.

Additional Life Expressions

The ball is in your court — It is your decision or responsibility now

Example: I've given you the details; the ball is in your court.

A hard nut to crack — A difficult problem or person

Example: That math question was a hard nut to crack.

Live and let live — Accept others and don't interfere

Example: I believe in live and let live.

Burn the midnight oil — Work late into the night

Example: He burned the midnight oil to finish the project.

Cross that bridge when you come to it — Deal with a problem when it happens

Example: We'll cross that bridge when we come to it.

Life in the fast lane — A busy, exciting or risky lifestyle

Example: He started living life in the fast lane.

Take life as it comes — Accept life without worrying too much

Example: She takes life as it comes.

A new lease of life — A fresh start or renewed energy

Example: He got a new lease of life.

It's not the end of the world — It's not a very serious problem

Example: You failed once, but it's not the end of the world.

Take it one day at a time — Deal with life slowly

Example: He learned to take it one day at a time.

Life goes on — Life continues after problems

Example: She was sad, but life goes on.

In the long run — Over a long period of time

Example: Studying hard will help in the long run.

Go with the flow — Accept things as they happen

Example: I just went with the flow.

Make the best of it — Use a bad situation positively

Example: We made the best of it.

At the end of the day — When everything is considered

Example: At the end of the day, health matters most.

A change of heart — A change in opinion or decision

Example: He had a change of heart.

Learn the hard way — Understand after difficulty or failure

Example: He learned the hard way.

No pain, no gain — You must work hard to succeed

Example: No pain, no gain.

Keep your chin up — Stay positive in difficult times

Example: Keep your chin up.

A rough patch — A difficult period

Example: They are going through a rough patch.

Hit the jackpot — Get a big success or lucky result

Example: She hit the jackpot with her idea.

Cost an arm and a leg — Very expensive

Example: That phone costs an arm and a leg.

Bite the bullet — Accept something difficult

Example: He bit the bullet and studied harder.

Break the ice — Start a conversation in a social situation

Example: He told a joke to break the ice.

Burn bridges — Destroy relationships so you cannot go back

Example: Don't burn bridges when leaving a job.

Better late than never — Better to do something late than not at all

Example: Better late than never.

Rome wasn't built in a day — Big things take time

Example: Rome wasn't built in a day.

Actions speak louder than words — What you do matters more than what you say

Example: Actions speak louder than words.

Pull yourself together — Calm down and control your emotions

Example: She pulled herself together and continued

REAL-LIFE DIALOGUE

Maya: I'm glad we finally have a few minutes to talk about office orientation.

Daniel: Me too. I wasn't sure how to bring it up, because I didn't want to make things awkward.

Maya: That is exactly why I wanted a relaxed conversation first. We can be honest without turning it into an argument.

Daniel: Fair enough. I actually felt a little nervous this morning.

Maya: I noticed. But once we started talking, you seemed more comfortable.

Daniel: Yes. Your opening question really helped. It felt natural rather than formal.

Maya: Good. Sometimes one small comment changes the whole atmosphere.

Daniel: And now I understand the plan much better. I was missing some important information before.

Maya: Exactly. That is why this kind of expression is useful: it describes a real situation quickly.

Daniel: I can see myself using "break the ice" when I explain this experience to someone else.

Maya: You can. Just make sure the situation really fits the meaning.

Daniel: Understood. I'll try to use it naturally rather than forcing it into every conversation.

Maya: Perfect. Natural use is more important than using a lot of idioms.

Daniel: Thanks. This was much more useful than memorizing a definition from a list.

Try it yourself: Write one sentence about office orientation using "break the ice." Then say it aloud twice.

— End of Chapter 2 —

CHAPTER 3

FAMILY IDIOMS

Meanings • Explanations • Usage • Examples • Real-Life Dialogues

Family is one of the richest sources of idioms in English. These expressions capture loyalty, resemblance, conflict, life stages, and the emotional bonds that shape our lives. This chapter presents thirty essential family idioms with full explanations and extended dialogues so you can use them naturally and confidently.

How to Study This Chapter

Read each entry carefully. Notice the register (formal/informal) and the emotional tone. Then read the dialogue aloud. After finishing the chapter, try writing your own short dialogue for three idioms that feel most useful to you.

1. Blood is thicker than water

Meaning: Family relationships are stronger and more important than relationships with people outside the family.

Short Explanation: The proverb asserts that kinship (blood) creates a deeper and more lasting bond than ordinary friendship or acquaintance (water). It is often used to justify supporting a relative even after conflict.

Usage: Common proverb. Can be used sincerely or ironically. Neutral register. Both American and British English.

Examples:

- *Even after arguing, they supported each other because blood is thicker than water.*
- *He chose his brother over his friend — blood is thicker than water.*
- *When the crisis came, blood proved thicker than water.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Friend: *Are you really going to help him after everything he did to you last year?*

You: *I know it looks strange from the outside. We had a terrible fight and barely spoke for months.*

Friend: *Exactly. So why are you paying his hospital bills?*

You: *Because he's still my brother. Blood is thicker than water. When it comes down to it, family is family.*

Friend: *I don't think I could do the same.*

You: *I didn't think I could either — until I had to.*

2. Like father, like son

Meaning: A son behaves, looks, or acts in a way that closely resembles his father.

Short Explanation: The expression highlights hereditary or environmental similarity between a father and his son. It is usually affectionate or mildly humorous.

Usage: Very common. Neutral to warm tone. Both varieties of English.

Examples:

- *They both love football — like father, like son.*
- *He's stubborn and ambitious, just like his dad. Like father, like son.*
- *Watching them argue is like watching a mirror — like father, like son.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Neighbour: *I saw your boy coaching the junior team last Saturday.*

Parent: *Yes. He spends every free hour at the pitch.*

Neighbour: *That's exactly how you were at his age.*

Parent: *I know. Like father, like son. Sometimes I feel as if I'm watching a younger version of myself.*

Neighbour: *It's rather sweet, actually.*

3. Like mother, like daughter

Meaning: A daughter is similar to her mother in character, interests, appearance, or behaviour.

Short Explanation: The female counterpart of 'like father, like son'. It emphasises resemblance between mother and daughter.

Usage: Common and usually affectionate. Neutral register.

Examples:

- *They both enjoy cooking — like mother, like daughter.*
- *She's organised, patient, and loves gardening. Like mother, like daughter.*
- *You can see it in the way they both organise a room — like mother, like daughter.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Aunt: *Your daughter has the same smile and the same way of tilting her head when she's thinking.*

Mother: *Everyone says that.*

Aunt: *And she's already taking over the kitchen on Sundays.*

Mother: *Like mother, like daughter. I used to do the same when I was her age.*

Aunt: *It's lovely to watch the pattern continue.*

4. A chip off the old block

Meaning: A child who is very similar to a parent in character, appearance, or behaviour.

Short Explanation: A chip taken from a block of wood looks like the original block. The idiom is usually positive and affectionate.

Usage: Common in both American and British English. Warm tone.

Examples:

- *Hamza is hardworking like his father — a chip off the old block.*
- *She's a chip off the old block: same humour, same determination.*
- *Looking at him, you'd think he was a chip off the old block.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Colleague: *Your son just presented the quarterly report. He handled the difficult questions with real confidence.*

You: *I'm proud of him.*

Colleague: *He has your calm under pressure.*

You: *People keep saying he's a chip off the old block. I take it as a compliment.*

Colleague: *You should. It's clearly meant as one.*

5. The apple doesn't fall far from the tree

Meaning: Children are often similar to their parents in character, habits, or abilities.

Short Explanation: An apple falls close to the tree that produced it. The proverb observes that children tend to resemble their parents.

Usage: Very common. Can be positive, neutral, or mildly critical depending on context.

Examples:

- *She's an excellent singer; the apple doesn't fall far from the tree.*
- *He's as stubborn as his father. The apple doesn't fall far from the tree.*
- *Looking at their careers, the apple clearly didn't fall far from the tree.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Teacher: *Your daughter has a natural gift for languages.*

Parent: *Her mother speaks four languages fluently.*

Teacher: *That explains it. The apple doesn't fall far from the tree.*

Parent: *We've been careful not to pressure her, but she seems to enjoy it the same way her mother did.*

6. Runs in the family

Meaning: A quality, talent, trait, or medical condition that is common among members of the same family.

Short Explanation: The expression treats a characteristic as something that moves through generations like a current.

Usage: Neutral. Used for both positive traits (talent, humour) and less desirable ones (temper, illness).

Examples:

- *Musical talent runs in the family.*
- *A short temper seems to run in the family.*
- *Longevity runs in their family — most of them live past ninety.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Doctor: *Has anyone else in the family had similar symptoms?*

Patient: *My father and my uncle both had the same issue in their forties.*

Doctor: *It may run in the family. We should keep a close eye on it.*

Patient: *That's what I was afraid of.*

7. Black sheep of the family

Meaning: A family member who is considered different, unsuccessful, or a source of embarrassment compared with the rest of the family.

Short Explanation: In a flock of white sheep, a black one stands out. The idiom is often critical or regretful, though sometimes used with affection or defiance.

Usage: Common. Tone depends on the speaker's attitude. Both varieties.

Examples:

- *He was the black sheep of the family.*
- *Every family has a black sheep.*
- *She left home at sixteen and was always regarded as the black sheep.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Cousin: *Why doesn't Uncle Ray ever come to the reunions?*

You: *He's the black sheep. The family never fully accepted his choices — the career, the lifestyle, the city he moved to.*

Cousin: *That's a shame. He always seemed interesting to me.*

You: *I agree. But once the label sticks, it's hard to remove.*

8. Home is where the heart is

Meaning: Home is the place where the people you love are; physical location matters less than emotional connection.

Short Explanation: The expression prioritises emotional belonging over geography. It is often used by people who travel or move frequently.

Usage: Warm and reflective. Neutral register. Common in both spoken and written English.

Examples:

- *I always miss my family because home is where the heart is.*
- *We've lived in five countries, but home is where the heart is.*
- *She keeps saying home is where the heart is, and right now her heart is with her parents.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Friend: *You've been away for three years. Don't you miss your old apartment?*

You: *Sometimes. But home is where the heart is. My heart is with my partner and the kids now, so wherever we are together feels like home.*

Friend: *That's a healthy way to look at it.*

9. Family comes first

Meaning: Family should be your highest priority, above work, social life, or other obligations.

Short Explanation: A clear statement of values. It is often used to explain a decision that others might question.

Usage: Common in both personal and professional contexts. Neutral to firm tone.

Examples:

- *She skipped work because family comes first.*
- *I turned down the promotion. Family comes first right now.*
- *He always says family comes first, and he means it.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Manager: *We really needed you at the client dinner last night.*

Employee: *I know. My daughter had a fever and my partner was travelling. I had to stay home.*

Manager: *I understand, but the client noticed.*

Employee: *I'm sorry. In situations like that, family comes first. I'll make it up with the follow-up call tomorrow.*

10. Flesh and blood

Meaning: A close family member; someone related by birth.

Short Explanation: The phrase emphasises biological connection. It is often used when appealing to loyalty or explaining protective behaviour.

Usage: Slightly formal or emphatic. Neutral register.

Examples:

- *I will always help my brother because he is my flesh and blood.*
- *You can't turn your back on your own flesh and blood.*
- *She's not just a colleague — she's flesh and blood.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Friend: *After everything he did, you're still defending him?*

You: *He's my flesh and blood. I can be angry with him and still refuse to abandon him.*

Friend: *I respect that, even if I don't fully understand it.*

11. Born with a silver spoon in one's mouth

Meaning: Born into a wealthy and privileged family; starting life with significant advantages.

Short Explanation: Silver spoons were once a clear marker of wealth. The idiom can be neutral, admiring, or mildly critical/envious.

Usage: Common. Slightly literary but still widely used. Both varieties.

Examples:

- *She was born with a silver spoon in her mouth and never had to worry about money.*
- *Not everyone is born with a silver spoon.*
- *He doesn't understand ordinary struggles — he was born with a silver spoon in his mouth.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Colleague: *How did she buy that apartment at twenty-six with no mortgage?*

You: *Family money. She was born with a silver spoon in her mouth.*

Colleague: *That explains a lot. The rest of us are still calculating rent.*

You: *Exactly. Different starting lines.*

12. Follow in someone's footsteps

Meaning: To do the same work, follow the same path, or live in a similar way as a parent or another family member.

Short Explanation: The image is of walking the same path someone else has already walked. It is often used for careers or major life choices.

Usage: Neutral to positive. Common in both personal and professional talk.

Examples:

- *He followed in his father's footsteps and became a doctor.*
- *She didn't want to follow in her mother's footsteps.*
- *Many children feel pressure to follow in their parents' footsteps.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Relative: *So you're applying to medical school as well?*

Young adult: *Yes. I know people will say I'm just following in Dad's footsteps, but I've wanted this since I was twelve.*

Relative: *There's nothing wrong with following in someone's footsteps if the path is genuinely yours.*

Young adult: *That's how I see it.*

13. Tie the knot

Meaning: To get married.

Short Explanation: From the symbolic act of tying a knot during wedding ceremonies in various cultures. The expression is informal and warm.

Usage: Very common. Informal. Both American and British English.

Examples:

- *My sister will tie the knot next month.*
- *They decided to tie the knot after five years together.*
- *We're tying the knot in June — keep the date free.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Friend: *Any big news this year?*

You: *Yes — we're tying the knot in September.*

Friend: *That's wonderful! Have you chosen a venue?*

You: *Not yet. We're still looking. The important thing is that we've decided to take the step.*

14. Better half

Meaning: A husband or wife (used affectionately or humorously).

Short Explanation: The phrase treats a spouse as the 'better' half of a single whole. It is light and often slightly playful.

Usage: Informal and warm. Common in casual conversation.

Examples:

- *He went on vacation with his better half.*
- *I'll have to check with my better half before I confirm.*
- *My better half is the organised one in this relationship.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Colleague: *Are you free for dinner on Friday?*

You: *I need to ask my better half first. We try to keep Friday evenings free for each other.*

Colleague: *Fair enough. Let me know.*

15. Bundle of joy

Meaning: A newborn baby.

Short Explanation: The expression focuses on the happiness a new baby brings. It is warm and celebratory.

Usage: Common and affectionate. Neutral register.

Examples:

- *Their bundle of joy arrived yesterday.*
- *We're expecting a new bundle of joy in March.*
- *The whole family came to meet the bundle of joy.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Neighbour: *I saw the hospital bag by the door last week.*

Parent: *Yes — our bundle of joy arrived two days ago. A healthy baby girl.*

Neighbour: *Congratulations! How are you both holding up?*

Parent: *Exhausted and completely happy.*

16. Breadwinner

Meaning: The person who earns the money that supports the family.

Short Explanation: Literally the person who brings home the bread (income). The term is practical rather than emotional.

Usage: Neutral and common in discussions of household roles and finances.

Examples:

- *Her father is the family's breadwinner.*
- *After the layoff she became the sole breadwinner.*
- *Being the main breadwinner carries a lot of pressure.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Relative: *Who's covering the household expenses while he's studying?*

You: *I'm the main breadwinner at the moment. He'll take over more once he finishes the degree.*

Relative: *That's a big responsibility.*

You: *It is, but it's temporary and we planned for it.*

17. Bring up

Meaning: To raise a child; to care for and educate a child until adulthood.

Short Explanation: The phrasal verb covers the entire process of parenting — physical care, values, education, and guidance.

Usage: Extremely common. Neutral. Both varieties.

Examples:

- *They brought up their children with good manners.*
- *She was brought up in a small village.*
- *It's not easy to bring up children in a big city.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Friend: *Your kids are so polite and confident.*

Parent: *Thank you. We've tried to bring them up with clear values and a lot of conversation.*

Friend: *It shows. They're a credit to you.*

18. Family tree

Meaning: A diagram or record that shows the relationships between members of a family across generations.

Short Explanation: The image of a tree with roots, trunk, and branches maps naturally onto ancestry and descendants.

Usage: Common in schools, genealogy, and family discussions. Neutral.

Examples:

- *We drew our family tree at school.*
- *She's been researching the family tree for years.*
- *The family tree goes back to the eighteenth century.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Child: *What's this chart on the wall?*

Parent: *It's our family tree. See? Here's your great-grandmother, then your grandparents, then us, and here you are.*

Child: *There are so many names.*

Parent: *That's why we keep it. So we remember where we come from.*

19. Next of kin

Meaning: The closest living relative or relatives, especially in legal or medical contexts.

Short Explanation: A formal term used by hospitals, employers, and legal documents to identify who should be contacted or who has rights in certain situations.

Usage: Formal. Common in official contexts.

Examples:

- *His wife is his next of kin.*
- *Please list your next of kin on the form.*
- *The hospital contacted the next of kin immediately.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Nurse: *We need an emergency contact and next of kin for the records.*

Patient: *My wife is both. Here's her number.*

Nurse: *Thank you. We'll only call if necessary.*

20. Home sweet home

Meaning: An expression of relief or pleasure at being back in one's own home after being away.

Short Explanation: The phrase celebrates the comfort and familiarity of home. It is often said upon returning from a trip.

Usage: Warm and common. Informal. Both varieties.

Examples:

- *After the trip, everyone said, 'Home sweet home!'*
- *There's nothing like walking through your own front door — home sweet home.*
- *Three weeks on the road and finally: home sweet home.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Partner: *The airport was chaos and the traffic was worse.*

You: *I know. But look — we're here. Home sweet home.*

Partner: *I'm going to make tea and not move for an hour.*

You: *Perfect plan.*

21. In the family way

Meaning: Pregnant.

Short Explanation: An older, slightly euphemistic way of saying that a woman is expecting a baby. It is less common in modern informal speech but still understood.

Usage: Slightly old-fashioned or polite. More British in flavour, though understood in American English.

Examples:

- *She is in the family way with her first child.*
- *They announced that she's in the family way.*
- *Word spread quickly that she was in the family way.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Relative: *Have you heard the news about your cousin?*

You: *No — what is it?*

Relative: *She's in the family way. Due in the autumn.*

You: *That's wonderful! I'll call her this evening.*

22. Leave the nest

Meaning: To leave home and begin living independently, especially for the first time.

Short Explanation: Young birds leave the nest when they are ready to fly. The idiom applies the same idea to young adults moving out.

Usage: Warm and common. Neutral register.

Examples:

- *Their eldest son left the nest for university.*
- *It's hard when children leave the nest.*
- *She left the nest at eighteen and never looked back.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Parent: *The house feels so quiet now.*

Friend: *That's normal when they leave the nest. It gets easier, though the first few months are strange.*

Parent: *I keep walking past his room and expecting to hear music.*

Friend: *Give it time. And enjoy the extra space when you can.*

23. Keep the home fires burning

Meaning: To take care of the home and family while others are away (originally while men were at war or working far from home).

Short Explanation: The image is of maintaining a fire so that home remains warm and welcoming for those who return. It implies steady, often unseen labour.

Usage: Slightly literary or old-fashioned, but still used. Warm and respectful tone.

Examples:

- *She kept the home fires burning while her husband worked abroad.*
- *Someone has to keep the home fires burning.*
- *Thank you for keeping the home fires burning while I was away.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Partner: *I know the last six months of travel have been hard on you.*

You: *I managed. Someone had to keep the home fires burning — school runs, bills, the dog, everything.*

Partner: *I'm grateful. Truly.*

You: *Just don't make it a permanent arrangement.*

24. Daddy's girl

Meaning: A daughter who is especially close to her father and often favoured or protected by him.

Short Explanation: The expression can be affectionate or mildly teasing. It highlights a strong father–daughter bond.

Usage: Informal and common. Usually warm, sometimes gently critical.

Examples:

- *Everyone knows she is Daddy's girl.*
- *She's always been a Daddy's girl.*
- *He can't say no to her — she's a classic Daddy's girl.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Sibling: *Of course Dad said yes to the trip. You're the Daddy's girl.*

Daughter: *That's not fair. I asked properly and I offered to pay half.*

Sibling: *Still. If I had asked, the answer would have been different.*

Daughter: *Maybe. But I'm not going to apologise for having a good relationship with him.*

25. Mama's boy

Meaning: A son who is overly attached to or dependent on his mother, sometimes to a degree considered excessive.

Short Explanation: The expression is often teasing or critical. It suggests that the son has not achieved full emotional independence.

Usage: Informal. Can be affectionate among family or mildly insulting from outsiders.

Examples:

- *His friends teased him for being a Mama's boy.*
- *He's thirty and still a bit of a Mama's boy.*
- *Don't call him a Mama's boy — he's just close to his mother.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Friend: *He calls his mother three times a day and still asks her advice on everything.*

You: *Some people would call him a Mama's boy.*

Friend: *I wouldn't say it to his face, but the attachment is unusual for his age.*

You: *As long as he's happy and functional, I'm not sure it's our business.*

26. One big happy family

Meaning: A group of people (not necessarily related) who get along very well and feel like a family.

Short Explanation: The phrase is often used for teams, workplaces, or groups of friends. It can be sincere or mildly ironic.

Usage: Common. Neutral to warm. Both varieties.

Examples:

- *Our team feels like one big happy family.*
- *After the retreat we really became one big happy family.*
- *They always describe themselves as one big happy family — whether it's true or not.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

New colleague: *The atmosphere here is surprisingly warm.*

You: *We work hard, but we also look after each other. Most days it feels like one big happy family.*

New colleague: *That's rare. I hope it stays that way.*

27. Keep it in the family

Meaning: Do not share family matters, secrets, or business with people outside the family.

Short Explanation: The expression values privacy and internal loyalty. It is often used when sensitive topics arise.

Usage: Common. Slightly cautious or protective tone. Neutral register.

Examples:

- *Let's keep it in the family.*
- *They prefer to keep financial matters in the family.*
- *Some problems are better kept in the family.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Sibling: *Should we tell the cousins about the inheritance discussion?*

You: *Not yet. Let's keep it in the family until we know exactly where we stand.*

Sibling: *Agreed. No need to create worry before we have facts.*

28. Blood relative

Meaning: A person related by birth rather than by marriage or adoption.

Short Explanation: The term is used when it is important to distinguish biological kinship from other forms of family connection.

Usage: Slightly formal. Common in legal, medical, and genealogical contexts.

Examples:

- *She is my blood relative.*
- *Only blood relatives were invited to the private ceremony.*
- *The will distinguishes between blood relatives and relatives by marriage.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Lawyer: *The estate is to be divided among blood relatives only.*

Client: *So my stepfather is not included?*

Lawyer: *Correct. Under the current wording, only blood relatives inherit.*

29. The prodigal son

Meaning: A family member who leaves home, often after wasteful or rebellious behaviour, and later returns, usually seeking forgiveness or reconciliation.

Short Explanation: From the biblical parable of the prodigal son. The expression is still widely used for anyone who returns after a long or difficult absence.

Usage: Slightly literary but common. Can be warm or ironic.

Examples:

- *After years abroad, he returned like the prodigal son.*
- *The prodigal son finally came home for the holidays.*
- *They welcomed the prodigal son with open arms.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Aunt: *I can't believe your brother is back after seven years of almost no contact.*

You: *Neither can I. The prodigal son returns.*

Aunt: *How is your mother taking it?*

You: *She's cooking his favourite meal. Some things never change.*

30. Welcome someone with open arms

Meaning: To receive someone warmly, enthusiastically, and without reservation.

Short Explanation: Open arms are a physical gesture of acceptance and affection. The idiom extends the gesture to emotional and social welcome.

Usage: Warm and positive. Common in both personal and professional contexts.

Examples:

- *His family welcomed him with open arms after his long journey.*
- *The community welcomed the refugees with open arms.*
- *She was welcomed with open arms on her first day back.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Friend: *Were you nervous about going home after so long?*

You: *A little. But they welcomed me with open arms — the whole family at the airport, tears, food waiting at the house.*

Friend: *That's the best kind of homecoming.*

You: *It reminded me why I needed to come back.*

IDIOMS EXPRESSION RELATED TO FAMILY

1. Blood is thicker than water

Meaning: Family relationships are stronger than other relationships.

Example: Even after arguing, they supported each other because blood is thicker than water.

2. Like father, like son

Meaning: A son behaves like his father.

Example: They both love football—like father, like son.

3. Like mother, like daughter

Meaning: A daughter is similar to her mother.

Example: They both enjoy cooking—like mother, like daughter.

4. A chip off the old block

Meaning: A child is very similar to a parent.

Example: Hamzaa is hardworking like his father—a chip off the old block.

5. The apple doesn't fall far from the tree

Meaning: Children are often like their parents.

Example: She's an excellent singer; the apple doesn't fall far from the tree.

6. Runs in the family

Meaning: A quality or talent is common in the family.

Example: Musical talent runs in the family.

7. Black sheep of the family

Meaning: A family member who is different or causes embarrassment.

Example: He was the black sheep of the family.

8. Home is where the heart is

Meaning: Home is where your loved ones are.

Example: I always miss my family because home is where the heart is.

9. Family comes first

Meaning: Family should be your top priority.

Example: She skipped work because family comes first.

10. Flesh and blood

Meaning: A close family member.

Example: I will always help my brother because he is my flesh and blood.

11. Born with a silver spoon in one's mouth

Meaning: Born into a wealthy family.

Example: She was born with a silver spoon in her mouth.

12. Follow in someone's footsteps

Meaning: Do the same as a family member.

Example: He followed in his father's footsteps and became a doctor.

13. Tie the knot

Meaning: Get married.

Example: My sister will tie the knot next month.

14. Better half

Meaning: A husband or wife.

Example: He went on vacation with his better half.

15. Bundle of joy

Meaning: A newborn baby.

Example: Their bundle of joy arrived yesterday.

16. Breadwinner

Meaning: The person who earns money for the family.

Example: Her father is the family's breadwinner.

17. Bring up

Meaning: Raise a child.

Example: They brought up their children with good manners.

18. Family tree

Meaning: A record of family history.

Example: We drew our family tree at school.

19. Next of kin

Meaning: Closest living relative.

Example: His wife is his next of kin.

20. Home sweet home

Meaning: Home is the best place.

Example: After the trip, everyone said, "Home sweet home!"

21. In the family way

Meaning: Pregnant.

Example: She is in the family way with her first child.

22. Leave the nest

Meaning: Leave home to live independently.

Example: Their eldest son left the nest for university.

23. Keep the home fires burning

Meaning: Take care of the family while others are away.

Example: She kept the home fires burning while her husband worked abroad.

24. Daddy's girl

Meaning: A daughter who is very close to her father.

Example: Everyone knows she is Daddy's girl.

25. Mama's boy

Meaning: A son who depends too much on his mother.

Example: His friends teased him for being a Mama's boy.

26. One big happy family

Meaning: A group that gets along like a family.

Example: Our team feels like one big happy family.

27. Keep it in the family

Meaning: Do not share family matters with outsiders.

Example: Let's keep it in the family.

28. Blood relative

Meaning: A person related by birth.

Example: She is my blood relative.

29. The prodigal son

Meaning: A family member who leaves and later returns.

Example: After years abroad, he returned like the prodigal son.

30. Welcome someone with open arms

Meaning: Receive someone warmly.

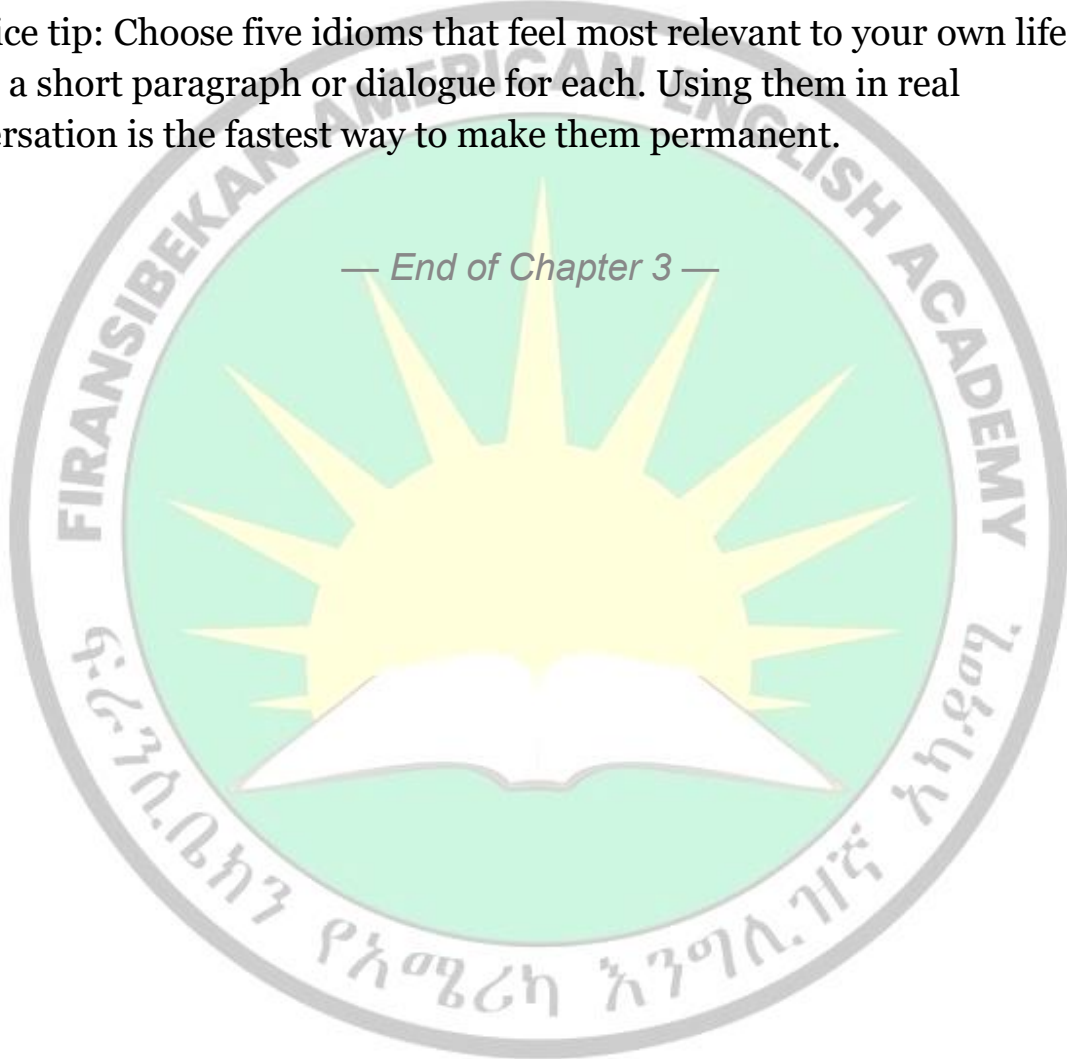
Example: His family welcomed him with open arms after his long journey.

Chapter Review

Family idioms help us talk about loyalty, resemblance, conflict, life stages, and emotional bonds with precision and colour. The thirty expressions in this chapter cover the most common and useful patterns.

Practice tip: Choose five idioms that feel most relevant to your own life. Write a short paragraph or dialogue for each. Using them in real conversation is the fastest way to make them permanent.

— End of Chapter 3 —



CHAPTER 4

Work & Business Idioms

These expressions dominate meetings, emails, performance reviews, and casual office talk. Using them correctly signals that you understand workplace culture.

Think outside the box

Meaning: To think creatively and unconventionally; to find solutions that are not obvious.

Short Explanation: The 'box' represents conventional thinking or standard procedures. Stepping outside it means generating original ideas.

Usage: Extremely common in business, advertising, and education. Neutral to slightly informal. Both US and UK.

Examples:

- *We need to think outside the box if we want to stand out from competitors.*
- *Her suggestion showed she was really thinking outside the box.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Creative director: *The client rejected the first three concepts.*

Designer: *Then we have to think outside the box. What if we abandon the usual product shots entirely?*

Creative director: *I'm listening. Keep going.*

Pull your weight

Meaning: To do your fair share of the work in a group or team.

Short Explanation: From rowing or physical labor: everyone must pull their portion of the load or the effort fails.

Usage: Common in teamwork contexts. Can sound critical if directed at someone. Neutral register.

Examples:

- *Everyone needs to pull their weight on this project.*
- *He's a great colleague – he always pulls his weight.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Team lead: *The deadline is next Friday. I need everyone pulling their weight.*

Junior: *Understood. I'll take the data cleaning so the analysts can focus on modeling.*

Burn the midnight oil

Meaning: To work late into the night.

Short Explanation: From the days when oil lamps provided light after dark. Working by lamp light meant staying up late.

Usage: Slightly literary but still widely used. Common in both professional and academic contexts.

Examples:

- *She burned the midnight oil to finish the proposal.*
- *I can't burn the midnight oil every night – I need sleep.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Colleague: *You look exhausted.*

You: *I burned the midnight oil finishing the quarterly report. It's done, though.*

Colleague: *Impressive. Now go home and rest.*

Hit the ground running

Meaning: To start a new job, project, or activity with energy and immediate effectiveness, without needing much preparation time.

Short Explanation: Military and sports image: a parachutist or athlete who lands and immediately begins moving at full speed.

Usage: Very common in job descriptions and performance talk. Positive and energetic. Neutral.

Examples:

- *We need someone who can hit the ground running.*
- *She hit the ground running in her first week and closed two deals.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Hiring manager: *The role is demanding from day one.*

Candidate: *I'm used to that. In my last position I had to hit the ground running during a product launch.*

Hiring manager: *That's exactly the energy we're looking for.*

Back to the drawing board

Meaning: To start again from the beginning because the previous plan or attempt has failed.

Short Explanation: From design and engineering: when a prototype fails, the designers return to their drawing boards to create a new plan.

Usage: Common after setbacks. Neutral, slightly informal. Both varieties.

Examples:

- *The client rejected the design, so it's back to the drawing board.*
- *The experiment didn't work. Back to the drawing board.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Engineer: *The prototype failed the stress test.*

Lead: *Disappointing, but not unexpected. Back to the drawing board – let's review the material choices.*

Touch base

Meaning: To make brief contact with someone in order to update them or check progress.

Short Explanation: From baseball: a runner must touch a base to be safe. Figuratively, a quick check-in keeps everyone 'safe' and informed.

Usage: Extremely common in modern business English, especially American. Slightly informal but widely accepted.

Examples:

- *I'll touch base with you later this week.*
- *Let's touch base after the client call.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Manager: *How's the vendor negotiation going?*

Buyer: *Still in progress. I'll touch base with you as soon as I have a final number.*

In the loop / Out of the loop

Meaning: In the loop: kept informed and included in communication. Out of the loop: not informed or excluded from updates.

Short Explanation: From communication circuits or military command loops. Being 'in the loop' means receiving the same information as the core group.

Usage: Very common in offices. Neutral. More American in origin but now global.

Examples:

- *Please keep me in the loop on any changes.*
- *I felt out of the loop while I was on leave.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Colleague: *Did you hear about the new timeline?*

You: *No – I've been out of the loop this week. Can you fill me in?*

Colleague: *Sure. From now on I'll make sure you're in the loop.*

Go the extra mile

Meaning: To make a special effort; to do more than what is expected or required.

Short Explanation: Biblical origin (Matthew 5:41) that has become secular: going beyond the minimum duty.

Usage: Positive and motivational. Common in customer service, performance reviews, and personal development. Neutral.

Examples:

- *Our support team always goes the extra mile for customers.*
- *She went the extra mile to make the event special.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Customer: *I can't believe you stayed late to fix this.*

Support agent: *We like to go the extra mile. Your satisfaction matters.*

Low-hanging fruit

Meaning: The easiest tasks, goals, or opportunities that can be achieved with the least effort.

Short Explanation: From agriculture: fruit hanging low on the tree is easiest to pick. Used for quick wins before tackling harder problems.

Usage: Very common in business strategy and project planning. Neutral to slightly informal.

Examples:

- *Let's tackle the low-hanging fruit first.*
- *Those three client requests are low-hanging fruit – we can close them this week.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Director: *We have limited resources this quarter.*

Strategist: *Then we should focus on the low-hanging fruit – the markets where we already have brand recognition.*

Move the needle

Meaning: To make a noticeable or meaningful difference; to produce a measurable impact.

Short Explanation: From gauges and meters whose needles move when values change. Figuratively, actions that register on important metrics.

Usage: Popular in business, marketing, and performance discussions. Slightly informal but widely used.

Examples:

- *This campaign really moved the needle on brand awareness.*
- *Small process changes won't move the needle enough.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

CMO: *We need results that the board will notice.*

Marketer: *The influencer partnership is already moving the needle – engagement is up 40 percent.*

Circle back

Meaning: To return to a topic or conversation at a later time.

Short Explanation: Modern business jargon. Suggests a temporary pause with the intention of revisiting the issue.

Usage: Extremely common in American corporate English. Can feel overused. Neutral in office settings.

Examples:

- *Let's circle back to this after we have the data.*
- *I'll circle back with you next week.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Colleague: *I have a question about the budget allocation.*

Manager: *Good question, but we're short on time. Let's circle back after lunch.*

The bottom line

Meaning: The most important point or the final result, especially regarding profit or the essential conclusion.

Short Explanation: From accounting: the bottom line of a financial statement shows profit or loss. Extended to any essential takeaway.

Usage: Very common in business and everyday speech. Neutral.

Examples:

- *The bottom line is we need more customers.*
- *I understand the details, but what's the bottom line?*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Analyst: *There are several contributing factors...*

CEO: *I appreciate the thoroughness. What's the bottom line for Q3?*

Analyst: *We're 8 percent under target.*

Get your ducks in a row

Meaning: To organize everything properly; to get all the necessary elements ready and in order.

Short Explanation: Image of ducklings following their mother in a neat line. Figuratively, arranging tasks, documents, or plans systematically.

Usage: Common in American English. Friendly and practical. Neutral to informal.

Examples:

- *I need to get my ducks in a row before the audit.*
- *Once we get our ducks in a row, the launch will be smooth.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Project lead: *Are we ready for the client presentation?*

Coordinator: *Almost. I'm still getting the financial ducks in a row. Give me one more hour.*

Drop the ball

Meaning: To make a mistake or fail to do something that was expected; to let responsibility slip.

Short Explanation: From sports: dropping the ball causes a turnover or lost opportunity. Applied to any failure of duty.

Usage: Common and mildly critical. Neutral register. Both US and UK.

Examples:

- *I dropped the ball on the email follow-up.*
- *We can't afford to drop the ball on this contract.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Boss: *The client never received the revised proposal.*

Employee: *That's on me. I dropped the ball. I'll send it within the hour and call to apologize.*

IDIOMS EXPRESSIONS RELATED TO MONEY

1. Break the bank

Meaning: To spend too much money or use all your savings.

Example: This vacation is amazing, but it doesn't have to break the bank.

2. Cost an arm and a leg

Meaning: Something that is very expensive.

Example: That new car costs an arm and a leg.

3. Save for a rainy day

Meaning: To save money for future problems or emergencies.

Example: My parents save money for a rainy day.

4. Make ends meet

Meaning: To have enough money to pay for basic needs.

Example: He works two jobs to make ends meet.

5. Time is money

Meaning: Time is valuable and should be used wisely.

Example: Don't waste time because time is money.

6. Money talks

Meaning: Money has power and influence.

Example: In some situations, money talks.

7. Bring home the bacon

Meaning: To earn money for your family.

Example: My father works hard to bring home the bacon.

8. Throw money down the drain

Meaning: To waste money.

Example: Buying unnecessary things is throwing money down the drain.

9. Live beyond your means

Meaning: To spend more money than you earn.

Example: He lives beyond his means and has many debts.

10. Worth every penny

Meaning: Good value for the money spent.

Example: This computer is worth every penny.

11. Money doesn't grow on trees

Meaning: Money is limited and should not be wasted.

Example: Be careful with your spending; money doesn't grow on trees.

12. Tighten your belt

Meaning: To spend less money.

Example: We need to tighten our belts this month.

13. Foot the bill

Meaning: To pay the cost of something.

Example: My brother footed the bill for the dinner.

14. Pick up the tab

Meaning: To pay the bill.

Example: I will pick up the tab for lunch today.

15. In the red

Meaning: Having financial problems or debt.

Example: The company is in the red this year.

16. In the black

Meaning: Making a profit or having financial success.

Example: The business is finally in the black.

17. Rolling in money

Meaning: To be very rich.

Example: The famous actor is rolling in money.

18. Strike it rich

Meaning: To become wealthy suddenly.

Example: He hopes to strike it rich with his new business.

19. Easy money

Meaning: Money earned with little effort.

Example: Some people think online jobs are easy money.

20. Cash cow

Meaning: A person or thing that produces a lot of profit.

Example: That product became the company's cash cow.

21. Pay through the nose

Meaning: To pay a very high price.

Example: We paid through the nose for the hotel room.

22. On a shoestring budget

Meaning: With very little money.

Example: They started the project on a shoestring budget.

23. Scrape together money

Meaning: To collect money with difficulty.

Example: She scraped together enough money to buy a phone.

24. Money to burn

Meaning: Having a lot of money to spend.

Example: He spends like he has money to burn.

25. A penny saved is a penny earned

Meaning: Saving money is as valuable as earning money.

Example: I save small amounts because a penny saved is a penny earned.

26. Keep your head above water

Meaning: To manage financially and avoid failure.

Example: He works hard to keep his head above water.

27. Rags to riches

Meaning: Becoming successful after being poor.

Example: His life story is a true rags-to-riches story.

28. Put your money where your mouth is

Meaning: To support your words with actions.

Example: If you believe in the idea, put your money where your mouth is.

29. A fool and his money are soon parted

Meaning: A careless person can lose money easily.

Example: He bought useless things; a fool and his money are soon parted.

30. Get your money's worth

Meaning: To receive good value for the money you spend.

Example: I got my money's worth from that course because I learned a lot.

REAL-LIFE DIALOGUE

Mira: I'm glad we finally have a few minutes to talk about marketing meeting.

Ben: Me too. I wasn't sure how to bring it up, because I didn't want to make things awkward.

Mira: That is exactly why I wanted a relaxed conversation first. We can be honest without turning it into an argument.

Ben: Fair enough. I actually felt a little nervous this morning.

Mira: I noticed. But once we started talking, you seemed more comfortable.

Ben: Yes. Your opening question really helped. It felt natural rather than formal.

Mira: Good. Sometimes one small comment changes the whole atmosphere.

Ben: And now I understand the plan much better. I was missing some important information before.

Mira: Exactly. That is why this kind of expression is useful: it describes a real situation quickly.

Ben: I can see myself using "think outside the box" when I explain this experience to someone else.

Mira: You can. Just make sure the situation really fits the meaning.

Ben: Understood. I'll try to use it naturally rather than forcing it into every conversation.

Mira: Perfect. Natural use is more important than using a lot of idioms.

Ben: Thanks. This was much more useful than memorizing a definition from a list.

Try it yourself: Write one sentence about marketing meeting using "think outside the box." Then say it aloud twice.

— End of chapter 4 —

CHAPTER 5

Feelings & Emotions

English has a rich set of idioms for describing internal states. These expressions allow speakers to convey intensity, nuance, and attitude more vividly than simple adjectives.

Over the moon

Meaning: Extremely happy or delighted.

Short Explanation: The image is of being so happy that you float above the moon. Strong positive emotion.

Usage: Informal and warm. Very common in British English; also used in American English. Casual contexts.

Examples:

- *She was over the moon when she got the job offer.*
- *We're over the moon about the new baby.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Friend: *Did you hear back from the university?*

Student: *Yes! I got in. I'm over the moon.*

Friend: *That's fantastic – you deserve it.*

On cloud nine

Meaning: Extremely happy; in a state of bliss.

Short Explanation: Possibly from cloud classifications or from the idea of floating high above ordinary worries. Intense joy.

Usage: Informal. Common in both American and British English.

Examples:

- *He's been on cloud nine since the engagement.*
- *Winning the award put her on cloud nine for weeks.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Colleague: *You seem unusually cheerful today.*

You: *I just found out I'm getting promoted. I'm on cloud nine.*

Down in the dumps

Meaning: Feeling sad, depressed, or discouraged.

Short Explanation: 'Dumps' once meant a state of melancholy. The expression is mild and everyday rather than clinical.

Usage: Informal. Common for temporary low moods. Both varieties.

Examples:

- *He's been down in the dumps since the holiday was cancelled.*
- *Cheer up – don't stay down in the dumps all weekend.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Roommate: *You've been quiet all day.*

You: *A bit down in the dumps. The interview didn't go well.*

Roommate: *Sorry to hear that. Want to talk or just watch something mindless?*

Butterflies in your stomach

Meaning: A feeling of nervousness or anxious excitement, often before an important event.

Short Explanation: The fluttering sensation in the abdomen that many people experience when anxious or excited.

Usage: Very common, especially among younger speakers and in everyday talk. Informal.

Examples:

- *I always get butterflies in my stomach before speaking in public.*
- *She had butterflies in her stomach on the first day of school.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Performer: *Five minutes to curtain.*

Friend: *How are you feeling?*

Performer: *Butterflies in my stomach, but the good kind. I'm ready.*

Wear your heart on your sleeve

Meaning: To show your emotions openly and not hide how you feel.

Short Explanation: From the custom of wearing a token of affection on one's sleeve. Figuratively, emotions are visible to everyone.

Usage: Neutral. Can be positive (honest) or slightly critical (too transparent). Both US and UK.

Examples:

- *She wears her heart on her sleeve – you always know exactly how she feels.*
- *In business it's sometimes better not to wear your heart on your sleeve.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Colleague: *I could tell you were disappointed in the meeting.*

You: *I know. I wear my heart on my sleeve. I should practice a better poker face.*

Blow off steam

Meaning: To release pent-up energy, stress, or anger in a harmless way.

Short Explanation: From steam engines: excess pressure is released through a valve. Figuratively, emotional pressure needs an outlet.

Usage: Informal and practical. Common advice after stressful situations.

Examples:

- *After a long week I go running to blow off steam.*
- *He needed to blow off steam after the argument.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Friend: *You look tense.*

You: *Crazy day at work. I'm going to the gym to blow off steam.*

Friend: *Good plan. Call me after if you want to talk.*

See red

Meaning: To become very angry suddenly.

Short Explanation: Anger is often associated with the color red (raised blood pressure, flushed face). The expression captures the flash of rage.

Usage: Informal. Strong emotion. Both varieties.

Examples:

- *He saw red when he found out about the lie.*
- *I see red every time someone parks in my spot.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Witness: *What happened when he read the email?*

Colleague: *He saw red. I've never seen him that angry.*

Keep a stiff upper lip

Meaning: To remain brave and unemotional in the face of difficulty; to hide one's feelings.

Short Explanation: Classic British stereotype of emotional restraint. The upper lip does not tremble even under stress.

Usage: More British than American, though understood everywhere. Slightly formal or humorous when used by non-British speakers.

Examples:

- *Even after the bad news he kept a stiff upper lip.*
- *The British are famous for keeping a stiff upper lip.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Friend: *How are you holding up after the loss?*

You: *Trying to keep a stiff upper lip. One day at a time.*

Green with envy

Meaning: Very jealous.

Short Explanation: Green has long been associated with envy in English literature and folklore.

Usage: Informal and vivid. Common in conversation. Both US and UK.

Examples:

- *She was green with envy when she saw her sister's new car.*
- *Don't be green with envy – you'll get your chance.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Sibling: *Look at the photos from their vacation.*

You: *I'm green with envy. Their hotel looks incredible.*

At the end of your rope / tether

Meaning: Having no more patience, energy, or resources left; completely frustrated or exhausted.

Short Explanation: Image of a rope that has been fully extended – there is nowhere further to go.

Usage: Informal. Strong expression of despair or frustration. 'Rope' is more American; 'tether' more British.

Examples:

- *I'm at the end of my rope with this project.*
- *After three sleepless nights she was at the end of her tether.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Partner: *You've been working nonstop.*

You: *I'm at the end of my rope. If one more thing goes wrong I might quit.*

Mixed feelings

Meaning: Experiencing both positive and negative emotions about the same situation.

Short Explanation: Straightforward: the feelings are mixed rather than pure. Useful for nuanced emotional states.

Usage: Neutral and very common. Suitable for almost any context.

Examples:

- *I have mixed feelings about moving abroad.*
- *She left with mixed feelings – excited but sad.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Friend: *Are you happy about the promotion?*

You: *Mixed feelings. The title is great, but it means longer hours and less time with the kids.*

Get cold feet

Meaning: To become nervous and change your mind about doing something important, especially at the last moment.

Short Explanation: Fear causes a physical sensation of coldness in the extremities. Applied to sudden loss of courage.

Usage: Common before weddings, big decisions, or performances. Informal.

Examples:

- *He got cold feet the night before the wedding.*
- *Don't get cold feet now – you've prepared for months.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Friend: *You're unusually quiet. Second thoughts about the move?*

You: *A little. I always get cold feet before big changes.*

Friend: *That's normal. You'll feel better once you're on the plane.*

IDIOMS EXPRESSIONS RELATED TO EMOTIONS

1. Wear your heart on your sleeve

Meaning: Show your feelings openly.

Example: She wears her heart on her sleeve and never hides her emotions.

2. Bottle up your feelings

Meaning: Keep your emotions inside.

Example: Don't bottle up your feelings; talk to someone.

3. Be over the moon

Meaning: Extremely happy.

Example: He was over the moon after passing the exam.

4. Down in the dumps

Meaning: Feeling sad or depressed.

Example: She was down in the dumps after losing her pet.

5. Cry your heart out

Meaning: Cry a lot because of sadness.

Example: He cried his heart out after hearing the bad news.

6. Green with envy

Meaning: Very jealous.

Example: She was green with envy when her friend won the prize.

7. See red

Meaning: Become very angry.

Example: He saw red when someone damaged his car.

8. Blow your top

Meaning: Lose your temper.

Example: Dad blew his top when he saw the broken window.

9. Keep a stiff upper lip

Meaning: Stay calm and brave during difficult times.

Example: She kept a stiff upper lip despite the challenges.

10. Jump for joy

Meaning: Show great happiness.

Example: The children jumped for joy after hearing the good news.

11. On cloud nine

Meaning: Extremely happy.

Example: She has been on cloud nine since her graduation.

12. Feel blue

Meaning: Feel sad.

Example: I feel blue whenever it rains.

13. Lose your cool

Meaning: Become angry or upset.

Example: He lost his cool during the argument.

14. Be in high spirits

Meaning: Be cheerful and happy.

Example: Everyone was in high spirits at the party.

15. Heartbroken

Meaning: Extremely sad because of disappointment or loss.

Example: She was heartbroken after her friend moved away.

16. Scared stiff

Meaning: Very frightened.

Example: I was scared stiff during the thunderstorm.

17. Get cold feet

Meaning: Become nervous before doing something important.

Example: He got cold feet before the speech.

18. Be on edge

Meaning: Feel nervous or anxious.

Example: She was on edge before the interview.

19. Have butterflies in your stomach

Meaning: Feel nervous.

Example: I had butterflies in my stomach before the competition.

20. Be beside yourself

Meaning: Be overwhelmed with emotion.

Example: He was beside himself with excitement.

21. Smile from ear to ear

Meaning: Smile very widely because of happiness.

Example: She smiled from ear to ear after receiving the gift.

22. Break someone's heart

Meaning: Cause someone deep sadness.

Example: His words broke her heart.

23. Be filled with joy

Meaning: Feel great happiness.

Example: They were filled with joy after the wedding.

24. Lose heart

Meaning: Become discouraged.

Example: Don't lose heart; keep trying.

25. Heart skips a beat

Meaning: Feel sudden excitement or fear.

Example: My heart skipped a beat when I heard my name.

26. Be sick with worry

Meaning: Be extremely worried.

Example: His parents were sick with worry when he was late.

27. Burst into tears

Meaning: Suddenly start crying.

Example: She burst into tears after hearing the news.

28. Walk on air

Meaning: Feel extremely happy.

Example: He was walking on air after winning the award.

29. Shake like a leaf

Meaning: Tremble because of fear or nervousness.

Example: She was shaking like a leaf before the interview.

30. Be at your wit's end

Meaning: Feel so worried or frustrated that you don't know what to do.

Example: I'm at my wit's end trying to solve this problem.

31. Have a heavy heart

Meaning: Feel very sad or unhappy.

Example: She left her hometown with a heavy heart.

32. Be on top of the world

Meaning: Feel extremely happy and confident.

Example: He was on top of the world after getting the job.

33. Be thrilled to bits

Meaning: Be extremely excited and happy.

Example: The children were thrilled to bits when they saw the surprise.

34. Have mixed feelings

Meaning: Feel both happy and sad or uncertain at the same time.

Example: I have mixed feelings about moving to another city.

35. Be crushed

Meaning: Feel extremely disappointed or sad.

Example: She was crushed when her team lost the final.

REAL-LIFE DIALOGUE

Lina: I'm glad we finally have a few minutes to talk about scholarship call.

Father: Me too. I wasn't sure how to bring it up, because I didn't want to make things awkward.

Lina: That is exactly why I wanted a relaxed conversation first. We can be honest without turning it into an argument.

Father: Fair enough. I actually felt a little nervous this morning.

Lina: I noticed. But once we started talking, you seemed more comfortable.

Father: Yes. Your opening question really helped. It felt natural rather than formal.

Lina: Good. Sometimes one small comment changes the whole atmosphere.

Father: And now I understand the plan much better. I was missing some important information before.

Lina: Exactly. That is why this kind of expression is useful: it describes a real situation quickly.

Father: I can see myself using "on cloud nine" when I explain this experience to someone else.

Lina: You can. Just make sure the situation really fits the meaning.

Father: Understood. I'll try to use it naturally rather than forcing it into every conversation.

Lina: Perfect. Natural use is more important than using a lot of idioms.

Father: Thanks. This was much more useful than memorizing a definition from a list.

Try it yourself: Write one sentence about scholarship call using "on cloud nine." Then say it aloud twice.

— End of chapter 5 —

CHAPTER 6

Success & Failure

These idioms capture the drama of achievement and setback. They appear in sports commentary, business reviews, personal stories, and motivational talk.

Hit the jackpot

Meaning: To have great success or sudden good luck, especially involving money or a major win.

Short Explanation: From slot machines and gambling: hitting the jackpot means winning the largest prize.

Usage: Informal and celebratory. Common for both literal wins and figurative breakthroughs.

Examples:

- *She hit the jackpot with her first novel.*
- *Investors who bought early really hit the jackpot.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Friend: *How did the startup exit go?*

Founder: *We hit the jackpot. The acquisition was beyond anything we expected.*

Miss the boat

Meaning: To miss an opportunity because you acted too slowly or too late.

Short Explanation: Literal image of a boat leaving the dock without you. Extended to any opportunity that has passed.

Usage: Common warning or regret. Neutral to informal. Both varieties.

Examples:

- *If you don't apply this week you'll miss the boat.*
- *I waited too long and missed the boat on that investment.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Advisor: *The early-bird discount ends tomorrow.*

Client: *I keep putting it off.*

Advisor: *Don't miss the boat. Prices jump after the deadline.*

A blessing in disguise

Meaning: Something that seems bad or unlucky at first but turns out to have a good result.

Short Explanation: The misfortune 'disguises' a later benefit. Encourages looking for hidden positives.

Usage: Common and comforting. Neutral register. Widely used.

Examples:

- *Losing that job was a blessing in disguise – it pushed me to start my own company.*
- *The delay turned out to be a blessing in disguise.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Friend: *I'm so sorry you didn't get the apartment.*

You: *Actually it was a blessing in disguise. The one I found later is quieter and cheaper.*

Every cloud has a silver lining

Meaning: Every difficult or unpleasant situation has some positive aspect.

Short Explanation: Clouds may look dark, but sunlight creates a bright edge (silver lining). Metaphor for hope.

Usage: Slightly proverbial. Comforting tone. Common in both spoken and written English.

Examples:

- *I know the project failed, but every cloud has a silver lining – we learned a lot.*
- *She always looks for the silver lining.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Colleague: *We lost the contract.*

Manager: *Painful, but every cloud has a silver lining. Now we can focus on stronger clients.*

Go back to square one

Meaning: To return to the starting point because previous efforts have failed or been cancelled.

Short Explanation: From board games or early radio sports commentary where positions were numbered in squares.

Usage: Common after setbacks. Neutral. Both US and UK.

Examples:

- *The deal fell through, so we're back to square one.*
- *After the software crashed we had to go back to square one.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Developer: *The client rejected the entire architecture.*

Lead: *Then we're back to square one. Let's schedule a fresh discovery workshop.*

Climb the corporate ladder

Meaning: To advance in one's career within a company or organization, usually by gaining promotions.

Short Explanation: The hierarchy is imagined as a ladder; each promotion is a higher rung.

Usage: Common in career discussions. Neutral. Slightly more American in flavor but understood globally.

Examples:

- *She's determined to climb the corporate ladder.*
- *He climbed the corporate ladder quickly after the merger.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Mentor: *What's your five-year goal?*

Mentee: *I'd like to climb the corporate ladder into a director role.*

Mentor: *Then we need to build visibility and stretch assignments.*

Fall flat

Meaning: To fail completely, especially of a joke, idea, or performance that receives no positive response.

Short Explanation: Image of something that was supposed to rise or land well but instead collapses flat.

Usage: Common for creative or social failures. Neutral to informal.

Examples:

- *The joke fell flat.*
- *Their marketing campaign fell flat with younger audiences.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Comedian: *How was the new material?*

Friend: *Honestly, a few bits fell flat. The political jokes didn't land.*

Come out on top

Meaning: To succeed or win after a competition, struggle, or difficult situation.

Short Explanation: Spatial metaphor: the winner ends in the highest position.

Usage: Positive and straightforward. Neutral register.

Examples:

- *Despite early problems, the team came out on top.*
- *In the end she always comes out on top.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Reporter: *It was a close race.*

Coach: *Yes, but our players kept their composure and came out on top.*

Bite off more than you can chew

Meaning: To take on more responsibility or work than you can handle.

Short Explanation: Literal image of putting too much food in your mouth. Figuratively, over-committing.

Usage: Common cautionary advice. Neutral to informal. Both varieties.

Examples:

- *I think you've bitten off more than you can chew with three side projects.*
- *Don't bite off more than you can chew in your first semester.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Colleague: *I'm leading two major launches and mentoring three juniors.*

Manager: *That sounds like you've bitten off more than you can chew. Let's re-prioritize.*

A flash in the pan

Meaning: Something that shows early promise or success but fails to last.

Short Explanation: From old firearms: the priming powder could flash without firing the main charge. Brief excitement without lasting result.

Usage: Slightly critical. Used for short-lived trends, people, or successes. Neutral.

Examples:

- *His early success turned out to be a flash in the pan.*
- *That product was just a flash in the pan – sales collapsed after three months.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Investor: *The app had huge downloads in week one.*

Analyst: *True, but retention is terrible. It might be a flash in the pan.*

Go From Strength to Strength

Meaning: to continue becoming more successful or effective

Example: After the first successful launch, the company went from strength to strength.

Usage: Positive and often used for people, careers, teams, and organizations.

Short explanation Each new stage is stronger than the one before it.

Get Your Act Together

Meaning: to become organized, prepared, or responsible

Example: We need to get our act together before the conference begins tomorrow.

Usage: Informal and sometimes critical; it can be used with yourself or others.

Short explanation: The “act” is like a performance that needs to be organized before it can succeed.

IDIOMS RELATED TO SUCCESS

1. Reach for the stars

Meaning: Aim for very high goals or success.

Example: She always tells her students to reach for the stars and never give up.

2. Hit the jackpot

Meaning: To achieve great success or get a big win.

Example: He hit the jackpot when his business idea became popular worldwide.

3. On the right track

Meaning: Doing something in a way that will lead to success.

Example: Your project is improving—you're on the right track.

4. Make it big

Meaning: Become very successful or famous.

Example: She moved to Hollywood hoping to make it big as an actress.

5. Break new ground

Meaning: Do something innovative or never done before.

Example: The scientist broke new ground with her discovery.

6. The sky's the limit

Meaning: There is no limit to what you can achieve.

Example: With your talent, the sky's the limit.

7. Climb the ladder

Meaning: Progress step by step toward success.

Example: He worked hard to climb the ladder in his company.

8. Win hands down

Meaning: Win very easily or clearly.

Example: Our team won the match hands down.

9. Pay off

Meaning: To succeed after effort or hard work.

Example: All his studying finally paid off when he passed the exam.

10. Make a name for oneself

Meaning: Become well-known and successful.

Example: She made a name for herself in the fashion industry.

Example: She made a name for herself as a designer by creating practical products for rural communities.

Usage: Often used for careers, achievements, and public recognition.

Short explanation: Your "name" becomes associated with a particular quality or accomplishment.

11. Go the extra mile

Meaning: Do more than what is expected to achieve success.

Example: She went the extra mile and studied every night to pass the exam.

12. Climb to the top

Meaning: Reach the highest level of success.

Example: He worked hard to climb to the top of his company.

13. Make headway

Meaning: Make progress toward success.

Example: We are finally making headway on the project.

14. Strike it rich

Meaning: Become very successful, usually financially.

Example: He struck it rich after launching his tech startup.

15. A stepping stone

Meaning: Something that helps you move toward success.

Example: This job is a stepping stone to a better career.

16. Burn the midnight oil

Meaning: Work late into the night to achieve success.

Example: She burned the midnight oil to prepare for her final exams.

17. Come out on top

Meaning: To be successful or win after competition.

Example: After a tough match, our team came out on top.

Example: After months of negotiations, the smaller company came out on top.

Usage: Can describe competitions, business negotiations, conflicts, or difficult situations.

Short explanation: The person “on top” is imagined as the one in the strongest position.

18. Get ahead

Meaning: Progress or become successful in life or career.

Example: He works hard to get ahead in life.

19. Make waves

Meaning: Do something successful that gets attention.

Example: The young athlete is making waves in international football.

20. Open doors

Meaning: Create opportunities for success.

Example: Good education can open doors to many careers.

21. At the peak of success

Meaning: At the highest level of success.

Example: The singer is at the peak of success after her new album.

22. On top of the world

Meaning: Feeling extremely successful and happy.

Example: He felt on top of the world after winning the championship.

23. Hit it big

Meaning: Become very successful, especially quickly.

Example: They hit it big with their new mobile app.

24. Seal the deal

Meaning: Successfully complete something important.

Example: The final interview helped him seal the deal for the job.

25. Make a breakthrough

Meaning: Achieve an important success after difficulty.

Example: Scientists made a breakthrough in cancer research.

26. Rising star

Meaning: A person who is becoming very successful.

Example: She is a rising star in the music industry.

27. Turn the corner

Meaning: Start to improve and move toward success.

Example: After months of hard work, the business finally turned the corner.

28. A gold mine

Meaning: Something that brings a lot of success or money.

Example: That idea turned out to be a gold mine.

29. In the fast lane

Meaning: Living a successful and exciting life.

Example: After his promotion, he is living in the fast lane.

30. Go places

Meaning: Be very successful in the future.

Example: She is talented and will definitely go places.

31. Rise To the Occasion

Meaning: to perform well when a difficult or important situation requires it

Example: The junior nurse rose to the occasion when the clinic became unexpectedly busy.

Usage: Positive; often praises someone who meets pressure with competence.

Short explanation an important moment is an “occasion”; rising to it means matching its demands.

REAL-LIFE DIALOGUE

Mentor: I'm glad we finally have a few minutes to talk about career development.

Designer: Me too. I wasn't sure how to bring it up, because I didn't want to make things awkward.

Mentor: That is exactly why I wanted a relaxed conversation first. We can be honest without turning it into an argument.

Designer: Fair enough. I actually felt a little nervous this morning.

Mentor: I noticed. But once we started talking, you seemed more comfortable.

Designer: Yes. Your opening question really helped. It felt natural rather than formal.

Mentor: Good. Sometimes one small comment changes the whole atmosphere.

Designer: And now I understand the plan much better. I was missing some important information before.

Mentor: Exactly. That is why this kind of expression is useful: it describes a real situation quickly.

Designer: I can see myself using "make a name for yourself" when I explain this experience to someone else.

Mentor: You can. Just make sure the situation really fits the meaning.

Designer: Understood. I'll try to use it naturally rather than forcing it into every conversation.

Mentor: Perfect. Natural use is more important than using a lot of idioms.

Designer: Thanks. This was much more useful than memorizing a definition from a list.

Try it yourself: Write one sentence about career development using "make a name for yourself." Then say it aloud twice.

REAL-LIFE DIALOGUE

CEO: I'm glad we finally have a few minutes to talk about contract negotiation.

Partner: Me too. I wasn't sure how to bring it up, because I didn't want to make things awkward.

CEO: That is exactly why I wanted a relaxed conversation first. We can be honest without turning it into an argument.

Partner: Fair enough. I actually felt a little nervous this morning.

CEO: I noticed. But once we started talking, you seemed more comfortable.

Partner: Yes. Your opening question really helped. It felt natural rather than formal.

CEO: Good. Sometimes one small comment changes the whole atmosphere.

Partner: And now I understand the plan much better. I was missing some important information before.

CEO: Exactly. That is why this kind of expression is useful: it describes a real situation quickly.

Partner: I can see myself using "come out on top" when I explain this experience to someone else.

CEO: You can. Just make sure the situation really fits the meaning.

Partner: Understood. I'll try to use it naturally rather than forcing it into every conversation.

CEO: Perfect. Natural use is more important than using a lot of idioms.

Partner: Thanks. This was much more useful than memorizing a definition from a list.

Try it yourself: Write one sentence about contract negotiation using "come out on top." Then say it aloud twice.

— End of chapter 6 —

CHAPTER 7

Money & Spending

Money idioms are among the most colorful in English. They appear in personal finance talk, business negotiations, and everyday complaints about prices.

Break the bank

Meaning: To cost more money than one can afford; to be extremely expensive.

Short Explanation: From gambling: breaking the bank means winning so much that the casino's funds are exhausted. Now used for any budget-breaking cost.

Usage: Informal. Common when discussing prices or budgets. Both varieties.

Examples:

- *We want a nice hotel, but nothing that will break the bank.*
- *The repairs won't break the bank if we do some of the work ourselves.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Partner: *This restaurant looks amazing.*

You: *It does, but I'm worried it will break the bank. Let's check the menu first.*

Tighten your belt

Meaning: To spend less money; to live more frugally because of financial pressure.

Short Explanation: When you have less food, you tighten your belt. Extended to reducing all spending.

Usage: Common advice during economic difficulty. Neutral to slightly formal.

Examples:

- *With inflation rising, many families are tightening their belts.*
- *We'll have to tighten our belts until the next contract is signed.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Spouse: *The bonus didn't come through.*

You: *Then we tighten our belts for a few months – no big purchases, fewer takeaways.*

Bring home the bacon

Meaning: To earn money to support the household; to be the primary earner.

Short Explanation: Bacon once symbolized a substantial food staple. 'Bringing it home' meant providing for the family.

Usage: Slightly old-fashioned but still used, often humorously. Informal. More American.

Examples:

- *Someone has to bring home the bacon.*
- *She's been bringing home the bacon since she was twenty.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Friend: *How's the new job?*

You: *Demanding, but it brings home the bacon. The family is covered.*

A nest egg

Meaning: Savings set aside for the future, especially for retirement or emergencies.

Short Explanation: Birds carefully protect eggs in a nest. Figuratively, carefully protected savings.

Usage: Common in personal finance. Neutral and positive.

Examples:

- *They've built a healthy nest egg for retirement.*
- *Don't touch your nest egg unless it's a true emergency.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Advisor: *How much have you saved?*

Client: *I've been building a nest egg for fifteen years. It's finally starting to feel secure.*

Foot the bill

Meaning: To pay for something, especially when the cost is significant or when paying for others.

Short Explanation: From the practice of writing the total at the foot (bottom) of a bill. The person who 'foots' it pays.

Usage: Neutral. Common in both social and business contexts.

Examples:

- *The company will foot the bill for relocation expenses.*
- *Who's footing the bill for dinner tonight?*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Colleague: *The client dinner ran over budget.*

Manager: *Don't worry – the firm will foot the bill this time.*

In the red / In the black

Meaning: In the red: losing money or in debt. In the black: profitable or having a positive balance.

Short Explanation: Accountants traditionally used red ink for losses and black ink for profits.

Usage: Standard business and personal finance language. Neutral.

Examples:

- *The company has been in the red for two quarters.*
- *We're finally in the black again.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

CFO: *Q2 numbers are in.*

CEO: *Are we still in the red?*

CFO: *No – we moved into the black last month.*

Pay through the nose

Meaning: To pay far too much for something; to be overcharged.

Short Explanation: Origin uncertain; possibly linked to harsh taxes or punishments. Emphasizes painful expense.

Usage: Informal and critical of the price. Both varieties.

Examples:

- *We paid through the nose for last-minute tickets.*
- *You'll pay through the nose if you buy at peak season.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Traveler: *How much was the hotel?*

Friend: *I paid through the nose because it was a holiday weekend. Never again.*

Make ends meet

Meaning: To have just enough money to pay for basic living expenses.

Short Explanation: The 'ends' are the beginning and end of a period (usually a month). Meeting them means income covers outgoings.

Usage: Very common when discussing tight budgets. Neutral and empathetic.

Examples:

- *It's hard to make ends meet on one salary.*
- *They take on extra work just to make ends meet.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Neighbor: *How are things?*

You: *We're making ends meet, but there's not much left over for extras.*

A rainy day fund

Meaning: Money saved for unexpected future needs or emergencies.

Short Explanation: Rainy days are metaphors for hard times. The fund is insurance against them.

Usage: Common personal finance advice. Neutral and practical.

Examples:

- Always keep a rainy day fund of three to six months' expenses.
- She dipped into her rainy day fund when the car broke down.

Real-Life Dialogue:

Parent: Why are you putting so much into savings?

Young adult: I'm building a rainy day fund. I don't want to be caught short.

Real-Life Dialogues

1. Break the Bank

Maya: Have you decided where you want to stay during the holiday?

Daniel: I've been looking at hotels all morning. There are some beautiful ones near the beach.

Maya: That sounds perfect. How much are they?

Daniel: Some of them are almost \$300 a night.

Maya: Wow, that's expensive.

Daniel: Exactly. I want us to have a comfortable trip, but I don't want the hotel to **break the bank**.

Maya: I agree. We still need money for food, transportation, and activities.

Daniel: I found another hotel about ten minutes from the beach. It's much cheaper.

Maya: Is it any good?

Daniel: The reviews are actually pretty positive. It has free breakfast and Wi-Fi too.

Maya: Then why spend twice as much?

Daniel: That's what I thought. We don't need a five-star hotel. We just need somewhere clean and comfortable.

Maya: Exactly. Let's save the extra money for things we'll actually enjoy.

Daniel: Good plan. A vacation should give us great memories, not a huge credit-card bill.

Maya: Agreed. Let's book the cheaper hotel.

2. Tighten Your Belt

Sarah: Did you hear from the company about the bonus?

James: Yes. They delayed it until next quarter.

Sarah: Seriously? We were counting on that money.

James: I know. I had planned to replace my laptop.

Sarah: I was hoping we could repaint the house too.

James: I think we're going to have to **tighten our belts** for a few months.

Sarah: What do you have in mind?

James: We could stop eating out every weekend.

Sarah: That would definitely save money.

James: We also spend too much on food delivery.

Sarah: That's true. We could cook more at home.

James: And I'm going to postpone buying that new phone.

Sarah: Good idea. Your current phone still works perfectly.

James: Exactly. We don't have to stop enjoying ourselves completely.

Sarah: We could have movie nights at home instead of going to the cinema.

James: See? We can still have fun without spending a lot.

Sarah: I suppose this is just temporary.

James: Right. Once the bonus comes through, we can relax the budget again.

3. Bring Home the Bacon

Kevin: How's the new job going?

Michael: It's demanding, but I'm enjoying it.

Kevin: How are the hours?

Michael: Long. I usually get home around seven.

Kevin: That must be difficult with the family.

Michael: It can be. But I try to make time for them every evening.

Kevin: At least the salary is good.

Michael: Definitely. It's much better than my old job.

Kevin: Then maybe all those long hours are worth it.

Michael: That's how I look at it. Someone has to **bring home the bacon**.

Kevin: Are you the only one working?

Michael: No. My wife works too.

Kevin: That's helpful.

Michael: Very. We're saving for a house, so having two incomes makes a big difference.

Kevin: Do you like the new company?

Michael: Yes. The work is challenging, and there are opportunities to grow.

Kevin: Then it sounds like you made the right decision.

Michael: I think so. It's hard work, but I know I'm helping support my family and build a better future.

4. A Nest Egg

Emma: You seem really disciplined about saving money.

Rachel: I've been trying to save something from every paycheck.

Emma: How much do you save?

Rachel: It depends on the month, but I always try to put something aside.

Emma: What are you saving for?

Rachel: I'm building a **nest egg** for the future.

Emma: For retirement?

Rachel: Partly. I also want to have money available for emergencies and eventually buy a home.

Emma: That's smart. I usually spend whatever is left after paying my bills.

Rachel: I used to do exactly the same thing.

Emma: So what changed?

Rachel: One month, I had an unexpected expense and realized I had no savings at all.

Emma: That must have been stressful.

Rachel: It was. After that, I decided to make saving a habit.

Emma: Do you ever use the money?

Rachel: Only when I really need to. I try not to touch my **nest egg** for everyday spending.

Emma: I think I should start saving too.

Rachel: Start small. Even a little money saved regularly can grow over time.

Emma: You're right. I'll start with my next paycheck.

Rachel: Good. Your future self will thank you.

5. Foot the Bill

Manager: How did the client dinner go last night?

Alex: Very well. The clients were impressed.

Manager: Good. Did everything stay within the budget?

Alex: Not exactly.

Manager: What happened?

Alex: They ordered several extra dishes, and we also had dessert and coffee.

Manager: How much over budget were we?

Alex: About \$180.

Manager: That's not ideal, but it's not a disaster.

Alex: I was worried you'd be upset.

Manager: No. Building a good relationship with the clients is important.

Alex: So what should I do with the receipt?

Manager: Send it to accounting.

Alex: Will the company cover everything?

Manager: Yes. The firm will **foot the bill**.

Alex: Even the extra amount?

Manager: Yes. It was still a legitimate business expense.

Alex: Great. I'll submit everything this afternoon.

Manager: Good. But next time, check the menu and pricing before the dinner.

Alex: Absolutely. I don't want accounting asking too many questions.

Manager: Fair enough. Just make sure we get a good result from the meeting.

Alex: I think we will.

6. In the Red / In the Black

CEO: How did we perform this quarter?

CFO: Much better than last quarter.

CEO: Are we still **in the red**?

CFO: No. We finally moved **into the black**.

CEO: That's excellent news. By how much?

CFO: We made a modest profit.

CEO: What changed?

CFO: Sales increased, and we reduced several unnecessary expenses.

CEO: Did the new marketing campaign help?

CFO: Definitely. Online sales were much stronger than expected.

CEO: That's encouraging.

CFO: We still need to be careful, though.

CEO: Why?

CFO: We have several large expenses coming next quarter.

CEO: So being **in the black** doesn't mean we can start spending freely.

CFO: Exactly. It just means the company is financially healthier.

CEO: Understood. Let's continue controlling costs.

CFO: That's the safest approach.

CEO: Good work. Moving from the red into the black is a major improvement.

CFO: Now our goal is to stay there.

7. Pay Through the Nose

Tom: How was your trip?

David: Great, except for the hotel.

Tom: What was wrong with it?

David: Nothing was really wrong with the room. It was just ridiculously expensive.

Tom: How much did you pay?

David: Nearly \$250 a night.

Tom: Wow! Why was it so expensive?

David: There was a huge festival in town.

Tom: That explains it.

David: I checked several hotels, but they were all charging crazy prices.

Tom: So you really **paid through the nose**.

David: I certainly did.

Tom: Was the hotel at least in a good location?

David: Yes. I could walk almost everywhere.

Tom: That's something.

David: True, but I still think I overpaid.

Tom: Why didn't you book earlier?

David: I waited until the last minute.

Tom: There's your problem.

David: I know. I learned my lesson.

Tom: Next time, book months in advance.

David: Absolutely. I'm not paying through the nose for a hotel again.

8. Make Ends Meet

Linda: How have things been lately?

Maria: Honestly, things have been a little difficult.

Linda: Is everything okay?

Maria: We're okay, but the cost of everything has gone up.

Linda: What's been the biggest problem?

Maria: Rent, food, transportation, and school expenses for the children.

Linda: That's a lot to manage.

Maria: It is. We're doing our best, but we're mostly just trying to **make ends meet**.

Linda: Are you able to save anything?

Maria: Not really. By the end of the month, almost everything is gone.

Linda: Have you considered taking on extra work?

Maria: My husband has started working weekends.

Linda: That must be exhausting.

Maria: It is, but the extra money helps.

Linda: I hope things improve soon.

Maria: So do I. We've also started cutting unnecessary expenses.

Linda: That's probably a good idea.

Maria: We're trying to stay positive and take things one month at a time.

Linda: That's all you can do.

Maria: Exactly. As long as we can **make ends meet** and take care of the family, we'll keep going.

9. A Rainy Day Fund

Father: I noticed you've been putting money aside every month.

Sam: Yes. I'm trying to become better at saving.

Father: What are you saving for?

Sam: Nothing specific right now. I just want to be prepared for emergencies.

Father: That's a very good habit.

Sam: I didn't always think that way.

Father: What changed?

Sam: Last year my car broke down unexpectedly.

Father: How much did the repair cost?

Sam: More than I could afford at the time.

Father: So what did you do?

Sam: I had to borrow money from a friend.

Father: That can be difficult.

Sam: It was. After that, I decided I needed a **rainy day fund**.

Father: How much are you trying to save?

Sam: Eventually, I want enough to cover several months of basic expenses.

Father: That's an excellent goal.

Sam: I put some money into savings every month, even when the amount is small.

Father: That's the important part—being consistent.

Sam: Exactly. I don't want another surprise expense to put me into debt.

Father: Good thinking.

Sam: Now I feel much more secure knowing that I'm preparing for a rainy day.

Father: And when that rainy day comes, you'll be ready.

— End of chapter 7 —

CHAPTER 8

FOOD IDIOMS

Meanings • Explanations • Usage • Examples • Real-Life Dialogues

Food is one of the richest sources of idioms in English. We use everyday items from the kitchen and the table to talk about ease, difficulty, emotion, money, personality, and success. This chapter presents twenty-five essential food idioms with full explanations and extended dialogues so you can use them naturally and confidently.

How to Study This Chapter

Read each entry carefully. Notice the register and emotional tone. Then read the dialogue aloud. After finishing, choose five idioms and write your own short dialogues. Using them in real conversation is the fastest way to make them permanent.

1. A piece of cake

Meaning: Something that is very easy to do.

Short Explanation: Cake is soft, pleasant, and easy to eat. The idiom transfers that ease to any task or situation.

Usage: Informal and extremely common. Both American and British English. Avoid in very formal writing.

Examples:

- *The exam was a piece of cake.*
- *Don't worry about the presentation — it'll be a piece of cake once you practise.*
- *Installing the software was a piece of cake.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Student: *Was the driving test hard?*

Friend: *No, it was a piece of cake. I finished early and still passed first time.*

Student: *You're making me jealous. Mine is next week.*

Friend: *Just practise the parallel park. The rest really is a piece of cake.*

2. Spill the beans

Meaning: To reveal a secret, usually by accident or without intending to.

Short Explanation: Possibly from an ancient voting method that used beans; spilling them revealed the result early. Now purely figurative.

Usage: Informal. Very common. Synonym of 'let the cat out of the bag'.

Examples:

- *Don't spill the beans about the surprise party.*
- *She spilled the beans during dinner and ruined the secret.*
- *Someone spilled the beans to the press.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Sibling: *You know about the surprise, don't you?*

You: *I do, and I'm not spilling the beans. Your secret is safe with me.*

Sibling: *Good. Dad still has no idea.*

You: *And it will stay that way — unless you spill the beans yourself.*

3. Cool as a cucumber

Meaning: Very calm and composed, especially in a stressful situation.

Short Explanation: Cucumbers remain cool inside even in warm weather. The idiom describes emotional coolness under pressure.

Usage: Informal and complimentary. Both varieties of English.

Examples:

- *Even during the crisis she stayed cool as a cucumber.*
- *He's always cool as a cucumber under pressure.*
- *I don't know how she stays cool as a cucumber in front of large audiences.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Colleague: *How did you stay so calm during the presentation when the slides crashed?*

You: *I just pretended I was cool as a cucumber. Inside I was panicking, but I kept talking.*

Colleague: *Well, it worked. No one noticed.*

4. The apple of my eye

Meaning: Someone (or occasionally something) that is cherished above all others.

Short Explanation: In older English the 'apple' of the eye was the pupil, thought essential to sight. Hence something precious.

Usage: Affectionate. Common for children, partners, or treasured people. Neutral to warm.

Examples:

- *Her grandson is the apple of her eye.*
- *That old guitar is the apple of his eye.*
- *You know you're the apple of my eye.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Grandparent: *How's my favourite person?*

Child: *Hi, Grandma.*

Grandparent: *You're still the apple of my eye. Come and tell me about school.*

Child: *Okay — but only if there's cake.*

5. Bring home the bacon

Meaning: To earn money to support the household; to be the primary earner.

Short Explanation: Bacon once symbolised a substantial food staple. 'Bringing it home' meant providing for the family.

Usage: Slightly old-fashioned but still used, often humorously. Informal. More American in flavour.

Examples:

- *Someone has to bring home the bacon.*
- *She's been bringing home the bacon since she was twenty.*
- *He works two jobs to bring home the bacon.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Friend: *How's the new job?*

You: *Demanding, but it brings home the bacon. The family is covered and we can finally breathe.*

Friend: *That's the main thing.*

6. Butter someone up

Meaning: To flatter someone in order to get something from them.

Short Explanation: Butter makes food smoother and more pleasant. Flattery is imagined as 'buttering' a person so they become more agreeable.

Usage: Informal. Often slightly critical or humorous.

Examples:

- *He's only buttering you up because he wants a favour.*
- *Stop buttering me up and tell me what you need.*
- *She buttered up the boss before asking for time off.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Colleague: *You look great today. And that report you wrote was brilliant.*

You: *Okay, you're buttering me up. What do you want?*

Colleague: *Could you cover my shift on Friday?*

You: *I knew it. Fine — but you owe me.*

7. In a pickle

Meaning: In a difficult or awkward situation.

Short Explanation: Pickling preserves food in a tight, restricted space. Being 'in a pickle' means being stuck in an uncomfortable position.

Usage: Informal and common. Mild tone.

Examples:

- *I'm in a bit of a pickle — I locked my keys in the car.*
- *She found herself in a pickle when both meetings were scheduled at the same time.*
- *We're in a pickle if the funding doesn't arrive.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Friend: *You look stressed.*

You: *I'm in a pickle. I promised two different people I'd help them at the same time.*

Friend: *Want me to take one of them?*

You: *Would you? That would get me out of this pickle.*

8. Take something with a pinch (grain) of salt

Meaning: Not to believe something completely; to treat information with scepticism.

Short Explanation: Salt was once thought to make food more digestible. Taking advice or news 'with a pinch of salt' means not swallowing it whole.

Usage: Common. Neutral. Both American ('grain') and British ('pinch') forms are used.

Examples:

- *I'd take his promises with a pinch of salt.*
- *Take the rumours with a grain of salt until we have facts.*
- *She told me the story, but I took it with a pinch of salt.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Colleague: *He said the project would be finished by Friday.*

You: *I'd take that with a pinch of salt. He's been optimistic before and missed deadlines.*

Colleague: *Good point. I'll plan for next week just in case.*

9. Eat like a horse / Eat like a bird

Meaning: Eat a very large amount (horse) or a very small amount (bird).

Short Explanation: Horses consume large quantities of food; birds eat very little relative to their size. Used humorously to describe appetite.

Usage: Informal and common. Slightly humorous.

Examples:

- *He eats like a horse after training.*
- *She eats like a bird — just a few bites and she's done.*
- *Teenagers often eat like horses.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Parent: *There's no food left in the fridge.*

Teen: *Sorry — I was starving after practice. I eat like a horse on training days.*

Parent: *I'll do another shop tomorrow. Just try not to finish everything in one evening.*

10. Hard nut to crack

Meaning: A difficult problem or a person who is hard to understand or deal with.

Short Explanation: Some nuts have very hard shells that resist opening. The idiom transfers that difficulty to people or tasks.

Usage: Common. Neutral to slightly informal.

Examples:

- *That math question was a hard nut to crack.*
- *She's a hard nut to crack — very private.*
- *The new market is a hard nut to crack.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Colleague: *Have you managed to get any information out of the new client?*

You: *Not really. He's a hard nut to crack. Very polite but gives almost nothing away.*

Colleague: *Keep trying. Sometimes they open up after a few meetings.*

11. Full of beans

Meaning: Full of energy and enthusiasm; lively.

Short Explanation: Beans were once associated with energy and vitality. The expression describes someone who is lively and high-spirited.

Usage: Informal and positive. More British, but understood in American English.

Examples:

- *The children are full of beans this morning.*
- *He's always full of beans at the start of a new project.*
- *Even after the long flight she was full of beans.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Parent: *How was the party?*

Child: *Great! We played outside for hours.*

Parent: *You still look full of beans. How about calming down with a story before bed?*

Child: *Okay... one more game first?*

12. Not my cup of tea

Meaning: Not something I like or am interested in.

Short Explanation: British understatement. Tea is a national symbol; rejecting a particular 'cup' is a polite way to decline.

Usage: Polite and mild. Very British, though widely understood.

Examples:

- *Horror films are not my cup of tea.*
- *Thanks for the invitation, but camping isn't really my cup of tea.*
- *Modern art is not everyone's cup of tea.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Friend: *Want to come to the heavy-metal concert?*

You: *Thanks, but that's not my cup of tea. Have fun though — send me a photo.*

Friend: *Will do. Next time we'll pick something we both like.*

13. Cry over spilled milk

Meaning: To waste time being upset about something that has already happened and cannot be changed.

Short Explanation: Once milk is spilled, it cannot be put back in the glass. The proverb advises against useless regret.

Usage: Common advice. Neutral. Both varieties.

Examples:

- *There's no use crying over spilled milk.*
- *I know you're disappointed, but don't cry over spilled milk.*
- *We made a mistake. Let's not cry over spilled milk — let's fix it.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Colleague: *I can't believe I deleted the wrong file.*

You: *It's done. There's no use crying over spilled milk. Let's restore it from the backup.*

Colleague: *You're right. Panicking won't help.*

14. Have a lot on one's plate

Meaning: To have many responsibilities or a lot of work to do.

Short Explanation: A full plate of food represents a heavy load of tasks. The idiom describes being busy or overloaded.

Usage: Very common in both personal and professional contexts. Neutral.

Examples:

- *I have a lot on my plate this week.*
- *She already has a lot on her plate — don't give her more work.*
- *With two jobs and three children, he has a lot on his plate.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Manager: *Can you take on the new client as well?*

Employee: *I'd like to, but I already have a lot on my plate with the product launch.*

Manager: *Understood. We'll find someone else.*

Employee: *Thank you. I can support in a smaller way if needed.*

15. The icing on the cake

Meaning: An additional good thing that makes a positive situation even better.

Short Explanation: Icing (frosting) is the decorative, extra-pleasant layer on a cake. The idiom describes a bonus that improves an already good situation.

Usage: Positive and common. Neutral register.

Examples:

- *Winning the award was the icing on the cake after a successful year.*
- *The free dessert was the icing on the cake.*
- *Getting the promotion was great; the company car was the icing on the cake.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Friend: *How was the holiday?*

You: *Wonderful. Beautiful weather, great food, and then they upgraded us to a suite for free — the icing on the cake.*

Friend: *That's amazing. You deserved it.*

16. Bite off more than you can chew

Meaning: To take on more responsibility or work than you can handle.

Short Explanation: Putting too much food in your mouth makes it hard to chew. The idiom warns against over-committing.

Usage: Common cautionary advice. Neutral to informal.

Examples:

- *I think you've bitten off more than you can chew with three side projects.*
- *Don't bite off more than you can chew in your first semester.*
- *She bit off more than she could chew and had to drop two courses.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Colleague: *I'm leading two major launches and mentoring three juniors.*

Manager: *That sounds like you've bitten off more than you can chew. Let's re-prioritise.*

Colleague: *You're probably right. I was trying to prove I could handle everything.*

17. Half-baked

Meaning: Not properly planned or thought through; incomplete or poorly developed.

Short Explanation: Bread that is only half-baked is not ready to eat. The idiom criticises ideas or plans that are unfinished or poorly considered.

Usage: Informal and critical. Common in business and everyday talk.

Examples:

- *That's a half-baked idea — we need more research.*
- *I don't want to present a half-baked proposal.*
- *His explanation sounded half-baked.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Team lead: *Have you finished the strategy document?*

Analyst: *It's still a bit half-baked. I need another day to check the numbers.*

Team lead: *Better to delay than present something half-baked. Take the time.*

18. Sell like hot cakes

Meaning: To sell very quickly and in large numbers.

Short Explanation: Hot cakes (pancakes) were popular and sold fast at fairs. The idiom describes rapid commercial success.

Usage: Common in business and retail contexts. Neutral to positive.

Examples:

- *The new phone is selling like hot cakes.*
- *Tickets sold like hot cakes once the reviews came out.*
- *Her books always sell like hot cakes.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Manager: *How are the new headphones doing?*

Sales: *They're selling like hot cakes. We may need to reorder by Friday.*

Manager: *Excellent. Keep the momentum going.*

19. Egg someone on

Meaning: To encourage someone to do something, often something risky or unwise.

Short Explanation: The origin is uncertain, but the expression is long-established. It usually has a negative or cautionary tone.

Usage: Informal. Often critical of the person doing the encouraging.

Examples:

- *His friends egged him on until he jumped.*
- *Don't egg her on — she's already nervous enough.*
- *They kept egging him on to quit his job.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Friend: *I can't believe he actually did it.*

You: *His mates egged him on all evening. Without them he would never have taken the risk.*

Friend: *Some friends.*

20. Put all your eggs in one basket

Meaning: To risk everything on a single plan or opportunity; to have no alternative.

Short Explanation: If you carry all your eggs in one basket and drop it, you lose everything. The proverb advises spreading risk.

Usage: Common in business, finance, and life advice. Neutral.

Examples:

- *Don't put all your eggs in one basket — apply to several universities.*
- *Investors who put all their eggs in one basket suffered badly.*
- *I'm not putting all my eggs in one basket this time.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Advisor: *You're only applying to one company?*

Graduate: *It's my dream job.*

Advisor: *I understand, but don't put all your eggs in one basket. Apply to a few more as a safety net.*

Graduate: *You're right. I'll send three more applications this week.*

21. That's the way the cookie crumbles

Meaning: That's how things happen; we have to accept the situation.

Short Explanation: Cookies break in unpredictable ways. The expression is a resigned acceptance of reality.

Usage: Informal and philosophical. More American, but understood widely.

Examples:

- *We lost the contract. That's the way the cookie crumbles.*
- *I didn't get the part. That's just the way the cookie crumbles.*
- *Sometimes you win, sometimes you don't — that's the way the cookie crumbles.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Colleague: *I really thought we had that deal.*

You: *So did I. But that's the way the cookie crumbles. We'll do better next time.*

Colleague: *Yeah. No point dwelling on it.*

22. Have bigger fish to fry

Meaning: To have more important things to do or worry about.

Short Explanation: Frying larger fish represents dealing with more significant matters. The idiom dismisses smaller concerns.

Usage: Informal. Common when prioritising.

Examples:

- *I can't deal with that now — I have bigger fish to fry.*
- *She ignored the gossip because she had bigger fish to fry.*
- *We have bigger fish to fry than arguing about the coffee machine.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Colleague: *Someone took my lunch from the fridge again.*

You: *Annoying, but we have bigger fish to fry today. The client presentation is in two hours.*

Colleague: *You're right. I'll deal with the fridge thief later.*

23. Sour grapes

Meaning: Pretending to dislike something because you cannot have it.

Short Explanation: From Aesop's fable of the fox who, unable to reach the grapes, declared them sour. The idiom describes false disdain.

Usage: Slightly critical. Common for jealousy or disappointment.

Examples:

- *His criticism of the award sounds like sour grapes.*
- *Don't listen — it's just sour grapes.*
- *She said she never wanted the job anyway, but it sounded like sour grapes.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Friend: *He keeps saying the competition was unfair.*

You: *He only started saying that after he lost. Sounds like sour grapes to me.*

Friend: *I thought the same.*

24. A recipe for disaster

Meaning: A situation or combination of factors that is very likely to end badly.

Short Explanation: A recipe lists ingredients and steps. A 'recipe for disaster' combines the wrong elements and guarantees trouble.

Usage: Common warning. Neutral to informal.

Examples:

- *Leaving him in charge alone is a recipe for disaster.*
- *Mixing those two chemicals is a recipe for disaster.*
- *No plan and no budget is a recipe for disaster.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Manager: *We're launching without testing the payment system.*

Developer: *That's a recipe for disaster. One failure and we'll lose customer trust.*

Manager: *You're right. Let's delay by a week and do proper testing.*

25. Food for thought

Meaning: Something worth thinking about seriously; an idea that stimulates reflection.

Short Explanation: Just as food nourishes the body, interesting ideas nourish the mind. The idiom invites careful consideration.

Usage: Neutral and common in both spoken and written English.

Examples:

- *Your suggestion has given me food for thought.*
- *The documentary provided plenty of food for thought.*
- *That's interesting food for thought — let me consider it overnight.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Colleague: *What if we switched the whole campaign to video instead of static ads?*

You: *Hmm. That's food for thought. I hadn't considered going all-in on video.*

Colleague: *Sleep on it and we can discuss tomorrow.*

You: *I will. Good idea.*

Chapter Review

Food idioms allow us to talk about ease, difficulty, emotion, risk, success, and personality with vivid, everyday images. The twenty-five expressions in this chapter cover the most useful and frequently heard patterns.

Practice tip: Choose five idioms that feel most relevant to your life or work. Write a short paragraph or dialogue for each. Then try to use at least one in a real conversation this week.

— End of Chapter 8 —

CHAPTER 9

RELATIONSHIPS IDIOMS

Meanings • Explanations • Usage • Examples • Real-Life Dialogues

These expressions describe connection, conflict, loyalty, and the end of relationships. They are essential for talking about friendship, romance, family bonds, and professional relationships with natural colour and accuracy.

How to Study This Chapter

Read each entry carefully. Notice the register and tone. Read the dialogue aloud. Then choose five idioms and write your own short dialogues. Using them in real conversation is the fastest way to make them permanent.

1. Hit it off

Meaning: To quickly become good friends or have a strong connection with someone.

Short Explanation: Immediate positive chemistry between people.

Usage: Informal and positive. Common.

Examples:

- *I met Sarah yesterday and we immediately hit it off.*
- *They hit it off from the first meeting.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Friend: *How did you find your roommate?*

You: *We hit it off right away.*

2. See eye to eye

Meaning: To agree with someone; to have the same opinion.

Short Explanation: When two people look at each other and share the same view.

Usage: Common for both agreement and disagreement. Neutral.

Examples:

- *My brother and I don't always see eye to eye on politics.*
- *I'm glad we see eye to eye on the main strategy.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Partner: *I think we should wait another year.*

You: *I actually see eye to eye with you on that.*

3. On the same wavelength

Meaning: To think or understand things in a similar way.

Short Explanation: Radio metaphor: same frequency means clear communication.

Usage: Positive. Common in teamwork and friendship.

Examples:

- *They are on the same wavelength.*
- *We work well because we are on the same wavelength.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Colleague: *Why do you two collaborate so easily?*

You: *We're on the same wavelength.*

4. Thick as thieves

Meaning: Very close friends who share secrets and trust each other.

Short Explanation: Thieves must trust one another completely.

Usage: Informal and warm. Common.

Examples:

- *Those two are thick as thieves.*
- *They've been thick as thieves since school.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Parent: *They do everything together.*

You: *Thick as thieves.*

5. Go through thick and thin

Meaning: To stay loyal during good and bad times.

Short Explanation: Thick and thin times = good and bad periods.

Usage: Strong loyalty. Common.

Examples:

- *True friends go through thick and thin together.*
- *They have gone through thick and thin.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Friend: *Will you still support him?*

You: *We've been through thick and thin. Of course.*

6. Give someone the cold shoulder

Meaning: To ignore someone intentionally.

Short Explanation: Turning the shoulder away is a physical rejection.

Usage: Common for social exclusion. Neutral to critical.

Examples:

- *She gave him the cold shoulder after the argument.*
- *He got the cold shoulder at the party.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Friend: *Why is she ignoring you?*

You: *She's giving me the cold shoulder.*

7. Patch things up

Meaning: To fix a broken relationship.

Short Explanation: Patching a hole repairs it. Applied to emotional repair.

Usage: Common for reconciliation. Neutral.

Examples:

- *They argued but now they've patched things up.*
- *It's time to patch things up.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Colleague: *Are they speaking again?*

You: *Yes, they patched things up.*

8. Call it quits

Meaning: To end a relationship.

Short Explanation: Agree that it is finished.

Usage: Informal. Common for romantic and business endings.

Examples:

- *After many fights they decided to call it quits.*
- *We called it quits on the partnership.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Friend: *Are you still together?*

You: *No. We called it quits last month.*

9. A match made in heaven

Meaning: A perfect couple or partnership.

Short Explanation: Heavenly perfection applied to human pairs.

Usage: Warm and positive. Common.

Examples:

- *Everyone says they are a match made in heaven.*
- *Their collaboration is a match made in heaven.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Guest: *They look perfect together.*

Host: *A match made in heaven.*

10. Get on like a house on fire

Meaning: To become very friendly very quickly.

Short Explanation: A fire spreads rapidly and intensely. Applied to rapid, warm friendship.

Usage: More British/Australian but understood widely. Informal.

Examples:

- *We got on like a house on fire when we first met.*
- *They got on like a house on fire.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Host: *How did you find your roommate?*

Tenant: *We got on like a house on fire.*

11. Burn bridges

Meaning: To damage a relationship so badly that it cannot be repaired.

Short Explanation: Destroying a bridge prevents any return journey.

Usage: Cautionary. Common career and personal advice. Neutral.

Examples:

- *Don't burn bridges when you resign.*
- *He burned bridges with half the industry.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Mentor: *You're angry about how they treated you.*

You: *Very.*

Mentor: *Feel the anger, but don't burn bridges.*

12. Two peas in a pod

Meaning: Two people who are very similar or always together.

Short Explanation: Peas in the same pod look alike and stay close.

Usage: Affectionate. Common for close friends or siblings.

Examples:

- *My best friend and I are like two peas in a pod.*
- *They're two peas in a pod — same humour, same interests.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Colleague: *Those two are inseparable.*

You: *Two peas in a pod.*

13. Keep someone at arm's length

Meaning: To avoid becoming too close to someone emotionally.

Short Explanation: Physical distance becomes emotional distance.

Usage: Common for self-protection. Neutral.

Examples:

- *She keeps most people at arm's length.*
- *I prefer to keep new colleagues at arm's length until I know them.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Friend: *Why don't you invite her more often?*

You: *I like her, but I keep most people at arm's length at first.*

14. Take someone for granted

Meaning: To not appreciate someone enough; to assume they will always be there.

Short Explanation: Failing to value a person's contribution or presence.

Usage: Common warning in relationships. Neutral to critical.

Examples:

- *Don't take your friends for granted.*
- *She felt taken for granted in the relationship.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Partner: *You never say thank you any more.*

You: *You're right. I don't want to take you for granted.*

15. Lose touch

Meaning: To stop communicating with someone over time.

Short Explanation: Contact fades and the connection weakens.

Usage: Very common. Neutral and often slightly regretful.

Examples:

- *We lost touch after finishing school.*
- *I don't want us to lose touch.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Old friend: *It's been years!*

You: *I know. We completely lost touch. How have you been*

IDIOMS RELATED TO RELATIONSHIPS

1. Hit it off

Meaning: To quickly become good friends or have a strong connection with someone.

Example: I met Sarah yesterday, and we immediately hit it off.

2. See eye to eye

Meaning: To agree with someone.

Example: My brother and I don't always see eye to eye on politics.

3. On the same wavelength

Meaning: To think or understand things in a similar way.

Example: They work so well together because they are on the same wavelength.

4. Thick as thieves

Meaning: Very close friends who share secrets and trust each other.

Example: Those two are thick as thieves—they do everything together.

5. Break the ice

Meaning: To start a conversation in a social situation to make people feel comfortable.

Example: He told a joke to break the ice at the meeting.

6. Tie the knot

Meaning: To get married.

Example: After dating for five years, they finally tied the knot.

7. Go through thick and thin

Meaning: To stay loyal during good and bad times.

Example: True friends go through thick and thin together.

8. Wear your heart on your sleeve

Meaning: To openly show your emotions.

Example: She wears her heart on her sleeve, so everyone knows how she feels.

9. Two peas in a pod

Meaning: Two people who are very similar or always together.

Example: My best friend and I are like two peas in a pod.

10. Give someone the cold shoulder

Meaning: To ignore someone intentionally.

Example: After their argument, she gave him the cold shoulder.

11. Patch things up

Meaning: To fix a broken relationship.

Example: They argued last week, but now they've patched things up.

12. Call it quits

Meaning: To end a relationship.

Example: After many fights, they decided to call it quits.

13. A match made in heaven

Meaning: A perfect couple or partnership.

Example: Everyone says they are a match made in heaven.

14. Get on like a house on fire

Meaning: To become very friendly very quickly.

Example: We got on like a house on fire when we first met.

15. Turn one's back on

Meaning: To abandon or stop supporting someone.

Example: He turned his back on his old friends.

16. Be on good terms

Meaning: To have a friendly relationship with someone.

Example: After the breakup, they are still on good terms.

17. Fall out with someone

Meaning: To have an argument and stop being friendly.

Example: I fell out with my best friend over a small issue.

18. Make up

Meaning: To become friends again after an argument.

Example: They had a fight but made up the next day.

19. Keep someone at arm's length

Meaning: To avoid becoming too close to someone emotionally.

Example: She keeps most people at arm's length.

20. Take someone for granted

Meaning: To not appreciate someone enough.

Example: Don't take your friends for granted.

21. Build bridges

Meaning: To improve a damaged relationship.

Example: They are trying to build bridges after the disagreement.

22. Burn bridges

Meaning: To destroy relationships so you cannot go back.

Example: Leaving the job angrily burned bridges with the company.

23. Be like chalk and cheese

Meaning: Two people who are completely different.

Example: My brother and I are like chalk and cheese.

24. In good/bad books

Meaning: To be liked or disliked by someone.

Example: He is in my good books after helping me.

25. Get along like a house on fire

Meaning: To become very friendly very quickly.

Example: They got along like a house on fire at school.

26. Have a falling-out

Meaning: A serious disagreement between friends.

Example: They had a falling-out over money.

27. Patch up differences

Meaning: To resolve problems in a relationship.

Example: They patched up their differences after talking.

28. Stick together

Meaning: To support each other no matter what.

Example: True friends stick together in hard times.

29. Cross paths

Meaning: To meet someone by chance.

Example: We crossed paths again after many years.

30. Speak the same language

Meaning: To understand each other well.

Example: We work well together because we speak the same language.

31. Lose touch

Meaning: To stop communicating with someone over time.

Example: We lost touch after finishing school.

32. Get back together

Meaning: To start a romantic relationship again after breaking up.

Example: They broke up last year but got back together recently.

33. Double-cross someone

Meaning: To betray someone who trusts you.

Example: He double-crossed his friend in business.

34. Make things worse

Meaning: To worsen a relationship or situation.

Example: Arguing only made things worse between them.

35. Win someone over

Meaning: To make someone like or support you.

Example: He won her over with kindness.

36. Have chemistry

Meaning: To have a strong natural connection (often romantic or friendship).

Example: They have great chemistry when they talk.

37. Play hard to get

Meaning: To act uninterested to make someone more interested.

Example: She played hard to get, but he kept trying.

38. Turn against someone

Meaning: To start opposing or disliking someone you once supported.

Example: Some friends turned against him after the argument.

39. Go separate ways

Meaning: To end a relationship and move in different directions.

Example: After college, they went separate ways.

Real-Life Dialogue

Emma: You know, I've been thinking about how relationships change over time.

Daniel: What made you think about that?

Emma: I ran into Sarah yesterday. We hadn't seen each other since university.

Daniel: Really? How was it?

Emma: Great, actually. We started talking, and we immediately **hit it off** again, just like we did when we first met.

Daniel: That's nice. Sometimes you meet someone after years apart and the connection is still there.

Emma: Exactly. We talked for hours. We were completely **on the same wavelength** about almost everything.

Daniel: Was she still close to Emily?

Emma: Yes! Those two are **thick as thieves**. They still tell each other everything.

Daniel: I remember them. They were always together.

Emma: Exactly. They're like **two peas in a pod**.

Daniel: It's amazing how some friendships survive for so many years.

Emma: True. Although Sarah told me she and another friend had a serious **falling-out** last year.

Daniel: What happened?

Emma: They disagreed about money, and things got ugly.

Daniel: Did they stop talking?

Emma: For several months. She said her friend even **gave her the cold shoulder** whenever they saw each other.

Daniel: That must have been uncomfortable.

Emma: It was. But eventually, they sat down and talked. They decided to **patch things up** and **patch up their differences**.

Daniel: Good for them.

Emma: Yes. Sarah said they realized that neither of them wanted to lose such a long friendship over one argument.

Daniel: I understand that. My brother and I don't always **see eye to eye**, especially when it comes to money.

Emma: Really?

Daniel: Oh, yes. We're completely different. We're **like chalk and cheese**.

Emma: But you're still close?

Daniel: Very close. We disagree, but we usually manage to **stick together** when something important happens.

Emma: That's what matters.

Daniel: Exactly. A relationship doesn't have to be perfect.

Emma: True. Some people think that if you disagree, the relationship is finished.

Daniel: That's not true at all. Real friends **go through thick and thin** together.

Emma: I agree. And you should never **take someone for granted** just because they've always been there.

Daniel: That's an important lesson.

Emma: Sarah said something similar. She told me that she used to **wear her heart on her sleeve**, so everyone always knew exactly how she felt.

Daniel: Is she still like that?

Emma: Yes, but she's learned to be more careful.

Daniel: I'm the opposite. I usually **keep people at arm's length** until I know I can trust them.

Emma: Why?

Daniel: I've had some bad experiences.

Emma: I understand. But sometimes you have to let people get close.

Daniel: I know. I'm working on that.

Emma: What about your old friends from school?

Daniel: Most of us **lost touch** after graduation.

Emma: That's sad.

Daniel: It happens. We all moved to different cities and eventually **went separate ways**.

Emma: Did you ever **cross paths** with any of them again?

Daniel: Actually, yes. I ran into Mark at a conference three years ago.

Emma: No way!

Daniel: It was completely unexpected. We started talking, and it felt like no time had passed.

Emma: That must have been wonderful.

Daniel: It was. We discovered that we still **spoke the same language**, even though our lives had changed.

Emma: What do you mean?

Daniel: We understood each other's humor, our way of thinking, and even our problems.

Emma: That's special.

Daniel: It really was.

Emma: What about your relationships at work?

Daniel: Mostly good. There was one colleague I didn't get along with, though.

Emma: What happened?

Daniel: We had a disagreement over a project, and he started **turning against me**.

Emma: Did the other people support him?

Daniel: At first, some of them did. But eventually, they realized what had really happened.

Emma: Did you two ever fix things?

Daniel: Yes. Our manager encouraged us to **build bridges** instead of continuing the conflict.

Emma: That was good advice.

Daniel: Definitely. We apologized and started working together again.

Emma: So now you're **on good terms**?

Daniel: Yes. We're not best friends, but we respect each other.

Emma: That's better than having a permanent enemy.

Daniel: Absolutely. I've learned not to **burn bridges**, especially in professional relationships.

Emma: Exactly. You never know when you might need someone again.

Daniel: Speaking of relationships, what's happening with your sister?

Emma: She and her boyfriend finally decided to **tie the knot**.

Daniel: Really? After all these years?

Emma: Yes. They've been together for six years.

Daniel: They seem like a **match made in heaven**.

Emma: Everyone says that. They have so much **chemistry**.

Daniel: I noticed that the last time I saw them.

Emma: They also **get on like a house on fire**. They can talk for hours.

Daniel: That's a good sign.

Emma: Definitely.

Daniel: I heard another couple we know broke up recently.

Emma: You mean James and Olivia?

Daniel: Yes.

Emma: They decided to **call it quits**.

Daniel: What happened?

Emma: They kept having the same arguments and wanted different things from life.

Daniel: That's difficult.

Emma: It was, but I think they made the right decision.

Daniel: Sometimes ending a relationship is better than staying in an unhappy one.

Emma: Exactly. Although I heard they may **get back together**.

Daniel: Seriously?

Emma: Apparently, they've been talking again.

Daniel: Well, maybe they needed some time apart.

Emma: Maybe.

Daniel: Did they **make up**?

Emma: I think so.

Daniel: Hopefully they've learned from their mistakes.

Emma: I hope so too.

Daniel: Sometimes people **play hard to get** when they want someone to chase them.

Emma: That's true, but I don't think games are a good foundation for a relationship.

Daniel: Neither do I.

Emma: It's much better to be honest.

Daniel: Absolutely.

Emma: One thing I've learned is that when someone truly cares about you, they shouldn't suddenly **turn their back on** you when times get difficult.

Daniel: Agreed.

Emma: And they shouldn't **double-cross** you either.

Daniel: Definitely not. Betrayal can destroy years of trust.

Emma: I once knew two business partners who were very close.

Daniel: What happened to them?

Emma: One secretly made a deal with a competitor. He completely **double-crossed** his partner.

Daniel: That's terrible.

Emma: It got even worse because they started arguing publicly.

Daniel: That probably **made things worse**.

Emma: Exactly. Eventually, they stopped working together.

Daniel: Some relationships are difficult to repair after that.

Emma: True.

Daniel: But people can sometimes **build bridges** again if both sides genuinely want to.

Emma: Yes. Forgiveness and communication can change a lot.

Daniel: I think that's the secret to strong relationships.

Emma: What is?

Daniel: Listening, respecting each other, and knowing when to apologize.

Emma: I agree.

Daniel: And sometimes you have to **win someone over** rather than trying to force them to agree with you.

Emma: That's true. Kindness can change people's minds.

Daniel: Exactly.

Emma: You know, talking about all these relationships has made me realize something.

Daniel: What?

Emma: People don't always need to be similar to get along.

Daniel: Definitely.

Emma: Some people are **like chalk and cheese**, but they still make wonderful friends.

Daniel: And sometimes people who seem completely different turn out to be **two peas in a pod**.

Emma: Exactly.

Daniel: The important thing is finding people you can trust.

Emma: And appreciating them while they're in your life.

Daniel: Yes. Because once you **lose touch**, it can be surprisingly difficult to reconnect.

Emma: Fortunately, sometimes you **cross paths** again.

Daniel: And when you do, you might discover that you still **speak the same language**.

Emma: Just like you and Mark.

Daniel: Exactly.

Emma: Maybe that's what makes relationships so interesting.

Daniel: What?

Emma: They change, they grow, sometimes they break, and sometimes they become stronger.

Daniel: And through all of it, the best relationships are the ones where people **stick together**.

Emma: I couldn't agree more.

Chapter Review

These idioms will help you sound natural and precise. Practise five of them this week in real conversations or writing.

— End of Chapter 9 —

CHAPTER 10

TIME IDIOMS

Time and human connections generate some of the most frequently used idioms in English. These expressions help speakers talk about urgency, patience, loyalty, conflict, and closeness.

Time generates many of the most frequently used idioms in English. These expressions help speakers talk about urgency, patience, rarity, delay, and the feeling that time is moving too quickly or too slowly.

1. Time flies

Meaning: Time passes very quickly.

Short Explanation: From the Latin 'tempus fugit'. Almost universal observation about the speed of pleasant or busy periods.

Usage: Extremely common. Neutral. Often followed by 'when you're having fun'.

Examples:

- *Time flies when you're busy.*
- *Can you believe it's already December? Time flies.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Colleague: *We've been working together five years already.*

You: *I know. Time flies. It feels like last month.*

2. In the nick of time

Meaning: Just before it is too late.

Short Explanation: 'Nick' once meant a critical moment. The expression describes last-minute success.

Usage: Common for last-minute arrivals or completions. Neutral.

Examples:

- *He arrived in the nick of time to catch the bus.*
- *We finished in the nick of time.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Friend: *Did you make the deadline?*

You: *In the nick of time.*

3. Against the clock

Meaning: Working with a limited amount of time; racing a deadline.

Short Explanation: The clock is the opponent. Every minute counts.

Usage: Common in work, sports, and emergency contexts. Neutral.

Examples:

- *We worked against the clock to deliver on time.*
- *The team is racing against the clock.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Producer: *The broadcast starts in forty minutes.*

Editor: *We're working against the clock.*

4. Once in a blue moon

Meaning: Something that happens very rarely.

Short Explanation: A blue moon is the second full moon in a calendar month — an uncommon event.

Usage: Informal and colorful. Common in conversation.

Examples:

- *I only eat fast food once in a blue moon.*
- *We see each other once in a blue moon these days.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Sarah: *Do you still play tennis?*

Mark: *Once in a blue moon. Work has taken over.*

5. Better late than never

Meaning: It is better to do something late than not to do it at all.

Short Explanation: A pragmatic acceptance that delayed action is still preferable to inaction.

Usage: Very common. Can be encouraging or mildly reproachful.

Examples:

- *You finally submitted the report — better late than never.*
- *He apologized after two years. Better late than never.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Colleague: *Sorry this feedback is three weeks late.*

You: *Better late than never.*

6. Around the clock

Meaning: All day and all night; continuously.

Short Explanation: The clock hands go full circle.

Usage: Common for continuous activity. Neutral.

Examples:

- *The doctors worked around the clock.*
- *The factory runs around the clock.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Reporter: *How long did the rescue take?*

Official: *Teams worked around the clock.*

7. At the eleventh hour

Meaning: At the last possible moment.

Short Explanation: The eleventh hour is the final hour before twelve.

Usage: Common for last-minute action. Neutral.

Examples:

- *He completed the work at the eleventh hour.*
- *The agreement was reached at the eleventh hour.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Manager: *When did they finally approve?*

Lead: *At the eleventh hour.*

8. In no time

Meaning: Very quickly.

Short Explanation: So fast that no time seems to have passed.

Usage: Informal and positive. Common.

Examples:

- *She finished the task in no time.*
- *We'll be there in no time.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Parent: *How long will homework take?*

Child: *In no time.*

9. Call it a day

Meaning: Stop working for the day; decide that enough has been done.

Short Explanation: Literally deciding that the working day is finished.

Usage: Very common at the end of sessions. Neutral to informal.

Examples:

- *We've done enough. Let's call it a day.*
- *After six hours of hiking we called it a day.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Lead: *Any last changes?*

Designer: *Minor tweaks.*

Lead: *They can wait. Let's call it a day.*

10. Kill time

Meaning: Spend time doing something while waiting.

Short Explanation: Using activity to make waiting pass more quickly.

Usage: Informal. Common.

Examples:

- *I played a game to kill time before dinner.*
- *We killed time in the café until the train arrived.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Friend: *The movie starts in forty minutes.*

You: *Let's kill time with a coffee.*

11. Make up for lost time

Meaning: Do something faster or more intensively because time was wasted earlier.

Short Explanation: Compensating for previous delay.

Usage: Common after delays or interruptions. Neutral.

Examples:

- *He studied hard to make up for lost time.*
- *We're working overtime to make up for lost time.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Manager: *The project was delayed two weeks.*

Lead: *We'll make up for lost time by adding extra shifts.*

12. A race against time

Meaning: A situation where you must hurry to succeed before a deadline.

Short Explanation: Time is the competitor.

Usage: Common for urgent situations. Neutral.

Examples:

- *Finding a solution became a race against time.*
- *It was a race against time to reach the hospital.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Doctor: *How long do we have?*

Nurse: *It's a race against time.*

13. Pressed for time

Meaning: Having very little time available.

Short Explanation: Feeling the pressure of a tight schedule.

Usage: Common in professional and everyday talk. Neutral.

Examples:

- *I cannot talk now because I am pressed for time.*
- *We're pressed for time, so let's keep this short.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Colleague: *Can we discuss this now?*

You: *I'm pressed for time — can it wait until after lunch?*

14. Time will tell

Meaning: The future will show the truth or the result.

Short Explanation: Only the passage of time will reveal the outcome.

Usage: Common when outcomes are uncertain. Neutral.

Examples:

- *Time will tell if our plan succeeds.*
- *We'll see — time will tell.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Friend: *Do you think they'll stay together?*

You: *Time will tell.*

15. Take your time

Meaning: Do something without rushing; there is no need to hurry.

Short Explanation: Permission or advice to proceed at a comfortable pace.

Usage: Very common. Polite and reassuring.

Examples:

- *Take your time and make the right choice.*
- *No rush — take your time.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Clerk: *I need a moment to check the system.*

Customer: *Take your time.*

Better late than never

Meaning: It is better to do something late than not to do it at all.

Short Explanation: A pragmatic acceptance that delayed action is still preferable to inaction.

Usage: Very common. Can be encouraging or mildly reproachful. Neutral.

Examples:

- *You finally submitted the report — better late than never.*
- *He apologized after two years. Better late than never, I suppose.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Colleague: *Sorry this feedback is three weeks late.*

You: *Better late than never. At least I have it before the final revision.*

Kill two birds with one stone

Meaning: To achieve two goals with a single action or effort.

Short Explanation: Literal image of efficiency: one throw solves two problems. Now purely figurative.

Usage: Extremely common. Positive and practical. Both varieties. Note: some prefer alternative phrasing for sensitivity, but the idiom remains widespread.

Examples:

- *By working remotely I kill two birds with one stone – I save commute time and spend more time with family.*
- *The meeting killed two birds with one stone: we approved the budget and assigned owners.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Friend: *Why are you studying at the café?*

You: *I kill two birds with one stone – I get my work done and I support a local business.*

In the same boat

Meaning: In the same difficult situation as someone else.

Short Explanation: Shared predicament: everyone is in one boat facing the same conditions.

Usage: Empathetic and common. Neutral. Both US and UK.

Examples:

- *We're all in the same boat with these budget cuts.*
- *Don't worry – I'm in the same boat.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Colleague: *I can't believe how expensive childcare has become.*

You: *Tell me about it. We're all in the same boat.*

Burn bridges

Meaning: To damage a relationship so badly that it cannot be repaired, often by leaving on bad terms.

Short Explanation: Destroying a bridge prevents any return journey. Applied to professional and personal relationships.

Usage: Cautionary. Common career advice. Neutral.

Examples:

- *Don't burn bridges when you resign – you may need references later.*
- *He burned bridges with half the industry.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Mentor: *You're angry about how they treated you.*

You: *Very.*

Mentor: *Feel the anger, but don't burn bridges. Leave professionally.*

See eye to eye

Meaning: To agree with someone; to have the same opinion.

Short Explanation: When two people look at each other directly and share the same view.

Usage: Common for both agreement and disagreement ('don't see eye to eye'). Neutral.

Examples:

- *We don't always see eye to eye, but we respect each other.*
- *I'm glad we see eye to eye on the main strategy.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Partner: *I think we should wait another year before buying.*

You: *I actually see eye to eye with you on that. The market feels uncertain.*

Get on like a house on fire

Meaning: To become friends very quickly and get along extremely well.

Short Explanation: A house on fire spreads rapidly and with intensity. Applied to rapid, warm friendship.

Usage: More British and Australian, but understood in American English. Informal and positive.

Examples:

- *They got on like a house on fire from the first meeting.*
- *I was nervous, but we got on like a house on fire.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Host: *How did you find your new roommate?*

Tenant: *We got on like a house on fire. It feels like we've known each other for years.*

A shoulder to cry on

Meaning: Someone who listens with sympathy when you are upset.

Short Explanation: Physical comfort of leaning on a shoulder becomes emotional support.

Usage: Warm and supportive. Common in personal contexts. Neutral.

Examples:

- *Thanks for being a shoulder to cry on.*
- *Everyone needs a shoulder to cry on sometimes.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Friend: *I feel terrible about the breakup.*

You: *I'm here. You need a shoulder to cry on – I'm happy to be that.*

Time flies

Meaning: Time passes very quickly.

Short Explanation: From the Latin 'tempus fugit'. Almost universal observation about the speed of pleasant or busy periods.

Usage: Extremely common. Neutral. Often followed by 'when you're having fun'.

Examples:

- *Time flies when you're busy.*
- *Can you believe it's already December? Time flies.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Colleague: *We've been working together five years already.*

You: *I know. Time flies. It feels like last month.*

Against the clock

Meaning: Trying to finish something before a deadline; racing to beat a time limit.

Short Explanation: The clock is the opponent. Every minute counts.

Usage: Common in work, sports, and emergency contexts. Neutral.

Examples:

- *We worked against the clock to deliver on time.*
- *The team is racing against the clock.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Producer: *The broadcast starts in forty minutes.*

Editor: *We're working against the clock. The final cut will be ready with five minutes to spare.*

IDIOMS EXPRESSIONS RELATED TO TIME

1. Time flies

Meaning: Time passes very quickly.

Example: Time flies when you are enjoying your holiday.

2. In the nick of time

Meaning: Just before it is too late.

Example: He arrived in the nick of time to catch the bus.

3. Against the clock

Meaning: Working with a limited amount of time.

Example: The students were working against the clock to finish the exam.

4. Once in a blue moon

Meaning: Something that happens very rarely.

Example: I go to the cinema once in a blue moon.

5. Better late than never

Meaning: Doing something late is better than not doing it.

Example: She started studying English at 25; better late than never.

6. Around the clock

Meaning: All day and all night.

Example: The doctors worked around the clock to help people.

7. At the eleventh hour

Meaning: At the last possible moment.

Example: He completed the work at the eleventh hour.

8. In no time

Meaning: Very quickly.

Example: She finished the task in no time.

9. From time to time

Meaning: Occasionally; sometimes.

Example: I visit my grandparents from time to time.

10. Time is money

Meaning: Time is valuable and should not be wasted.

Example: Successful people know that time is money.

11. Call it a day

Meaning: Stop working for the day.

Example: We finished our work and called it a day.

12. Kill time

Meaning: Spend time doing something while waiting.

Example: I played a game to kill time before dinner.

13. Make up for lost time

Meaning: Do something faster because you wasted time before.

Example: He studied hard to make up for lost time.

14. Long time no see

Meaning: Used when meeting someone after a long time.

Example: Long time no see! How are you?

15. Have the time of your life

Meaning: Enjoy yourself very much.

Example: We had the time of our lives at the festival.

16. Time after time

Meaning: Again and again.

Example: She helped me time after time.

17. Ahead of your time

Meaning: Having ideas that are more modern than others.

Example: His inventions were ahead of his time.

18. Behind the times

Meaning: Old-fashioned or not modern.

Example: That phone is behind the times.

19. Bide your time

Meaning: Wait patiently for the right opportunity.

Example: He is biding his time before making a decision.

20. A matter of time

Meaning: Something will happen sooner or later.

Example: It is only a matter of time before he succeeds.

21. In the meantime

Meaning: During the time before something happens.

Example: I will study; in the meantime, you can prepare dinner.

22. Time and again

Meaning: Many times repeatedly.

Example: He has proved his talent time and again.

23. Have time on your hands

Meaning: Have free time.

Example: I have time on my hands during the weekend.

24. Take your time

Meaning: Do something without rushing.

Example: Take your time and make the right choice.

25. Pressed for time

Meaning: Having very little time available.

Example: I cannot talk now because I am pressed for time.

26. Time will tell

Meaning: The future will show the truth.

Example: Time will tell if our plan succeeds.

27. Turn back the clock

Meaning: Return to the past.

Example: We cannot turn back the clock and change history.

28. The sands of time

Meaning: The passing of time.

Example: Great achievements remain in the sands of time.

29. Live on borrowed time

Meaning: Continue existing after expecting something to end.

Example: The old machine is living on borrowed time.

30. A race against time

Meaning: A situation where you must hurry to succeed.

Example: Finding a solution became a race against time.

Real-Life Dialogue

Daniel: Long time no see, Michael! How have you been?

Michael: Daniel! Wow, it really is a **long time no see**. I can't believe how quickly the years have passed.

Daniel: I know. **Time flies** when life gets busy. It feels like we were sitting in the same classroom just yesterday.

Michael: Exactly. After graduation, everything changed so quickly. Work, family, responsibilities—it all happened at once.

Daniel: What have you been doing these days?

Michael: I started a small technology business about three years ago.

Daniel: Really? I didn't know that. How is it going?

Michael: It's going well now, but the beginning was difficult. There were so many problems to solve, and we were always **against the clock**.

Daniel: What kind of problems?

Michael: Everything from finding customers to developing the product. Last year, we had a major project that had to be completed within two weeks.

Daniel: Two weeks? That sounds impossible.

Michael: It almost was. We worked **around the clock** for several days.

Daniel: Seriously?

Michael: Yes. We were under so much pressure that everyone was exhausted.

Daniel: So how did you finish?

Michael: We finally delivered the project **at the eleventh hour**.

Daniel: Wow. Literally at the last possible moment.

Michael: Exactly. We sent the final version five minutes before the deadline.

Daniel: You must have been relieved.

Michael: I was. We had been working on it **time after time**, checking every detail again and again.

Daniel: I can imagine.

Michael: But you know what? The client loved it.

Daniel: Then all that hard work was worth it.

Michael: Absolutely. Sometimes you just have to keep going.

Daniel: That reminds me of something I learned recently. I used to think that if I didn't start something early, there was no point starting at all.

Michael: What changed your mind?

Daniel: I started studying English seriously when I was twenty-eight.

Michael: That's great.

Daniel: At first, I felt embarrassed because some people had started much earlier.

Michael: You shouldn't have worried about that.

Daniel: I eventually realized **better late than never**.

Michael: Exactly. It's never too late to learn something useful.

Daniel: Now I practice every day.

Michael: That's probably why you've improved so much.

Daniel: I missed a lot of time before, so now I'm trying to **make up for lost time**.

Michael: That's a good attitude.

Daniel: Although sometimes I become too impatient.

Michael: You need to **take your time**. Learning takes practice.

Daniel: True.

Michael: You know, I sometimes wish I could **turn back the clock**.

Daniel: Why?

Michael: I made a few business decisions in the beginning that I would handle differently today.

Daniel: Everyone has decisions they regret.

Michael: I know. But we can't turn back the clock.

Daniel: Exactly. We can only learn from the past.

Michael: That's what I'm doing now.

Daniel: How do you manage your time these days?

Michael: Very carefully. Running a business has taught me that **time is money**.

Daniel: Absolutely. A wasted hour can sometimes mean a wasted opportunity.

Michael: Exactly. Last month, I was so **pressed for time** that I nearly missed an important meeting.

Daniel: What happened?

Michael: I had three meetings scheduled one after another, and then my car broke down.

Daniel: That sounds stressful.

Michael: It was. I had to take a taxi and arrived **in the nick of time**.

Daniel: At least you made it.

Michael: Barely.

Daniel: What did you do while you were waiting for the taxi?

Michael: I checked some emails to **kill time**.

Daniel: That's one way to use waiting time.

Michael: Exactly. I hate sitting around doing nothing.

Daniel: I actually like having **time on my hands** occasionally.

Michael: Really?

Daniel: Yes. It gives me a chance to relax, read, or visit my family.

Michael: I suppose I should do that more often.

Daniel: Definitely. You can't work all the time.

Michael: True. Even successful people need rest.

Daniel: Do you ever take vacations?

Michael: Not often. Maybe **once in a blue moon**.

Daniel: That's not healthy.

Michael: I know. I'm trying to change that.

Daniel: You should take a proper holiday sometime.

Michael: I'm planning one for next year.

Daniel: Good. And when you go, you should **have the time of your life**.

Michael: I definitely plan to.

Daniel: Where are you thinking of going?

Michael: Maybe somewhere near the coast. I want to spend a week without checking work emails.

Daniel: That sounds perfect.

Michael: In the meantime, I'm trying to organize my schedule better.

Daniel: What are you doing differently?

Michael: I make a plan every morning. I decide which tasks are urgent and which ones can wait.

Daniel: That's smart.

Michael: And **in the meantime**, my assistant handles some of the smaller responsibilities.

Daniel: Good delegation.

Michael: I've also learned not to rush every decision.

Daniel: That's important.

Michael: Sometimes my employees want an immediate answer, but I tell them to give me a little time.

Daniel: So you **bide your time**?

Michael: Exactly. Some decisions are too important to make quickly.

Daniel: I agree.

Michael: Although sometimes we simply don't have a choice.

Daniel: You mean when there's **a race against time**?

Michael: Exactly. We had one situation recently where a customer's system stopped working.

Daniel: What did you do?

Michael: We had only six hours to fix it before their business opened.

Daniel: That really was a race against time.

Michael: It was. Our engineers worked continuously and solved the problem **in no time**.

Daniel: That must have been impressive.

Michael: It was one of our best moments.

Daniel: Your company sounds like it has grown a lot.

Michael: It has. And now I have some ideas that I think could really change the industry.

Daniel: You've always been creative.

Michael: Some people think my ideas are strange.

Daniel: Maybe because they're **ahead of your time**.

Michael: I hope so.

Daniel: But don't become **behind the times** either.

Michael: What do you mean?

Daniel: Technology changes quickly. A company can become outdated before it even realizes it.

Michael: That's true. We try to update our systems regularly.

Daniel: Good. Otherwise your old equipment might be **living on borrowed time**.

Michael: That's actually happening with some of our machines.

Daniel: Then replace them before they fail completely.

Michael: We're planning to.

Daniel: You've learned a lot since starting your business.

Michael: Definitely. Experience teaches you things that books cannot.

Daniel: And sometimes you learn the same lesson **time and again**.

Michael: Unfortunately, yes.

Daniel: What's one lesson you wish you had learned earlier?

Michael: Patience.

Daniel: Why?

Michael: Because I used to think success had to happen immediately. Now I understand that progress takes time.

Daniel: That's true.

Michael: Some goals take months. Some take years.

Daniel: And sometimes **time will tell** whether a decision was right.

Michael: Exactly. I recently invested in a new project, and I'm not sure how successful it will be.

Daniel: Are you worried?

Michael: A little.

Daniel: Just give it time.

Michael: That's what I'm trying to do.

Daniel: Do you still visit your old school?

Michael: **From time to time.**

Daniel: Really?

Michael: Yes. I sometimes speak to students about starting businesses.

Daniel: That must be rewarding.

Michael: It is. Walking through those old classrooms reminds me of how much life has changed.

Daniel: That's the **sands of time** for you.

Michael: Exactly. Years disappear almost without warning.

Daniel: And before you know it, another decade has passed.

Michael: That's why I'm trying to enjoy the present more.

Daniel: Good. Don't spend all your time worrying about tomorrow.

Michael: You're right.

Daniel: So, are you free this weekend?

Michael: I think so. Why?

Daniel: A few old classmates are meeting for dinner.

Michael: Really? Who's coming?

Daniel: James, Sarah, Peter, and a few others.

Michael: I haven't seen some of them in years.

Daniel: Then come along.

Michael: Definitely. It will be good to see everyone again.

Daniel: Great. But don't arrive late.

Michael: I'll try.

Daniel: No, seriously. We're starting at seven.

Michael: I'll be there **in no time.**

Daniel: That's what you always say.

Michael: And this time I mean it.

Daniel: Well, I'll believe it when I see you.

Michael: Fair enough.

Daniel: You know, talking to you today has made me realize something.

Michael: What?

Daniel: We spend so much time chasing the future that we sometimes forget to enjoy the moment.

Michael: That's very true.

Daniel: We can't stop time.

Michael: No, but we can choose how we spend it.

Daniel: Exactly.

Michael: And maybe that's the most important lesson of all.

Daniel: I couldn't agree more.

Michael: So, shall we call it a day and get some coffee?

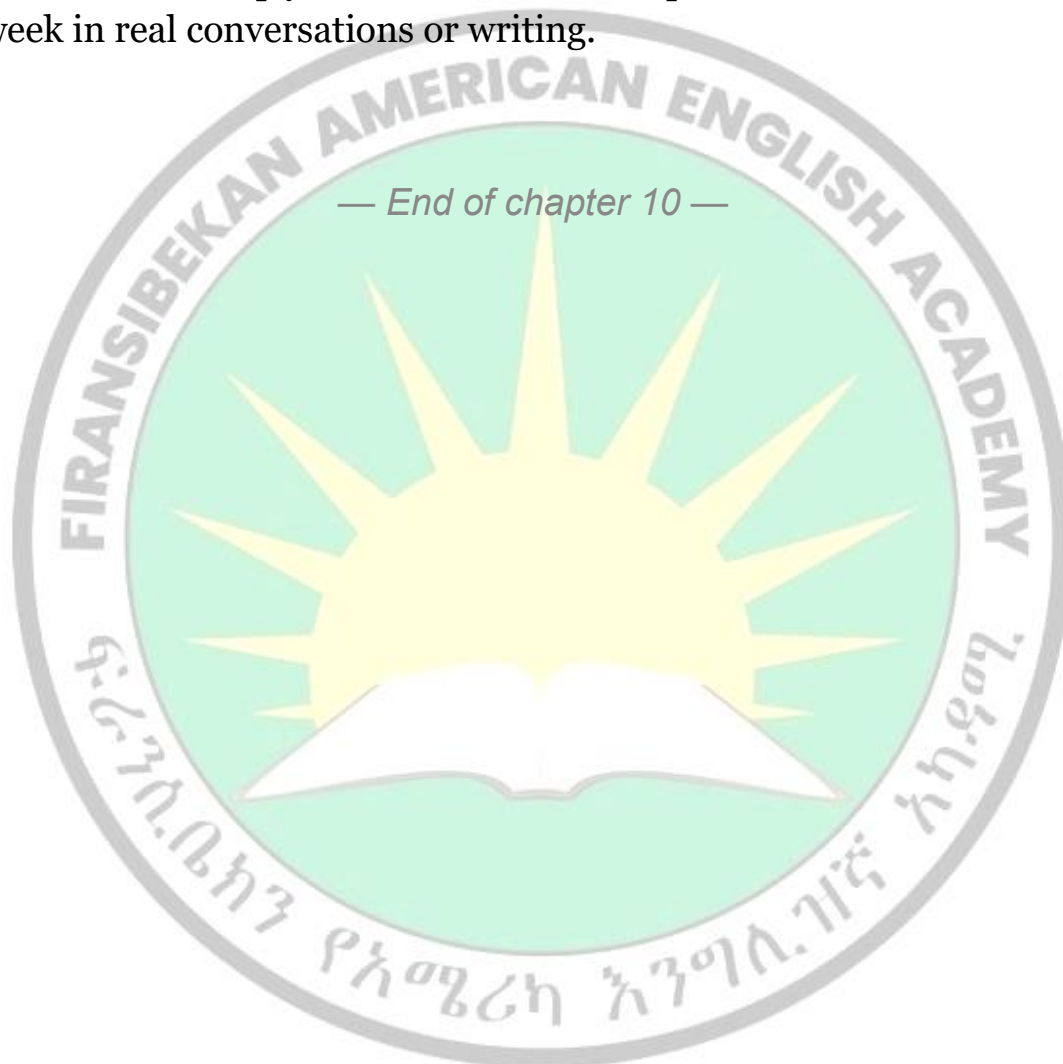
Daniel: Absolutely. We've got plenty of time.

Michael: For once, I'm not going to argue with you.

Daniel: Good. Let's make the most of it.

Chapter Review

These idioms will help you sound natural and precise. Practise five of them this week in real conversations or writing.



— End of chapter 10 —

CHAPTER 11

School & Learning

Academic life generates its own set of vivid expressions. These idioms appear in classrooms, study groups, parent-teacher conversations, and lifelong learning contexts.

Learn the ropes

Meaning: To learn how a particular job, activity, or organization works.

Short Explanation: From sailing: new sailors had to learn the complex system of ropes that controlled the sails.

Usage: Very common for new jobs, schools, and systems. Neutral. Both varieties.

Examples:

- *It took me a month to learn the ropes at the new company.*
- *The mentor helped the intern learn the ropes.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

New hire: *Everything still feels confusing.*

Mentor: *That's normal. Give yourself three weeks to learn the ropes. You'll feel at home soon.*

Hit the books

Meaning: To study hard, especially for an exam or important academic task.

Short Explanation: Literal image of opening books and working intensively.

Usage: Informal and common among students. More American, but understood elsewhere.

Examples:

- *I can't go out tonight – I need to hit the books.*
- *Finals start next week, so everyone is hitting the books.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Roommate: *Coming to the party?*

Student: *Not tonight. I have to hit the books for tomorrow's midterm.*

Pass with flying colors

Meaning: To succeed easily and with a very high standard; to do extremely well.

Short Explanation: From naval tradition: ships that had been victorious returned with flags (colors) flying. Applied to academic or other success.

Usage: Positive and celebratory. Neutral. Both varieties.

Examples:

- *She passed the certification exam with flying colors.*
- *He completed the course with flying colors.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Parent: *How was the driving test?*

Teen: *I passed with flying colors! Not a single mistake.*

Draw a blank

Meaning: To be unable to remember or think of something; to fail to find an answer.

Short Explanation: From lotteries or raffles where a blank ticket wins nothing. Figuratively, the mind produces nothing.

Usage: Common for memory lapses and creative blocks. Neutral to informal.

Examples:

- *I know the name, but I'm drawing a blank.*
- *When the teacher asked for examples, half the class drew a blank.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Quiz partner: *What's the capital of Australia?*

You: *I know this... wait, I'm drawing a blank. Canberra? Yes – Canberra.*

School of hard knocks

Meaning: Learning through difficult real-life experiences rather than formal education.

Short Explanation: Life itself becomes the teacher, and the lessons come from hardship.

Usage: Slightly rough, respectful of practical wisdom. Informal. More American.

Examples:

- *He never went to college, but he graduated from the school of hard knocks.*
- *Some skills you only learn in the school of hard knocks.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Interviewer: *You don't have a formal degree in management.*

Candidate: *True. I learned leadership in the school of hard knocks – building teams under pressure for fifteen years.*

Know something inside out

Meaning: To know something extremely well; to understand every detail.

Short Explanation: Knowing both the inside and the outside – complete mastery.

Usage: Common for expertise. Neutral. Both varieties.

Examples:

- *She knows the tax code inside out.*
- *After ten years he knows the system inside out.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Manager: *Can you handle the legacy software?*

Engineer: *I know it inside out. I helped build the original version.*

A quick study

Meaning: Someone who learns new things rapidly and easily.

Short Explanation: Emphasizes speed of learning rather than depth alone.

Usage: Positive description of ability. Neutral. Common in professional contexts.

Examples:

- *She's a quick study – she'll be productive within days.*
- *The new intern is a quick study.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Supervisor: *How's the new analyst?*

Trainer: *A quick study. She absorbed the reporting tools in two days.*

Teach someone a lesson

Meaning: To punish or correct someone so that they learn not to repeat a mistake; or more neutrally, to cause someone to learn something important.

Short Explanation: Can be punitive or educational depending on context.

Usage: Common. Tone depends on context – can sound threatening or simply instructive.

Examples:

- *The failure taught him a valuable lesson about preparation.*
- *That experience taught me a lesson I'll never forget.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Friend: *I can't believe I trusted that vendor again.*

You: *Sometimes the only way to learn is when life teaches you a lesson the hard way.*

Real-Life Dialogue

Daniel: *Hey, Sarah! You look exhausted. What happened?*

Sarah: *I've been at the library since six this morning.*

Daniel: *Since six? What are you studying for?*

Sarah: *My final exams. They start next week, and I still have so much to review.*

Daniel: *I remember those days. I suppose you've been **hitting the books** every day.*

Sarah: Pretty much. I wanted to go to the movies with my friends last night, but I stayed home to study.

Daniel: That sounds serious.

Sarah: It is. I really want to get good grades this semester.

Daniel: I'm sure you'll do well. You've been working hard.

Sarah: I hope so. Actually, I've been struggling with one subject.

Daniel: Which one?

Sarah: Economics. The professor moves so quickly that sometimes I have trouble keeping up.

Daniel: Have you talked to anyone who can help?

Sarah: Yes. My older brother studied economics at university, and he offered to tutor me.

Daniel: That's helpful.

Sarah: Very. He told me that I'm actually a **quick study** once I understand the basic ideas.

Daniel: I agree. You usually learn things pretty quickly.

Sarah: Thanks. But sometimes I panic during exams.

Daniel: What happens?

Sarah: I can study something perfectly the night before, but when I sit down for the exam, my mind suddenly stops working.

Daniel: You mean you **draw a blank**?

Sarah: Exactly! Last semester, the professor asked me to explain a theory I had studied for three days.

Daniel: And what happened?

Sarah: Nothing. I just stared at him.

Daniel: That must have been embarrassing.

Sarah: It was terrible. I knew the answer, but I simply couldn't remember it.

Daniel: Don't worry. It happens to everyone.

Sarah: I hope it doesn't happen again.

Daniel: Maybe you need to practice answering questions under pressure.

Sarah: That's what my brother suggested.

Daniel: Good idea.

Sarah: Speaking of learning, how was your first week at the new company?

Daniel: Much better than the first day.

Sarah: Was it difficult?

Daniel: At first, yes. There were so many new systems, procedures, and people to remember.

Sarah: I can imagine.

Daniel: My manager told me not to worry and said it would take some time to **learn the ropes**.

Sarah: That's a useful expression.

Daniel: Definitely. After a couple of weeks, I started understanding how everything worked.

Sarah: Did anyone help you?

Daniel: Yes. One of the senior employees showed me how to use the company software and explained the procedures.

Sarah: So you've learned everything already?

Daniel: Not everything. But I know the basic system pretty well now.

Sarah: You're probably becoming an expert.

Daniel: Maybe not an expert yet, but I know the reporting system **inside out**.

Sarah: Really?

Daniel: Yes. I spent several days studying it. Now I know where everything is and how the different functions work.

Sarah: That must make your job easier.

Daniel: It does. Yesterday my manager had a problem with one of the reports.

Sarah: Were you able to fix it?

Daniel: Immediately. I knew exactly what was wrong.

Sarah: Nice.

Daniel: He actually asked me how I learned the system so quickly.

Sarah: What did you tell him?

Daniel: I said I was determined to understand it completely because I didn't want to depend on someone else every time I had a problem.

Sarah: That's a good attitude.

Daniel: Thanks. But not everything I've learned came from school or work.

Sarah: What do you mean?

Daniel: Some of the most important lessons I've learned came from difficult experiences.

Sarah: Like what?

Daniel: When I started my first business, I made plenty of mistakes. I trusted the wrong people, spent money carelessly, and didn't know how to manage a team.

Sarah: That sounds painful.

Daniel: It was. But those experiences taught me things that no textbook could teach me.

Sarah: So you learned from the **school of hard knocks**?

Daniel: Exactly.

Sarah: I've heard people use that expression before.

Daniel: It means learning through real-life difficulties instead of formal education.

Sarah: That makes sense.

Daniel: My first business failed, but I learned from the experience.

Sarah: And what happened afterward?

Daniel: I started another company. This time, I planned more carefully, listened to experienced people, and paid more attention to the numbers.

Sarah: Was the second business successful?

Daniel: Much more successful.

Sarah: Then your first failure was actually useful.

Daniel: Absolutely. Sometimes failure can be a better teacher than success.

Sarah: I've had experiences like that at school.

Daniel: Such as?

Sarah: Last year, I failed an important exam because I didn't prepare properly.

Daniel: What did you learn?

Sarah: I learned that I couldn't wait until the last week and expect everything to work out.

Daniel: Sounds like the experience **taught you a lesson**.

Sarah: It definitely did.

Daniel: Did you change the way you study?

Sarah: Completely. Now I review my notes every week instead of waiting until the night before the exam.

Daniel: That's much better.

Sarah: I also started studying with friends.

Daniel: Does that help?

Sarah: A lot. We explain difficult topics to each other.

Daniel: Teaching someone else is actually a good way to learn.

Sarah: Exactly. Sometimes I understand something better after explaining it to someone else.

Daniel: Have you ever had a teacher who really changed the way you think?

Sarah: Yes. My English teacher, Mr. Jibril, had a big influence on me.

Daniel: What did he do?

Sarah: He always encouraged us to ask questions instead of simply memorizing information.

Daniel: That's a good teacher.

Sarah: He used to tell us that knowing something is not enough—you have to understand how and when to use it.

Daniel: I like that.

Sarah: Me too. That's why I'm trying to improve my English beyond just passing exams.

Daniel: What are you working on?

Sarah: Vocabulary, pronunciation, listening, and especially idioms.

Daniel: Idioms can be difficult.

Sarah: They were at first. Sometimes I understood every individual word, but the sentence still didn't make sense.

Daniel: Exactly. English can be strange that way.

Sarah: But the more I read and listen, the easier they become.

Daniel: That's how language learning works.

Sarah: I'm hoping that one day I'll understand English conversations without translating everything in my head.

Daniel: You will. Just keep practicing.

Sarah: That's what I'm trying to do.

Daniel: And don't put too much pressure on yourself.

Sarah: I know.

Daniel: Remember when you started learning English?

Sarah: Yes. I could barely introduce myself.

Daniel: Look at you now.

Sarah: I've improved a lot.

Daniel: Exactly. Learning is a process.

Sarah: Sometimes I forget how far I've come.

Daniel: That happens. We often notice what we still don't know instead of what we already know.

Sarah: That's true.

Daniel: So what's your goal after graduation?

Sarah: I want to study business and eventually start my own company.

Daniel: That sounds ambitious.

Sarah: It is, but I'm willing to work for it.

Daniel: Good. And remember, you don't have to know everything immediately.

Sarah: I know.

Daniel: You'll **learn the ropes** as you go.

Sarah: And hopefully become a **quick study**.

Daniel: You already are.

Sarah: Thanks.

Daniel: Just keep studying, keep asking questions, and don't be afraid of mistakes.

Sarah: I won't.

Daniel: And when the exam comes, try not to **draw a blank**.

Sarah: Very funny.

Daniel: I'm serious!

Sarah: Don't worry. I've prepared well this time.

Daniel: Then you might **pass with flying colors**.

Sarah: That's the goal.

Daniel: And even if things don't go perfectly?

Sarah: I'll learn from it.

Daniel: Exactly.

Sarah: Because sometimes the most valuable lessons come from the mistakes we make.

Daniel: Now you're talking like someone who has graduated from the **school of hard knocks**.

Sarah: Maybe I have.

Daniel: Well, good luck with your exams.

Sarah: Thank you. I'd better get back to the library.

Daniel: More books?

Sarah: Yes. Time to **hit the books** again.

Daniel: All right. Go get that top grade.

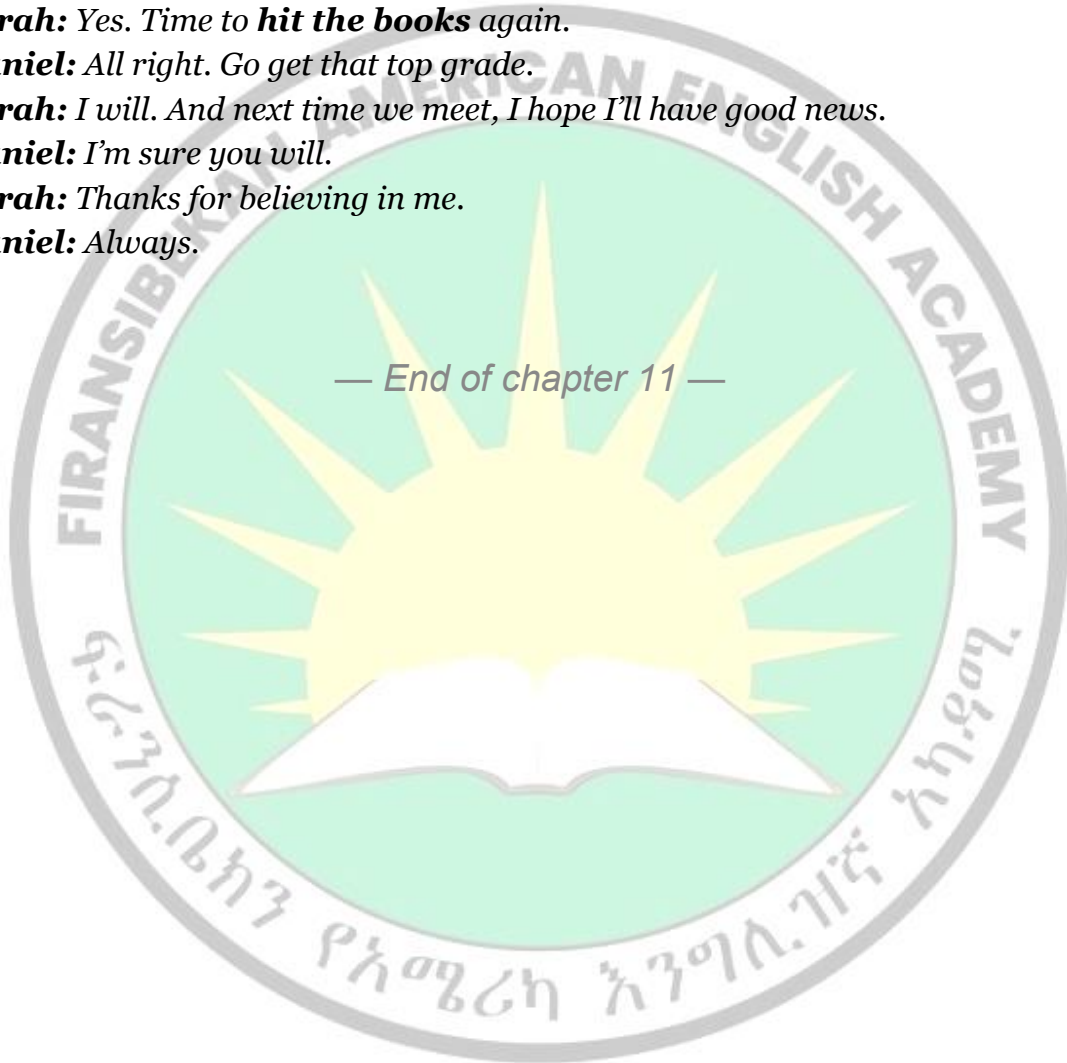
Sarah: I will. And next time we meet, I hope I'll have good news.

Daniel: I'm sure you will.

Sarah: Thanks for believing in me.

Daniel: Always.

— End of chapter 11 —



CHAPTER 12

Food, Animals & Nature Idioms

English draws heavily on the natural world and the kitchen for figurative language. These idioms are vivid, memorable, and frequent in everyday speech.

A piece of cake

Meaning: Something very easy (already covered in Chapter 1; repeated here for the food theme).

Short Explanation: Cake is soft and pleasant – the task feels equally effortless.

Usage: Informal. Extremely common.

Examples:

- *The test was a piece of cake.*
- *Don't worry – installing the software is a piece of cake.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Student: *Was the exam hard?*

Friend: *No, a piece of cake. I finished early.*

Spill the beans

Meaning: To reveal a secret or confidential information, often accidentally.

Short Explanation: Possibly from an ancient voting method using beans; spilling them revealed the result early.

Usage: Informal. Very common. Synonym of 'let the cat out of the bag'.

Examples:

- *Don't spill the beans about the promotion.*
- *She spilled the beans during dinner.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Sibling: *You know about the surprise, don't you?*

You: *I do, and I'm not spilling the beans. Your secret is safe.*

Cool as a cucumber

Meaning: Very calm and composed, especially in a stressful situation.

Short Explanation: Cucumbers remain cool inside even in warm weather. Applied to emotional coolness.

Usage: Informal and complimentary. Both varieties.

Examples:

- *Even during the crisis she stayed cool as a cucumber.*
- *He's always cool as a cucumber under pressure.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Colleague: *How did you stay so calm during the presentation?*

You: *Practice. I just pretended I was cool as a cucumber.*

The apple of my eye

Meaning: Someone (or occasionally something) that is cherished above all others.

Short Explanation: Old expression: the pupil of the eye was thought essential to sight; hence something precious.

Usage: Affectionate. Common for children, partners, or treasured people. Neutral to warm.

Examples:

- *Her grandson is the apple of her eye.*
- *That old guitar is the apple of his eye.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Grandparent: *How's my favorite person?*

Child: *Hi, Grandma.*

Grandparent: *You're still the apple of my eye.*

Let sleeping dogs lie

Meaning: To avoid interfering with a situation that is currently quiet, because interference might cause trouble.

Short Explanation: Waking a sleeping dog risks being bitten. Better to leave potential problems undisturbed.

Usage: Cautionary wisdom. Neutral. Both varieties.

Examples:

- *I know you're curious, but let sleeping dogs lie.*
- *We decided to let sleeping dogs lie and not reopen the old argument.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Colleague: *Should we mention the earlier conflict in the meeting?*

Manager: *No. Let sleeping dogs lie. The team has moved on.*

Kill two birds with one stone

Meaning: Achieve two aims with a single action (see also Chapter 6).

Short Explanation: Efficiency metaphor drawn from hunting.

Usage: Extremely common despite modern sensitivity discussions. Neutral in most contexts.

Examples:

- *I killed two birds with one stone by exercising on my commute.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Friend: *Why the early meeting?*

You: *I kill two birds with one stone – I update the team and avoid the rush-hour traffic afterward.*

Raining cats and dogs

Meaning: Raining very heavily.

Short Explanation: Origin uncertain – possibly from old thatched roofs where animals sheltered and were washed out in storms, or from mythological associations. Now purely idiomatic.

Usage: Informal and vivid. Common weather talk. Both varieties.

Examples:

- *We can't go out – it's raining cats and dogs.*
- *It was raining cats and dogs all afternoon.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Caller: *Are you still coming over?*

Friend: *I'd love to, but it's raining cats and dogs. Can we reschedule?*

Barking up the wrong tree

Meaning: To pursue a mistaken line of thought or action; to accuse or look for solutions in the wrong place.

Short Explanation: From hunting dogs that bark at the base of the wrong tree while the prey is elsewhere.

Usage: Common for correcting misconceptions. Neutral to mildly critical.

Examples:

- *If you think I leaked the information, you're barking up the wrong tree.*
- *The investigators were barking up the wrong tree for months.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Colleague: *I heard you were the one who cancelled the project.*

You: *You're barking up the wrong tree. That decision came from finance, not me.*

A fish out of water

Meaning: Someone who feels uncomfortable or out of place in a particular situation.

Short Explanation: A fish cannot survive long out of its natural element. Applied to social or environmental mismatch.

Usage: Empathetic and common. Neutral.

Examples:

- *At the formal dinner I felt like a fish out of water.*
- *He's a fish out of water in large corporate settings.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Friend: *How was the gala?*

You: *Beautiful, but I felt like a fish out of water among all those executives.*

The tip of the iceberg

Meaning: A small, visible part of a much larger problem or situation that remains hidden.

Short Explanation: Only about one-tenth of an iceberg is visible above water. The greater mass lies beneath.

Usage: Common for systemic issues. Neutral. Both varieties.

Examples:

- *These complaints are just the tip of the iceberg.*
- *The reported cases may be only the tip of the iceberg.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Investigator: *We've found three violations so far.*

Supervisor: *I suspect that's only the tip of the iceberg. Keep digging.*

Take the bull by the horns

Meaning: To face a difficult situation directly and with determination.

Short Explanation: From bullfighting or farming: grasping the horns is a bold, risky way to control the animal.

Usage: Positive and courageous. Neutral to informal.

Examples:

- *It's time to take the bull by the horns and confront the issue.*
- *She took the bull by the horns and asked for the promotion.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Advisor: *You've been avoiding the conversation with your landlord.*

Client: *You're right. Tomorrow, I take the bull by the horns and request the repairs in writing.*

Food, Animals & Nature Idioms — One Medium-Length Dialogue

James: *How was your exam yesterday?*

Michael: *Honestly, it was a piece of cake. I studied well, so I finished much earlier than I expected.*

James: *Lucky you! Mine was difficult. By the way, did you hear about the surprise party for Mrs. Brown?*

Michael: *Yes, but don't ask me for details.*

James: *Why not?*

Michael: Because I promised not to **spill the beans**.

James: Come on, just tell me a little!

Michael: No way. You'll have to wait until Saturday.

James: Fine. I'll be patient. By the way, how did you stay so calm during yesterday's presentation?

Michael: I practiced several times. I tried to stay **cool as a cucumber** even when people started asking difficult questions.

James: It worked. You looked completely relaxed.

Michael: Inside, I was nervous!

James: Nobody could tell. By the way, how is your little daughter?

Michael: She's doing great. She's the **apple of my eye**.

James: I can tell. You talk about her all the time.

Michael: She means everything to me.

James: Speaking of family, did you hear that Peter and his brother started arguing again?

Michael: Yes, but I don't want to get involved.

James: Why?

Michael: They seem to have calmed down now. I think we should **let sleeping dogs lie** and not bring up the old argument.

James: That's probably wise.

Michael: Exactly. Sometimes trying to solve an old problem only creates a new one.

James: You know what? I went to work by bicycle this morning.

Michael: Really? Why?

James: I needed exercise, and I also wanted to avoid the traffic. I managed to **kill two birds with one stone**.

Michael: That's a good idea. I should try that sometime.

James: You should—but not today. Look outside.

Michael: Wow! It's **raining cats and dogs**!

James: Exactly. I'm glad I'm already home.

Michael: Me too. I definitely wouldn't want to ride a bicycle in this weather.

James: I heard that Carlos blamed you for canceling the meeting.

Michael: He did?

James: Yes.

Michael: Then he's **barking up the wrong tree**. I had nothing to do with it. The manager canceled it.

James: I thought so. Carlos probably misunderstood what happened.

Michael: I'll talk to him tomorrow.

James: Good idea.

Michael: Actually, speaking of work, how are you feeling about your new position?

James: Honestly, I feel like **a fish out of water**.

Michael: Why?

James: Everyone seems to know what they're doing, and I'm still trying to understand the system.

Michael: That's normal when you're new. Give yourself some time.

James: I hope so.

Michael: Remember when I started my first job? I felt exactly the same way.

James: Really?

Michael: Yes. What you see at first is often only **the tip of the iceberg**. There's always much more to learn than you expect.

James: That makes me feel better.

Michael: Don't worry. You'll get there.

James: I think I need to stop avoiding some of the difficult tasks.

Michael: Then it's time to **take the bull by the horns**.

James: You're right. Tomorrow I'm going to talk to my manager, ask questions, and deal with the problems directly.

Michael: That's the attitude.

James: Thanks for the advice.

Michael: Anytime. Now, before we get completely soaked by this rain, let's go inside and have some coffee.

James: Good idea. And don't even think about asking me about that surprise party.

Michael: Fine, fine. I won't try to make you **spill the beans**.

James: Good. Some secrets are worth keeping.

Michael: Agreed.

— End of chapter 12 —

CHAPTER 13

Animal Idioms

Animals provide some of the most vivid idioms in English. These expressions draw on observed animal behaviour.

A dark horse

Meaning: A person with hidden talent or potential that surprises others.

Short Explanation: From horse racing: a dark horse was one whose form was unknown.

Usage: Common in sports, politics and competitions. Neutral.

Examples:

- *She was a dark horse in the race.*
- *No one expected him to win — he was a real dark horse.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Coach: *Who do you think will win?*

Teacher: *Watch the quiet girl. She's a dark horse.*

The lion's share

Meaning: The largest or greatest part of something.

Short Explanation: Lions take the largest portion of a kill.

Usage: Neutral. Common in business and family contexts.

Examples:

- *He got the lion's share of the money.*
- *Marketing received the lion's share of the budget.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Sibling: *How was it divided?*

You: *Dad got the lion's share.*

Hold your horses

Meaning: Wait a moment; slow down.

Short Explanation: From horse-drawn transport: a command to stop the horses.

Usage: Informal and common.

Examples:

- *Hold your horses! I'm coming.*
- *Hold your horses — we need to check the facts.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Teen: *Can I have the keys?*

Parent: *Hold your horses. Finish your chores first.*

A fish out of water

Meaning: Someone who feels uncomfortable or out of place.

Short Explanation: A fish cannot survive long outside water.

Usage: Empathetic and very common. Neutral.

Examples:

- *I felt like a fish out of water at the formal dinner.*
- *He is a fish out of water in large meetings.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Friend: *How was the gala?*

You: *I felt like a fish out of water among the executives.*

Let the cat out of the bag

Meaning: To reveal a secret, usually accidentally.

Short Explanation: Linked to market fraud in which a cat was substituted for a piglet.

Usage: Informal to neutral. Extremely common.

Examples:

- *Don't let the cat out of the bag about the party.*
- *He let the cat out of the bag during the meeting.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Priya: *We're planning a surprise.*

Ravi: *I almost let the cat out of the bag.*

Kill two birds with one stone

Meaning: Achieve two goals with a single action.

Short Explanation: Efficiency metaphor from hunting.

Usage: Extremely common. Neutral.

Examples:

- *Cycling to work kills two birds with one stone.*
- *The meeting killed two birds with one stone.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Colleague: *Why the early meeting?*

You: *I kill two birds with one stone — update the team and avoid traffic.*

The elephant in the room

Meaning: An obvious problem that everyone is aware of but no one discusses.

Short Explanation: An elephant is impossible to ignore.

Usage: Very common in meetings and families. Neutral.

Examples:

- *Nobody mentioned the budget cuts — that was the elephant in the room.*
- *We need to address the elephant in the room.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Manager: *Any other comments?*

Member: *We should talk about the elephant in the room — the delayed launch.*

Cry wolf

Meaning: Give a false alarm so that later genuine warnings may be ignored.

Short Explanation: From Aesop's fable of the boy who cried 'Wolf!'.

Usage: Cautionary. Common with children and risk discussions.

Examples:

- *Don't cry wolf again.*
- *The company has cried wolf so many times that no one reacts.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Parent: *You said there was a spider last night too.*

Child: *This time it's real!*

Parent: *You've cried wolf twice this week.*

Busy as a bee

Meaning: Extremely busy and active.

Short Explanation: Bees are constantly in motion.

Usage: Informal and positive.

Examples:

- *She's busy as a bee preparing for the conference.*
- *I've been as busy as a bee all week.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Colleague: *How are you managing?*

You: *Busy as a bee, but it's satisfying.*

Eat like a horse

Meaning: Eat a very large amount of food.

Short Explanation: Horses consume large quantities.

Usage: Informal and humorous.

Examples:

- *He eats like a horse after training.*
- *Teenagers often eat like horses.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Parent: *There's no food left.*

Teen: *Sorry — I eat like a horse on training days.*

A wolf in sheep's clothing

Meaning: A dangerous person pretending to be kind.

Short Explanation: Biblical origin. The wolf hides its nature.

Usage: Strong warning. Neutral.

Examples:

- *He was a wolf in sheep's clothing.*
- *Be careful — she may be a wolf in sheep's clothing.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Friend: *He seems so helpful.*

You: *Something feels off. He might be a wolf in sheep's clothing.*

Take the bull by the horns

Meaning: Face a difficult situation directly and bravely.

Short Explanation: Grasping the horns is a bold way to control a bull.

Usage: Positive and courageous.

Examples:

- *She took the bull by the horns and asked for the promotion.*
- *It's time to take the bull by the horns.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Advisor: *You've been avoiding the conversation.*

Client: *Tomorrow I take the bull by the horns.*

Birds of a feather flock together

Meaning: Similar people tend to associate with one another.

Short Explanation: Birds of the same species gather together.

Usage: Common proverb-like idiom.

Examples:

- *Birds of a feather flock together.*
- *I'm not surprised they're friends.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Colleague: *Why do those three always lunch together?*

You: *Birds of a feather flock together.*

Smell a rat

Meaning: Suspect that something is wrong or dishonest.

Short Explanation: Rats are associated with hidden danger.

Usage: Informal. Common for suspicion.

Examples:

- *I smell a rat — the numbers don't add up.*
- *She smelled a rat when he became very generous.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Partner: *He offered an unusually high price.*

You: *I smell a rat. Let's check the history.*

IDIOMS EXPRESSIONS RELATED TO ANIMALS

1. A dark horse

Meaning: A person with hidden talent.

Example: She was a dark horse in the race.

2. The lion's share

Meaning: The biggest part.

Example: He got the lion's share of the money.

3. Hold your horses

Meaning: Wait a moment.

Example: Hold your horses! I'm coming.

4. A fish out of water

Meaning: Feeling uncomfortable.

Example: I felt like a fish out of water.

5. Let the cat out of the bag

Meaning: Reveal a secret.

Example: He let the cat out of the bag.

6. Kill two birds with one stone

Meaning: Achieve two goals at once.

Example: Cycling to work kills two birds with one stone.

7. The elephant in the room

Meaning: An obvious problem.

Example: Nobody mentioned the elephant in the room.

8. Cry wolf

Meaning: Give a false alarm.

Example: Don't cry wolf again.

9. Busy as a bee

Meaning: Very busy.

Example: She's busy as a bee.

10. Eat like a horse

Meaning: Eat a lot.

Example: He eats like a horse.

11. Butterflies in your stomach

Meaning: Feel nervous.

Example: I had butterflies before the test.

12. A wolf in sheep's clothing

Meaning: A dangerous person pretending to be kind.

Example: He was a wolf in sheep's clothing.

13. Monkey see, monkey do

Meaning: Copy others.

Example: Children often follow monkey see, monkey do.

14. The early bird catches the worm

Meaning: Success comes to those who act early.

Example: She arrived first—the early bird catches the worm.

15. Like a duck to water

Meaning: Learn easily.

Example: He took to football like a duck to water.

16. Stubborn as a mule

Meaning: Very stubborn.

Example: My brother is stubborn as a mule.

17. Take the bull by the horns

Meaning: Face a problem bravely.

Example: She took the bull by the horns.

18. Birds of a feather flock together

Meaning: Similar people stay together.

Example: Birds of a feather flock together.

19. Smell a rat

Meaning: Suspect something is wrong.

Example: I smell a rat.

20. As quiet as a mouse

Meaning: Very quiet.

Example: The baby was as quiet as a mouse.

Additional Animal Expressions

As quiet as a mouse — Very quiet

Example: The baby was as quiet as a mouse.

Stubborn as a mule — Extremely stubborn

Example: My brother is stubborn as a mule.

Like a duck to water — Learn or adapt very easily

Example: He took to football like a duck to water.

The early bird catches the worm — Success comes to those who act early

Example: She arrived first — the early bird catches the worm.

Monkey see, monkey do — Copy the behaviour of others

Example: Children often follow monkey see, monkey do.

Butterflies in your stomach — Feel nervous or excited

Example: I had butterflies in my stomach before the test.

— End of Chapter 13 —

CHAPTER 14

Environment Idioms

Nature and environmental awareness supply many fixed expressions.

A breath of fresh air

Meaning: Something new and refreshing.

Short Explanation: Clean air after stuffiness feels renewing.

Usage: Positive. Common for people or ideas.

Examples:

- *Her ideas were a breath of fresh air.*
- *The new manager is a breath of fresh air.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Colleague: *How's the new hire?*

You: *A breath of fresh air. Fresh thinking.*

Barking up the wrong tree

Meaning: Blaming the wrong person or pursuing a mistaken line.

Short Explanation: Hunting dogs bark at the wrong tree.

Usage: Common for correcting misconceptions.

Examples:

- *You're barking up the wrong tree.*
- *The investigators were barking up the wrong tree.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Colleague: *I heard you cancelled the project.*

You: *You're barking up the wrong tree.*

Make hay while the sun shines

Meaning: Use a good opportunity while it lasts.

Short Explanation: Hay must be cut and dried in good weather.

Usage: Practical advice. Neutral.

Examples:

- *Let's make hay while the sun shines.*
- *The market is good — make hay while the sun shines.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Manager: *Demand is high right now.*

You: *Then we make hay while the sun shines.*

The calm before the storm

Meaning: A quiet period before trouble begins.

Short Explanation: Weather often goes still before a storm.

Usage: Common for tension. Neutral.

Examples:

- *It was the calm before the storm.*
- *Enjoy the calm before the storm.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Colleague: *Everything seems quiet.*

You: *This is the calm before the storm. The audit starts Monday.*

Come rain or shine

Meaning: No matter what happens; regardless of circumstances.

Short Explanation: Weather will not stop the commitment.

Usage: Reliable and determined. Common.

Examples:

- *I'll be there, come rain or shine.*
- *She exercises every morning, come rain or shine.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Friend: *Will you still come if it rains?*

You: *Come rain or shine.*

Nip it in the bud

Meaning: Stop a problem early, before it grows.

Short Explanation: Removing a bud prevents the plant from developing.

Usage: Practical. Common for early intervention.

Examples:

- *We should nip it in the bud.*
- *Nip the rumour in the bud before it spreads.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Manager: *There's early dissatisfaction.*

You: *Let's nip it in the bud with an open meeting.*

Out of the woods

Meaning: Out of danger or difficulty.

Short Explanation: Leaving a dark forest for open ground.

Usage: Common for recovery. Neutral.

Examples:

- *He's finally out of the woods.*
- *The company is not out of the woods yet.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Doctor: *The critical phase is over.*

Family: *So he's out of the woods?*

Doctor: *Yes, but recovery will take time.*

The tip of the iceberg

Meaning: Only a small visible part of a much larger problem.

Short Explanation: Most of an iceberg is underwater.

Usage: Common for systemic issues.

Examples:

- *That's just the tip of the iceberg.*
- *These complaints are the tip of the iceberg.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Investigator: *We've found three violations.*

Supervisor: *That's the tip of the iceberg. Keep digging.*

IDIOMS EXPRESSIONS RELATED TO ENVIRONMENT

1. Go green

Meaning: Be eco-friendly; adopt environmentally friendly practices.

Example: We should go green.

Example: We should go green and reduce our plastic use.

2. Green living

Meaning: An eco-friendly lifestyle that minimises harm to the environment.

Eco-friendly lifestyle

Example: They enjoy green living.

Example: They enjoy green living — solar panels, composting, and cycling everywhere.

3. Leave no trace

Meaning: Do not harm nature; leave a place exactly as you found it.

Example: Always leave no trace when you hike in national parks.

4. Save the Earth

Meaning: Protect the planet from environmental damage.

Example: Let's save the Earth by cutting our carbon footprint.

5. Plant a seed

Meaning: Start something positive that will grow or develop later.

Example: The community workshop planted a seed of environmental awareness.

6. Clean up

Meaning: Remove waste or pollution from a place.

Example: We cleaned up the park after the festival.

7. Back to nature

Meaning: Return to a more natural, simple way of living.

Example: After years in the city they went back to nature and bought a small farm.

8. Green thumb

Meaning: A natural talent for gardening and growing plants.

Example: She has a green thumb — everything she plants thrives.

9. Fresh air

Meaning: Clean, unpolluted air; also used for a refreshing change.

Example: I need some fresh air after sitting indoors all day.

10. Breathe easy

Meaning: Feel relaxed, safe, or relieved (sometimes linked to cleaner air).

Example: Once the factory closed, the town could finally breathe easy.

11. Cut down on waste

Meaning: Reduce the amount of waste produced.

Example: We cut down on waste by using reusable containers.

12. Think green

Meaning: Consider the environment in your decisions and actions.

Example: Always think green when you shop or travel.

13. Reuse and recycle

Meaning: Use items again and process materials so they can be used once more.

Example: We reuse and recycle everything we can at home.

14. Save water

Meaning: Do not waste water; use it carefully.

Example: Save water every day — turn off the tap while brushing your teeth.

15. Protect wildlife

Meaning: Keep animals and their habitats safe from harm.

Example: The new reserve was created to protect wildlife.

16. Keep it clean

Meaning: Do not pollute; maintain cleanliness in the environment.

Example: Keep it clean — take your rubbish with you.

17. Love nature

Meaning: Care deeply for the natural world.

Example: We all love nature and want to protect it for future generations.

18. Every drop counts

Meaning: Small amounts matter, especially when saving resources.

Example: Don't leave the tap running — every drop counts.

19. Reduce pollution

Meaning: Make less pollution; lower harmful emissions or waste.

Example: New regulations aim to reduce pollution in the city centre.

20. Keep Earth green

Meaning: Protect the environment so the planet remains healthy.

Example: Let's keep Earth green by supporting renewable energy.

21. A breath of fresh air

Meaning: Something new, refreshing, and welcome (often linked to positive change).

Example: Her ideas on sustainability were a breath of fresh air in the meeting.

22. The tip of the iceberg

Meaning: Only a small visible part of a much larger environmental or other problem.

Example: These plastic bottles on the beach are just the tip of the iceberg.

23. Nip it in the bud

Meaning: Stop an environmental or other problem early, before it grows.

Example: We need to nip illegal dumping in the bud before it becomes a crisis.

24. Make hay while the sun shines

Meaning: Take advantage of good conditions while they last (also used for weather/opportunity).

Example: The weather is perfect for the tree-planting day — make hay while the sun shines.

25. Out of the woods

Meaning: Out of danger or difficulty (sometimes used for environmental recovery).

Example: The endangered species is not out of the woods yet, but numbers are rising.

26. Go with the flow

Meaning: Accept things as they happen; also used for working with natural processes.

Example: In permaculture we try to go with the flow of the land rather than fight it.

27. Down to earth

Meaning: Practical, realistic, and unpretentious (often linked to natural values).

Example: She's very down to earth — she grows her own food and repairs things instead of replacing them.

28. As fresh as a daisy

Meaning: Full of energy and refreshed (connected to nature imagery).

Example: After a weekend in the mountains he looked as fresh as a daisy.

29. Barking up the wrong tree

Meaning: Pursuing a mistaken approach or blaming the wrong cause (sometimes environmental).

Example: If you think recycling alone will solve climate change, you may be barking up the wrong tree.

30. The calm before the storm

Meaning: A quiet period before trouble or a major environmental event.

Example: The unusually warm winter felt like the calm before the storm.

31. Come rain or shine

Meaning: No matter what the weather or circumstances are.

Example: The volunteers show up come rain or shine to clean the river.

32. Under the weather

Meaning: Feeling unwell (originally linked to weather effects).

Example: The air quality was so poor that many people felt under the weather.

33. A ray of sunshine

Meaning: A cheerful person or a source of hope (nature image).

Example: The young climate activist is a ray of sunshine in a difficult debate.

34. Storm in a teacup

Meaning: A big fuss over a small problem (sometimes used for overblown environmental claims).

Example: The local argument about one tree was a storm in a teacup compared with deforestation rates.

35. Take root

Meaning: Become established and begin to grow (ideas or plants).

Example: The idea of community gardens has taken root across the city.

Environment Idioms Dialogue

*Amina: We really need to **go green** at school.*

*David: I agree. We could start with **green living**—use less plastic, recycle, and save electricity.*

*Amina: And whenever we visit the forest, we should **leave no trace**.*

*David: Exactly. We all have a responsibility to **save the Earth**.*

*Amina: Even a small project can **plant a seed** of environmental awareness.*

*David: Then let's organize a **clean-up** this weekend.*

*Amina: Great! I'd also love to spend more time **back to nature**.*

*David: My sister has a **green thumb**. She could help us plant trees.*

*Amina: After a long day in the city, I just want some **fresh air**.*

*David: Same here. Cleaner streets would help everyone **breathe easy**.*

*Amina: We should also **cut down on waste**.*

*David: Yes, and **think green** whenever we shop.*

*Amina: At home, we **reuse and recycle** almost everything.*

*David: And remember to **save water**. Every little action matters.*

*Amina: We also need to **protect wildlife**.*

*David: Absolutely. And everyone should **keep it clean** when visiting parks.*

*Amina: I really **love nature**, especially the mountains.*

*David: Me too. And remember, **every drop counts** when we're saving water.*

*Amina: We also need stronger action to **reduce pollution and keep Earth green**.*

*David: I think your ideas are **a breath of fresh air**.*

*Amina: Thanks! But the plastic problem we see is probably only **the tip of the iceberg**.*

*David: Then we should **nip it in the bud** before it becomes even worse.*

Amina: The weather is perfect for planting today.

*David: Then let's **make hay while the sun shines**.*

Amina: Do you think the forest is finally recovering?

David: It's improving, but it's not completely **out of the woods** yet.

Amina: We should **go with the flow** and work with nature instead of fighting it.

David: That's a very **down-to-earth** way of thinking.

Amina: After a weekend in the mountains, I always feel **as fresh as a daisy**.

David: And anyone who says recycling alone will solve every environmental problem may be **barking up the wrong tree**.

Amina: True. We need many different solutions.

David: The quiet weather this week may just be **the calm before the storm**.

Amina: But the volunteers will come **come rain or shine**.

David: I've been a little **under the weather**, but I'll still come.

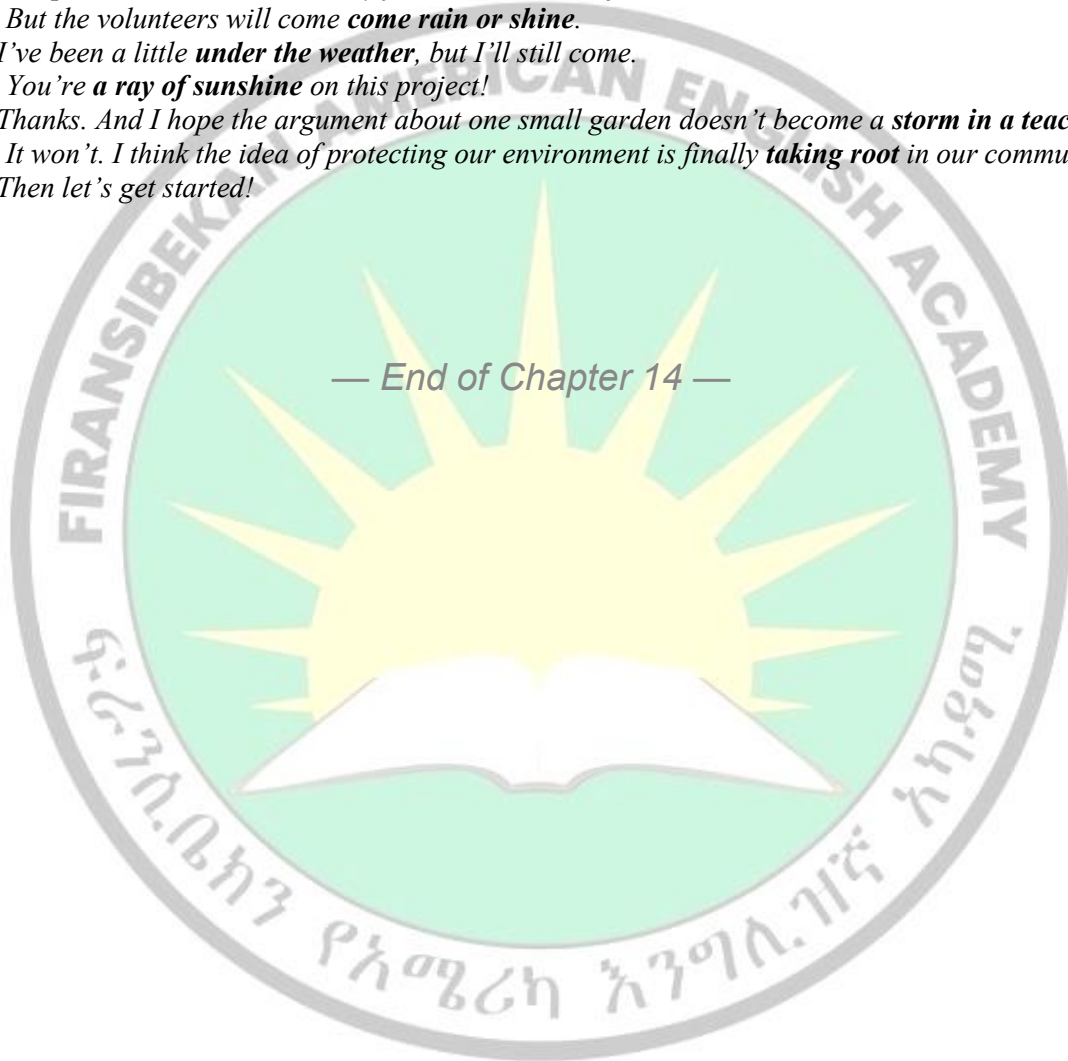
Amina: You're **a ray of sunshine** on this project!

David: Thanks. And I hope the argument about one small garden doesn't become a **storm in a teacup**.

Amina: It won't. I think the idea of protecting our environment is finally **taking root** in our community.

David: Then let's get started!

— End of Chapter 14 —



CHAPTER 15

IDIOMS RELATED TO NATURE

Nature has given English some of its most vivid and memorable expressions. From trees, flowers, animals, weather, and farming to the changing seasons, everyday experiences in the natural world have inspired idioms that describe people, problems, opportunities, relationships, and life itself.

Expressions such as **“a breath of fresh air,” “the calm before the storm,” “take root,”** and **“every cloud has a silver lining”** allow speakers to communicate ideas in a colorful and imaginative way. Many of these idioms are common in everyday conversations, while others are especially useful when talking about personal growth, challenges, success, change, and unexpected opportunities.

Learning nature-related idioms is not only about memorizing definitions. It is about understanding how native and fluent English speakers use figurative language to make their conversations more natural, expressive, and engaging.

The dialogue below brings several of these expressions together in a realistic situation. As you read, pay attention to the context in which each idiom is used. This will help you understand not only what the idioms mean, but also how to use them naturally in your own conversations.

IDIOMS EXPRESSIONS RELATED TO NATURE

1. A breath of fresh air

Meaning: Something new and refreshing.

Example: Her ideas were a breath of fresh air.

2. Barking up the wrong tree

Meaning: Blaming the wrong person or pursuing a mistaken approach.

Example: You're barking up the wrong tree.

3. Beat around the bush

Meaning: Avoid the main point.

Example: Stop beating around the bush.

4. Make hay while the sun shines

Meaning: Use a good opportunity while it lasts.

Example: Let's make hay while the sun shines.

5. The calm before the storm

Meaning: A quiet time before trouble.

Example: It was the calm before the storm.

6. Come rain or shine

Meaning: No matter what happens.

Example: I'll be there, come rain or shine.

7. Sow the seeds

Meaning: Start something that grows later.

Example: She sowed the seeds of success.

8. Nip it in the bud

Meaning: Stop a problem early.

Example: We should nip it in the bud.

9. Out of the woods

Meaning: Out of danger or difficulty.

Example: He's finally out of the woods.

10. Take root

Meaning: Become established.

Example: The idea quickly took root.

11. Like a fish out of water

Meaning: Feel uncomfortable or out of place.

Example: I felt like a fish out of water.

12. Go with the flow

Meaning: Accept things as they happen.

Example: Just go with the flow.

13. Under the weather

Meaning: Feeling sick.

Example: I'm under the weather today.

14. Every cloud has a silver lining

Meaning: Every bad situation has something good.

Example: Every cloud has a silver lining.

15. Chasing rainbows

Meaning: Trying to achieve the impossible.

Example: He's chasing rainbows.

16. A ray of sunshine

Meaning: A cheerful person or source of hope.

Example: She is a ray of sunshine.

17. Storm in a teacup

Meaning: A small problem made bigger.

Example: It's just a storm in a teacup.

18. Down to earth

Meaning: Practical and realistic.

Example: She's very down to earth.

19. The tip of the iceberg

Meaning: Only a small part of the problem.

Example: That's just the tip of the iceberg.

20. As fresh as a daisy

Meaning: Full of energy.

Example: He woke up as fresh as a daisy.

21. The grass is always greener

Meaning: Other situations always seem better than your own.

Example: He keeps changing jobs because the grass is always greener.

22. Beat a path

Meaning: Make frequent visits or create a route through difficulty.

Example: Fans beat a path to her door after the award.

23. Put down roots

Meaning: Settle permanently in a place.

Example: After years of travelling they finally put down roots.

24. A bed of roses

Meaning: An easy, comfortable situation.

Example: Starting a business is no bed of roses.

25. Go to seed

Meaning: Decline or deteriorate through neglect.

Example: The garden went to seed after they moved away.

26. In full bloom

Meaning: At the peak of beauty, health, or success.

Example: The project is in full bloom this season.

27. Reap what you sow

Meaning: Receive the consequences of your actions.

Example: If you work hard, you will reap what you sow.

28. Through the grapevine

Meaning: Hear news informally from other people.

Example: I heard through the grapevine that she's leaving.

29. Turn over a new leaf

Meaning: Start behaving in a better way.

Example: He decided to turn over a new leaf.

30. Up a tree / Out on a limb

Meaning: In a difficult or risky position.

Example: Without backup data we're out on a limb.

Real-Life Dialogue

Amina: How is your new project going?

David: Much better than I expected. At first, I felt **like a fish out of water**, but now I'm starting to **go with the flow**.

Amina: That's good to hear. I also heard some great ideas from your team. They were **a breath of fresh air**.

David: Thanks. We're trying to **sow the seeds** of some new ideas and hope they will **take root** soon.

Amina: I heard through the grapevine that your manager almost canceled the project.

David: That's true, but we managed to solve the problem. I think we're finally **out of the woods**.

Amina: That's wonderful. Sometimes **every cloud has a silver lining**.

David: Exactly. We had a difficult start, but it forced us to improve the plan.

Amina: Just make sure you don't **chase rainbows** and try to do everything at once.

David: Don't worry. I'm trying to stay **down to earth**.

Amina: Good. And if a small problem appears, **nip it in the bud** before it becomes serious.

David: Absolutely. We've learned that lesson already.

Amina: So, are you confident about the future?

David: I am. The project is beginning to **take root**, and I think success is only a matter of time.

Amina: Then keep working hard and **reap what you sow**.

David: I will. And whatever happens, I'll keep moving forward—**come rain or shine**.

Amina: That's the spirit!

— End of Chapter 15 —

CHAPTER 16

IDIOMS RELATED TO SEA

The sea has inspired English speakers for centuries, and its influence can be found in some of the language's most vivid idioms and expressions. Sailing, ships, storms, anchors, waves, and sailors have all provided powerful images for describing everyday experiences.

Sea-related idioms are often used to talk about **confusion, opportunity, risk, leadership, difficulty, success, and resilience**. Expressions such as “**in the same boat**,” “**rock the boat**,” “**miss the boat**,” “**take the helm**,” and “**weather the storm**” allow speakers to express complicated ideas in a simple and memorable way.

These expressions are especially common in conversations about work, business, personal challenges, and relationships. Understanding them will help learners recognize figurative meaning and communicate more naturally and confidently in English.

The following dialogue brings several sea idioms together in an everyday situation. Notice how the meaning of each expression becomes clear from the context.

IDIOMS EXPRESSIONS RELATED TO SEA

1. All at sea

Meaning: Confused or unsure.

Example: I was all at sea during the math test.

2. Plain sailing

Meaning: Easy and without problems.

Example: The project was plain sailing.

3. In the same boat

Meaning: In the same difficult situation.

Example: We are all in the same boat.

4. Rock the boat

Meaning: Cause trouble or disrupt a stable situation.

Example: Don't rock the boat at work.

5. Miss the boat

Meaning: Miss an opportunity.

Example: He missed the boat by applying late.

6. Learn the ropes

Meaning: Learn how to do something.

Example: She is learning the ropes.

7. A drop in the ocean

Meaning: A very small amount compared with what is needed.

Example: My donation was a drop in the ocean.

8. Any port in a storm

Meaning: Accept any help in difficulty.

Example: Any port in a storm, so I accepted the offer.

9. Bail out

Meaning: Leave a difficult situation or provide emergency help.

Example: He bailed out of the deal.

10. Take the helm

Meaning: Take control.

Example: She took the helm of the company.

11. On board

Meaning: In agreement or involved.

Example: Everyone is on board with the plan.

12. Smooth seas never made a skilled sailor

Meaning: Difficulties build strength and skill.

Example: Hard times teach us—smooth seas never made a skilled sailor.

13. Weather the storm

Meaning: Survive a difficult time.

Example: We weathered the storm together.

14. Between the devil and the deep blue sea

Meaning: Choose between two bad options.

Example: I was between the devil and the deep blue sea.

15. Cast anchor

Meaning: Settle in one place.

Example: They cast anchor in a small town.

16. Keep your head above water

Meaning: Manage to survive (often financially).

Example: He is working hard to keep his head above water.

17. Know the ropes

Meaning: Be experienced.

Example: She knows the ropes.

18. Go overboard

Meaning: Do too much.

Example: Don't go overboard with decorations.

19. At the helm

Meaning: In charge.

Example: He is at the helm of the team.

20. Make waves

Meaning: Cause excitement or trouble.

Example: Her ideas made waves.

21. Sink or swim

Meaning: Succeed or fail by yourself.

Example: It was a sink-or-swim situation.

22. Throw someone a lifeline

Meaning: Give help in a difficult situation.

Example: My friend threw me a lifeline.

23. Steer clear of

Meaning: Avoid.

Example: Steer clear of bad company.

24. Test the waters

Meaning: Try something carefully first.

Example: We tested the waters before investing.

25. Ride the wave

Meaning: Take advantage of success or opportunity.

Example: The company is riding the wave of popularity.

26. In deep water

Meaning: In serious trouble.

Example: He found himself in deep water after the audit.

27. Make a splash

Meaning: Attract a lot of attention.

Example: The new product made a big splash at the trade show.

28. On an even keel

Meaning: Stable and well-balanced.

Example: After the crisis the company is back on an even keel.

29. Sail close to the wind

Meaning: Take risks or behave in a way that is almost unacceptable.

Example: His comments were sailing close to the wind.

30. Take the wind out of someone's sails

Meaning: Destroy someone's confidence or advantage.

Example: The unexpected criticism took the wind out of her sails.

Real-Life Dialogue

Aisha: How is your new business going?

Michael: Honestly, at first I was **all at sea**. There were so many things I didn't understand.

Aisha: That's normal when you're starting something new.

Michael: Yes. Fortunately, my partner helped me **learn the ropes**. Now I **know the ropes** much better.

Aisha: So things are going more smoothly?

Michael: Definitely. Once we solved the biggest problems, it became almost **plain sailing**.

Aisha: That's great. Is everyone **on board** with your new plan?

Michael: Yes, although I'm trying not to **rock the boat** by making too many changes at once.

Aisha: Good idea. Sometimes it's better to **test the waters** before making a big decision.

Michael: Exactly. We tested a new product with a small group of customers first.

Aisha: And how did it go?

Michael: Very well. The product made a **splash**, and now we're **riding the wave** of interest.

Aisha: Sounds exciting!

Michael: It is, but we still have to be careful. If we spend too much too quickly, we could end up **in deep water**.

Aisha: Then keep things balanced.

Michael: That's the plan. We're trying to keep the company **on an even keel**.

Aisha: And who's **at the helm**?

Michael: I am, for now.

Aisha: No pressure!

Michael: None at all! But I've learned that **smooth seas never made a skilled sailor**.

Aisha: That's true. Difficult times can teach you the most.

Michael: Exactly. We've had some storms, but we're learning how to **weather the storm** together.

Aisha: Just remember not to **go overboard**.

Michael: I'll try. And if things get really difficult, I know you'll **throw me a lifeline**.

Aisha: Anytime. We're all **in the same boat**, after all.

Michael: That's exactly what good friends are for.

— End of chapter 16 —

CHAPTER 17

Idioms and Expressions Related to Weather

Weather is a powerful part of everyday English, and many common expressions use clouds, storms, rain, snow, and sunshine to describe feelings, problems, surprises, risks, and changes in life. These idioms make conversations more vivid and natural. Expressions such as “**under the weather**,” “**on cloud nine**,” “**take a rain check**,” “**weather the storm**,” and “**clear the air**” are frequently heard in everyday conversations. Learning them in context makes their meanings easier to understand and remember.

IDIOMS EXPRESSIONS RELATED TO WEATHER

1. Every cloud has a silver lining

Meaning: Every bad situation has something good in it.

Example: I lost my job, but I found a better one. Every cloud has a silver lining.

2. Under the weather

Meaning: Feeling sick.

Example: I stayed home because I was under the weather.

3. Come rain or shine

Meaning: No matter what happens.

Example: She exercises every morning, come rain or shine.

4. Save for a rainy day

Meaning: Save money for the future or emergencies.

Example: I save part of my salary for a rainy day.

5. Storm in a teacup

Meaning: A big fuss over a small problem.

Example: Their argument was just a storm in a teacup.

6. Steal someone's thunder

Meaning: Take attention from someone else.

Example: He stole my thunder by announcing the news first.

7. Take a rain check

Meaning: Do something another time; postpone politely.

Example: I'm busy today. Can I take a rain check?

8. Break the ice

Meaning: Start a friendly conversation.

Example: He told a joke to break the ice.

9. Snowed under

Meaning: Very busy.

Example: I'm snowed under with homework.

10. Calm before the storm

Meaning: A quiet time before trouble begins.

Example: The silence was the calm before the storm.

11. Weather the storm

Meaning: Survive a difficult time.

Example: Our family weathered the storm together.

12. Head in the clouds

Meaning: Not paying attention; dreamy or unrealistic.

Example: He always has his head in the clouds.

13. Fair-weather friend

Meaning: A friend only in good times.

Example: He disappeared when I needed help—a fair-weather friend.

14. On cloud nine

Meaning: Very happy.

Example: She was on cloud nine after passing the exam.

15. A bolt from the blue

Meaning: A complete surprise.

Example: The news came like a bolt from the blue.

16. Chasing rainbows

Meaning: Trying to achieve something impossible.

Example: He's chasing rainbows with that plan.

17. Be on thin ice

Meaning: Be in a risky situation.

Example: You're on thin ice after missing work again.

18. Throw caution to the wind

Meaning: Take a risk without worrying.

Example: She threw caution to the wind and started her own business.

19. Ride out the storm

Meaning: Endure a difficult period.

Example: We will ride out the storm together.

20. A ray of sunshine

Meaning: A cheerful person or source of hope.

Example: Her smile is a ray of sunshine.

21. Right as rain

Meaning: Feeling completely well or fine.

Example: After a good night's sleep I felt right as rain.

22. Raining cats and dogs

Meaning: Raining very heavily.

Example: We can't go out — it's raining cats and dogs.

23. In the eye of the storm

Meaning: In the centre of a difficult or chaotic situation.

Example: She stayed calm even in the eye of the storm.

24. Cloud on the horizon

Meaning: A sign of possible future trouble.

Example: There is a cloud on the horizon with the new regulations.

25. Weather permitting

Meaning: If the weather is good enough.

Example: We'll have the picnic outside, weather permitting.

26. Blow hot and cold

Meaning: Keep changing one's attitude or opinion.

Example: He blows hot and cold about the project.

27. Get wind of something

Meaning: Hear a rumour or become aware of something secret.

Example: She got wind of the planned changes.

28. Three sheets to the wind

Meaning: Very drunk.

Example: By midnight he was three sheets to the wind.

29. A storm is brewing

Meaning: Trouble is about to start.

Example: You can feel a storm is brewing in the office.

30. Clear the air

Meaning: Remove tension or misunderstanding by talking openly.

Example: We need a meeting to clear the air.

Real-Life Dialogue

Sara: You look a little tired today. Are you **under the weather**?

Michael: A little, but I'll be **right as rain** after some rest.

Sara: I hope so. We're still meeting for dinner tonight, right?

Michael: I'd love to, but I'm completely **snowed under** with work. Can I **take a rain check**?

Sara: Of course. We can go another day.

Michael: Thanks. I've also heard that there's **a storm brewing** at the office.

Sara: Really? What happened?

Michael: The manager **got wind of** some problems with the new project.

Sara: I thought everything was going well.

Michael: So did I. Maybe this is just **the calm before the storm**.

Sara: I hope not. We should probably talk to the team and **clear the air** before things get worse.

Michael: Good idea. We need to **weather the storm** together.

Sara: Definitely. And don't worry—**every cloud has a silver lining**.

Michael: I like your attitude. That's why you're such **a ray of sunshine**.

Sara: Thanks! Now get some rest.

Michael: I will. **Come rain or shine**, I'll be ready for work tomorrow.

— End of Chapter 17 —

CHAPTER 18

Common American & British Idioms

Many idioms are shared across the Atlantic. A smaller set remains strongly regional. This chapter highlights useful differences and shared favorites so you can navigate both varieties with confidence.

Shared Favorites (Used Widely in Both Varieties)

Break the ice, piece of cake, under the weather, cost an arm and a leg, once in a blue moon, speak of the devil, beat around the bush, call it a day, on the same page, bite the bullet, think outside the box, go the extra mile, over the moon, down in the dumps, every cloud has a silver lining, better late than never, in the same boat, learn the ropes, raining cats and dogs, barking up the wrong tree.

More Commonly American

Touch base, circle back, low-hanging fruit, move the needle, get your ducks in a row, hit the books, school of hard knocks, bring home the bacon, a home run, Monday-morning quarterback, drink the Kool-Aid, throw someone under the bus.

Throw someone under the bus

Meaning: To betray or sacrifice someone else, especially to protect oneself or gain advantage.

Short Explanation: Modern American political and corporate slang. The image is of pushing a person into the path of an oncoming bus.

Usage: Strongly critical. Informal. Primarily American, though spreading.

Examples:

- *When the project failed he threw his teammate under the bus.*
- *I won't throw anyone under the bus to save myself.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Colleague: *Management is looking for someone to blame.*

You: *I refuse to throw anyone under the bus. We succeed or fail as a team.*

More Commonly British

A storm in a teacup, chuck a wobbly, knackered, gobsmacked, take the mickey / take the piss, not my cup of tea, a different kettle of fish, Bob's your uncle, keep a stiff upper lip, get on like a house on fire.

A storm in a teacup

Meaning: A lot of unnecessary anger or worry about a matter that is not important.

Short Explanation: British equivalent of the American 'tempest in a teapot'. Small container, exaggerated storm.

Usage: Mildly dismissive. Common in British English.

Examples:

- *The argument was just a storm in a teacup.*
- *Don't worry – it's a storm in a teacup.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Colleague: *Everyone is upset about the new coffee machine.*

Manager: *It's a storm in a teacup. They'll forget by Friday.*

Not my cup of tea

Meaning: Not something I like or am interested in.

Short Explanation: British understatement. Tea is a national symbol; rejecting a particular 'cup' is a polite way to decline.

Usage: Polite and mild. Very British, though understood in American English.

Examples:

- *Horror films are not my cup of tea.*
- *Thanks for the invitation, but camping isn't really my cup of tea.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Friend: *Want to come to the heavy-metal concert?*

You: *Thanks, but that's not my cup of tea. Have fun though.*

Bob's your uncle

Meaning: And there you have it; the simple or final step that completes the process.

Short Explanation: British expression of uncertain origin (possibly political). Used when explaining that something is straightforward.

Usage: Informal and cheerful. Strongly British.

Examples:

- *Just click the button, fill in your details, and Bob's your uncle.*
- *Add the flour, mix, and Bob's your uncle – the batter is ready.*

Real-Life Dialogue:

Learner: *Is the process complicated?*

Instructor: *Not at all. Follow the three steps and Bob's your uncle.*

Useful Cross-Variety Notes

American 'touch base' ≈ British 'have a quick word' or 'catch up'. American 'circle back' ≈ British 'come back to that later'. American 'low-hanging fruit' is understood in British business English but less frequent. British 'knackered' (exhausted) is rarely used by Americans, who prefer 'exhausted', 'wiped out', or 'beat'.

— End of chapter 18 —

CHAPTER 19

Idiom Exercises & Review

Use these exercises to test recognition, understanding, and productive use. An answer key appears at the end of the chapter.

Exercise 1 – Matching

Match each idiom with its meaning.

1. Break the ice
2. Hit the nail on the head
3. Under the weather
4. Cost an arm and a leg
5. Bite the bullet
6. Pull your weight
7. Over the moon
8. A blessing in disguise
9. Make ends meet
10. Learn the ropes
- A. Extremely happy
- B. Something bad that turns out well
- C. Do your fair share of work
- D. Feeling slightly ill
- E. Very expensive
- F. Start a conversation in a tense situation
- G. Face something difficult with courage
- H. Have just enough money for basic needs
- I. Be exactly right
- J. Learn how something works

Exercise 2 – Fill in the Blank

Complete each sentence with an appropriate idiom from the book.

1. We've been working for hours. Let's _____ and continue tomorrow.
2. I was so nervous before the interview that I had _____ in my stomach.
3. The client rejected our first design, so it's _____.
4. She finally _____ and asked her boss for a raise.
5. Don't _____ about the party – it's supposed to be a surprise.
6. After the merger he quickly began to _____.
7. I only see my old classmates _____ these days.
8. The reported problems are just _____ – the real issues go much deeper.

Exercise 3 – Dialogue Completion

Choose the best idiom to complete each short dialogue.

1. A: The presentation is in ten minutes and the projector isn't working.
B: Stay _____ – we'll fix it.
2. A: I can't believe how much the tickets cost.
B: I know. We _____ for them.
3. A: Why did you leave the company so suddenly?
B: I didn't want to _____, so I gave proper notice and offered to help with the transition.

Exercise 4 – Rewrite

Rewrite each sentence using an idiom that has roughly the same meaning.

1. The test was extremely easy.
2. She revealed the secret by accident.
3. We need to start the project.
4. He is extremely happy about the news.
5. They are in the same difficult situation.

Answer Key

Exercise 1: 1-F, 2-I, 3-D, 4-E, 5-G, 6-C, 7-A, 8-B, 9-H, 10-J

Exercise 2 (sample answers): 1. call it a day 2. butterflies 3. back to the drawing board 4. bit the bullet 5. let the cat out of the bag / spill the beans 6. climb the corporate ladder 7. once in a blue moon 8. the tip of the iceberg

Exercise 3 (sample answers): 1. cool as a cucumber 2. paid through the nose / paid an arm and a leg 3. burn bridges

Exercise 4 (sample answers): 1. The test was a piece of cake. 2. She let the cat out of the bag / spilled the beans. 3. We need to get the ball rolling. 4. He is over the moon / on cloud nine. 5. They are in the same boat.

— End of chapter 16 —

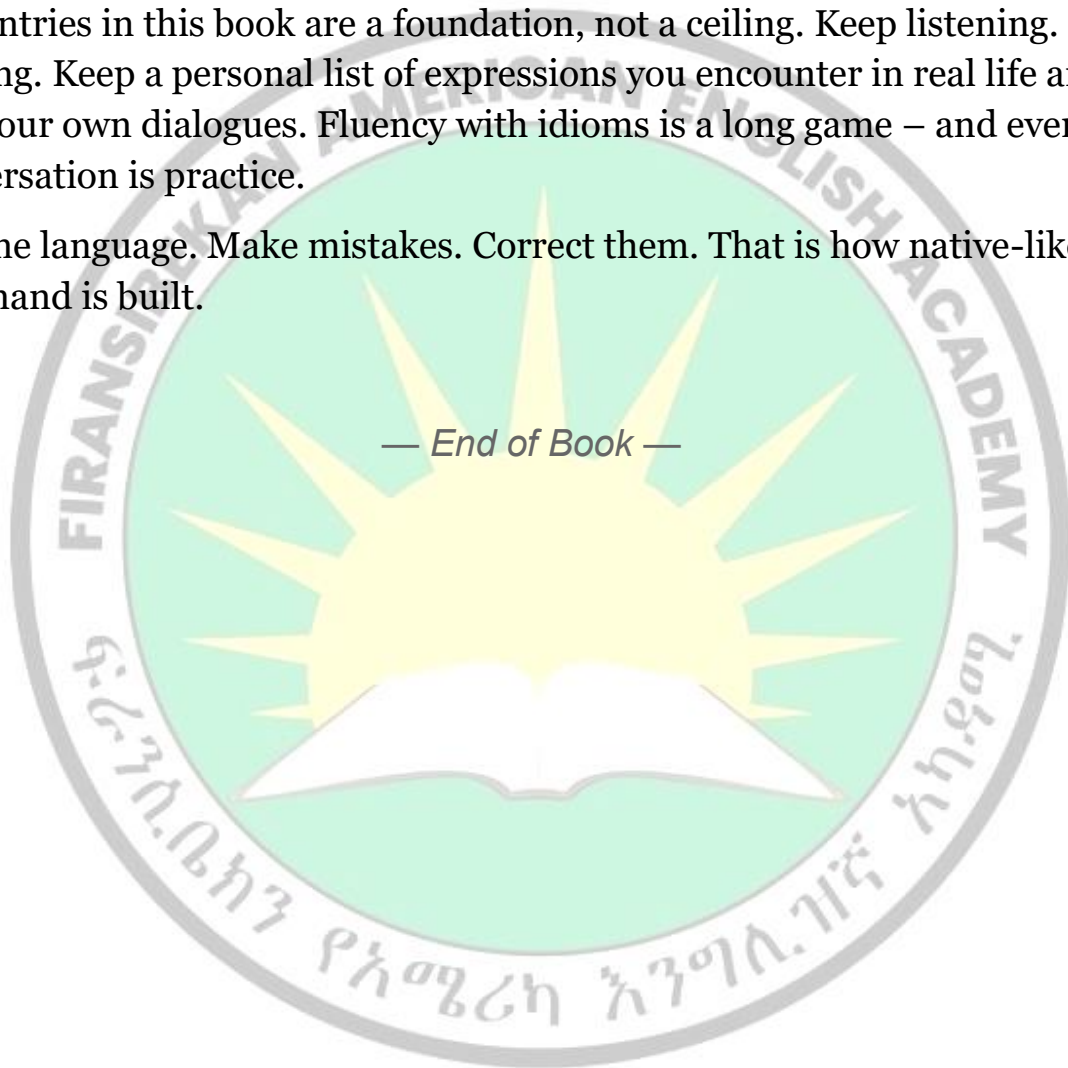
Final Note from the Author

Idioms are not decoration. They are compressed into cultural knowledge. When you use them accurately you signal membership in the speech community; when you understand them you gain access to humor, nuance, and efficiency that pure literal language cannot provide.

The entries in this book are a foundation, not a ceiling. Keep listening. Keep reading. Keep a personal list of expressions you encounter in real life and add your own dialogues. Fluency with idioms is a long game – and every conversation is practice.

Use the language. Make mistakes. Correct them. That is how native-like command is built.

— End of Book —



REFERENCES

Sources & Recommended Further Reading

Primary Dictionaries & Reference Works

- Ammer, C. (2013). *The American Heritage Dictionary of Idioms* (2nd ed.). Houghton Mifflin Harcourt.
- Ayto, J. (2010). *Oxford Dictionary of English Idioms* (3rd ed.). Oxford University Press.
- Cambridge University Press. (n.d.). *Cambridge Dictionary – English Idioms*.
<https://dictionary.cambridge.org>
- Collins. (n.d.). *Collins English Dictionary – Idioms*. <https://www.collinsdictionary.com>
- Longman. (n.d.). *Longman Dictionary of Contemporary English*. Pearson Education.
- Merriam-Webster. (n.d.). *Merriam-Webster Dictionary*. <https://www.merriam-webster.com>
- Oxford University Press. (n.d.). *Oxford Learner's Dictionaries*.
<https://www.oxfordlearnersdictionaries.com>
- Spears, R. A. (2005). *McGraw-Hill's Dictionary of American Idioms and Phrasal Verbs*. McGraw-Hill.

Specialised Idiom Collections

- Brenner, G. (2003). *Webster's New World American Idioms Handbook*. Wiley.
- Flavell, L., & Flavell, R. (2000). *Dictionary of Idioms and Their Origins*. Kyle Cathie.
- Gulland, D. M., & Hinds-Howell, D. (2001). *The Penguin Dictionary of English Idioms* (2nd ed.). Penguin.
- Seidl, J., & McMordie, W. (1988). *English Idioms* (5th ed.). Oxford University Press.
- Siefring, J. (Ed.). (2004). *The Oxford Dictionary of Idioms* (2nd ed.). Oxford University Press.

Academic & Linguistic Resources

- Fernando, C. (1996). *Idioms and Idiomaticity*. Oxford University Press.
- Liu, D. (2008). *Idioms: Description, Comprehension, Acquisition, and Pedagogy*. Routledge.
- Moon, R. (1998). *Fixed Expressions and Idioms in English: A Corpus-Based Approach*. Oxford University Press.
- Wray, A. (2002). *Formulaic Language and the Lexicon*. Cambridge University Press.

Online Corpora & Usage Databases

- British National Corpus (BNC). (n.d.). <http://www.natcorp.ox.ac.uk>
- Corpus of Contemporary American English (COCA). (n.d.). <https://www.english-corpora.org/coca/>
- Google Books Ngram Viewer. (n.d.). <https://books.google.com/ngrams>
- Just The Word. (n.d.). <http://www.just-the-word.com>

Learner-Oriented & Classroom Resources

- McCarthy, M., & O'Dell, F. (2017). *English Idioms in Use (Intermediate & Advanced)*. Cambridge University Press.
- Wright, J. (2002). *Idioms Organiser: Organised by Metaphor, Topic and Key Word*. Language Teaching Publications.
- Watcyn-Jones, P., & Allsop, J. (1990). *Test Your English Idioms*. Penguin.

— End of References —